

SIGRA

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SIGRA

by [Cr0ftisprocrastinating](#)

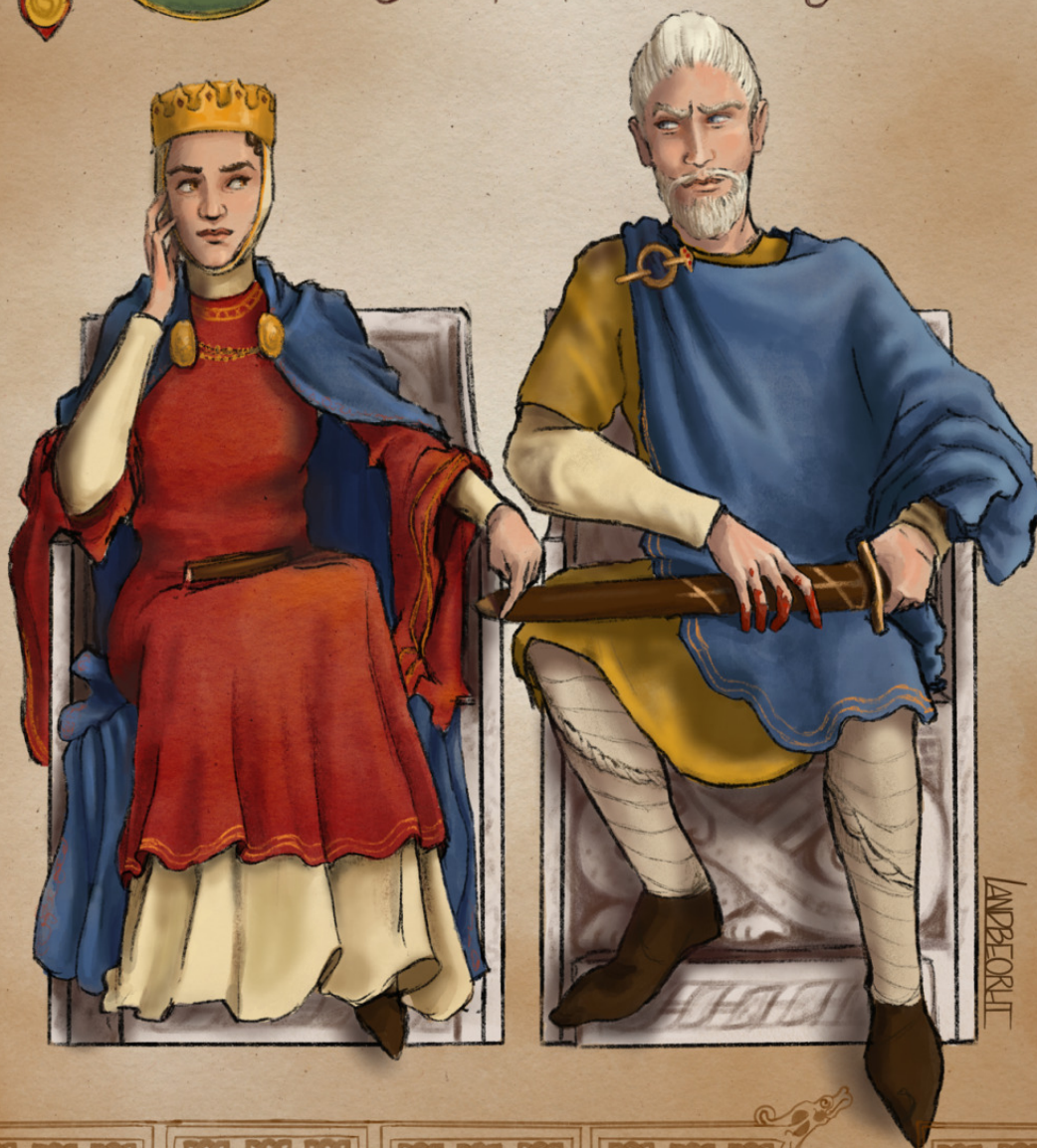
Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

SIGRÁ

by cʀ0ftisprocʀastinating



‘...in the world things go from bad to worse, and so it must of necessity deteriorate greatly on account of the people’s sins before the coming of Antichrist.’

Archbishop Wulfstan of York, 1014

The battle was over, yet my bloodlust was not satiated. It rang through my body as sure as my sword had rung with the dripping insides of my enemies. I wanted to destroy. Devour. To rip this world in two and make it mine. And it was.

I was already being heralded as *konung* . King. No longer merely Prince, they called for me. I grinned, and laughed at the sky, and knew that the quivering excuse of a man in front of me thought I was insane. I could taste it, his fear and revulsion.

I crouched down to look him straight in the eye.

I still could not decide if I would end his life or merely strip it of everything that was important to him.

“You have won,” he said to me in my own language. Perhaps his father taught him. His father, who had managed to resist for so long, and was now dead, too.

“I have.”

“I did not want this war. I did not want to be *konung* .”

“You are not King anymore,” I pointed out, still grinning. Perhaps I would kill him, if he had nothing to suffer through.

“I am not.” He inclined his head in a show of respect. I liked this fallen man, as pathetic as he was. Perhaps I would not kill him.

“You will kill me,” he continued.

“I have not yet decided,” I told him honestly.

“Why not?”

“What matters to you, Edmund,” I asked, my voice curling around his name like it was a curse. He flinched.

“Peace,” he told me, quietly. I laughed again.

“Peace? Is this from your god? Does he call for peace from his magical kingdom in the sky?” I sneered. I had heard enough of this new religion to be curious, but any god that claimed peace was the way to an eternal life held no interest for me. And his god was nowhere now, with the bodies of his men scattered and slaughtered on the field. That was what *peace* got you.

“The kingdom of heaven,” he corrected a bit stiffly. “But no. I want peace for my daughter, so that she may live a life free from conflict.”

That got my attention. A daughter. I took him in.

“Take me to her.”

He realised what he had done, and panicked.

“I beg you-”

“Is she a child?”

“She does not -”

“Is she a child?” I demanded, sizing up his age.

“No,” he admitted. “She is a woman.”

“Married?”

I sweetened my demand with the tip of my knife, raising his chin so he was forced to look me in the eye.

“She is not.”

“You will take me to her, and if she pleases me, you will have your peace.” And if she didn’t please me, then I’d fuck her anyway, and cast them both out.

His fear was back. I had missed it.

It didn’t take long to ready my men. We were to ride into the Hall of the fallen King Edmund, and feast our victory. I did not tell them of the daughter, but I let them know that there would be no violence. Not now the hall was mine.

They understood. They feasted on flesh on the battlefield, but by the time the fighting was over they were hungry for other things. Other kinds of flesh. Other kinds of futures. I saw it, then. As we galloped over the landscape, once foreign, now mine. A hunger for something rooted. Perhaps it was even for peace.

It had been years of fighting. Years of skirmishes, of conquering and losing. Years of me, taking back what my father had lost. I let myself think of his cold face, what he might have done or said if he discovered that his son was now more powerful than he had ever been. That his son had conquered the English, and succeeded where he couldn’t.

Inn riki , they called around me, *The Great* .

I laughed at the sky again, and saw the ravens already gathering on the horizon, ready to welcome me to my new home.

They hid from me, my new subjects. Their faces were scared and shaded as we galloped through. The gold and silver on my helm glinted, the noise my weapons made as they clinked against each other rattled out a new beginning. And Edmund, the fallen king, rode behind me in chains.

There was crying, perhaps. But there were no alarms. Someone had already told them we were coming.

The Hall was being readied for us. It was big, strong. I approved, even if these English made no sense to me, with their buildings of wood yet their churches of stone. Embroidered hangings decorated the walls, the firelight glinting off them. I eyed them appreciatively. I knew well the wealth this Isle held. And now it was mine.

I sat on the throne and stared at him.

“Bring her.”

“I beg -”

“I do not care,” I told him. He wasn’t the one who’s begging I was interested in. “Bring her.”

I sent two of my men to go with him, should he try anything stupid, like convincing his precious daughter to run. And then I waited for my prize.

I heard her before I saw her. Her feet were scuffling. She was shouting, not in any language I knew, but she was resisting. I liked that about her.

I was smiling when she was pulled through the doorway. She squinted for a bit, her eyes adjusting to the change in light, the tall fire in the centre obscuring her entirely until she was pulled around it, in front of me. My men had a hand on each of her arms, and I assessed their grips. My eyes narrowed, and they loosened quickly. Her father was hovering behind her, but I just stared.

She was slim, not dressed like any daughter of a king I knew would have been. Her dress was simple and plain, tightened with only the most basic belt. A string of wooden beads were strung from it. Her head coverings were again simple and plain, some rough woven thing, not fine linens, silks or even a decently spun wool. Had we bled this green and rich place dry already? Did they prefer to decorate their halls with their riches rather than their women? I vowed I would enforce splendour on her as soon as I could. I wanted to see her in gold, in jewels, in the finest of linen shifts so I could see the peak of her nipples as she moved around our bedchamber.

Her eyes were huge and brown, warm and reflecting the light in ways that made my trousers tighten. Her gaze flickered all over the hall, frantically, and I was reminded of a sparrow, right before his breast was spilled open. She felt like that frightened bird, and I wanted her. I wanted her immediately.

I waited for her gaze to fall on me, once she had realised there was no way out. And when it did, I was not disappointed.

She did not hide. She glared. Here, at least, she was a princess. In her bearing, in her manner. She looked at me as though I were a subject, and I grinned wolfishly back. She didn’t even flinch in the face of my desire, in the face of the blood drying all over me. I still had not washed, and I was glad of it. I wanted her to see me, to know. I wanted her father to know that I had conquered him in every way that mattered. I could not say what it was specifically that made my blood sing with a certainty that I would have her. But I wanted to hold her soft and supple body underneath me, and taste her. Make her mine.

“Wife,” I greeted her, and at this, she fell to the ground, begging her father in that same language. Watching her beg - I did like. She was pretty on her knees.

“Does she not speak the language of her people,” I asked in my own language, frustration sharpening the syllables. It wasn’t the end of the world, of course, but it would be annoying, especially if she refused to learn.

“She does,” her father reassured me, clearly relieved now that I had made my desire clear. Perhaps he knew, too, that as my wife she would be queen. Perhaps he hoped for more than peace. If he did not die soon, I would make sure he did. “She is speaking the language of the Church.”

Ah. This church again. I snorted.

“I have no interest in priest-speak,” I told him, and he murmured something to her as she cried harder. “Is she too stupid to learn her own tongue?”

This got her, as I hoped it would. Her tears dried almost immediately, and she turned to me, still on the floor, the dirt darkening the knees of her hideous dress.

“I am not stupid, nor am I your wife,” she spat in *my* own tongue. Concern morphed into pleasure. She was clever, my wife.

“You will be,” I told her instead.

“No.”

“Hermione,” her father murmured to her, and I smiled wider at her name. “You must. This is for peace. For a future without this senseless violence.”

“You promised me,” she sobbed. “You promised me I would not marry. You promised me I could dedicate my life to God,”

This was interesting. My new wife was one of them, a defender of the new faith. I considered her prone figure. A plan started to take root in my head.

“Your father promised a great many things,” I murmured, though I knew she would hear me, “and now he is defeated, and his word is nothing. I am your king now, sparrow. And you are mine.”

A shiver ran through her at my words.

“We marry tonight,” I announced to the room, and the flurry of activity increased in fervour.

“Tonight? There is not enough time - we have customs -”

“We marry tonight, with my customs,” I said the words directly to her, though her father had been the one to question me, and I watched her eyes widen as she understood what kind of *customs* I might have, “and when I am crowned, then we will marry again with yours,” I said with a cold smile, and she blanched, before straightening her spine. My wedding gift to her - a concession. Not something I did often. Or ever.

“No,” she said.

“It happens tonight,” I told her calmly. “Or I will gut every man, woman and child of your people. And afterwards, I will take you anyway.”

True fear edged her gaze. I didn't bother to hide the fact that I loved it. But she did not back down. My sparrow was strong. I couldn't wait to see just how strong she might be.

I had intended to spend the evening feasting with my men, sharing in stories from the battle and listening to their crowing and conquering. But after the ceremony was complete, the only thing I had any appetite for was her.

I could still hear them, their voices in the night. But their stories were dimmed in front of the soft crackle of the fire, and the woman standing in front of me.

She hadn't changed - of course she hadn't. I almost liked that she had refused to wear something new for me. I might throw this dress of hers into the fire and burn it tonight, once I got it off her.

She was trembling and trying not to, and I handed her wine.

"Drink."

"Why?"

"Are you always this argumentative?"

"Are you always this demanding?"

"Yes," I told her, moving towards her, and tipping her chin up with my finger. I towered over her, but I only allowed myself to hold her with that one finger. This was the kind of chase that I wanted, that I craved. And I knew that it would make her eventual submission all the sweeter.

"Then I am always this argumentative," she snapped back. I chuckled, and her expression darkened. I knew she did not want to please me.

I turned from her, throwing another log on the fire and then moved around the room, stripping off my tunic until I was before her again, almost naked. Her eyes widened as she took in the size of me. I knew I was strong. I knew I was desired. I knew that even though she hated herself for it, she couldn't help the awareness of my naked body. She tried to speak.

"Never seen a naked man before," I teased, and her cheeks flushed darker.

"I was promised to the Church," she muttered again, turning away from me. She drank, however. I smirked and sat on the bed, digging my fingers into the blankets and furs underneath me. I knew this place was rich, I had been waging war against it for the past however many years it had been. But even the smallest reminders of it pleased me.

"Tell me about it," I commanded.

“About what?” She snapped, her eyes darting to me and then away again. She was holding herself tightly, arms wrapped around her upper body, angling herself away from me. I held out the bottle. After a moment she extended her arm stiffly out, allowing me to refill her glass.

She did not stay, of course, once I had. But perhaps if she was one of these Christians she would not be used to drinking, and that would work in my favour. The wine was strong, after all, and good, much better quality than the normal ale or mead myself and my soldiers drank.

“Your promise. Why are you going to the Church, when you could help your father.”

“I can help him in the Church.”

“Not in this lifetime,” I reminded her.

“An eternity compared to brief suffering is worth it.”

“What would you do, then,” I said, bored already. “In this Church. You would make sacrifices?”

“No,” she recoiled. “No. We don’t do that. The priests are all men, anyway.”

I stared at her, confused. She did not seem to be the type to want to be second best.

“So what do the women do,” I asked.

“They have houses. Great places of learning where they read and write and spread the word of God. Where they spend their days in quiet contemplation, making music or medicine. Peace.” She insisted. I considered this. Powerful communities of women didn’t sound like peace, but there was no denying the longing that bled into her words when she mentioned reading and writing.

“You are already learned,” I guessed.

“There is much I don’t know,” she said with a shrug, a slightly arrogant one at that. The wine was loosening her tongue and her body language, and I wanted more.

“Then I will make you a deal.”

I was not particularly interested in extending this discussion to the rest of her new church. I had found what she wanted. And now I was going to use it against her. Both her and her father were far too open.

“I’m not interested in making deals with devils,” she hissed, and I threw my head back and laughed.

“You have no choice, little one,” I sat forward, making sure she knew exactly what my intentions were. The scent of her fear started to fill the room. “For every night you come to my bed willingly, I will give you something for your church.”

She paused, her eyes flickering over my body again.

“Bribing me does not sound particularly willing.”

“It is willing enough for me,” I told her, let a little bit of the wolf out in my eyes. The dragon. She shivered.

“I don’t know.”

“You do,” I told her, standing and moving towards her. She was rooted to the spot. “You are scared to say yes,” I trailed a finger down her cheek, “but you want to,” I whispered. She blinked up at me.

Before she could reply, I stepped back, watching the confusion filter through. Push and pull. Back and forth.

“Take off your veil,” I told her roughly, before she could argue. And then - thank the Gods - her shaking hands placed the wine cup on the low table, and started to remove the pins that held her hideous head coverings in place.

I sat, watching her, listening to the plink of the iron pins as they fell on the wood, waiting and hardly breathing as she lifted the veil off. And then repeated the movements for the one underneath, this one at least made of a finer, lighter material than the heavy wool covering. I nearly moaned in impatience. There was no hiding my arousal, not with my shirt off, and there was a part of me that wondered if she was doing it on purpose,

All other thoughts filed out of my mind however when her hair tumbled forward. Her shaking hands undid the thick braids, but all I could hear was the roaring in my blood.

It was long, tangled, curling around her like a wild thing. My cock throbbed when I thought about what it would look like, spilled out around her head as she writhed underneath me.

“The dress,” I rasped, managing to drag my eyes downwards. “Take it off.”

There was another pause, and I waited for her to say no. Stared at her, at those beautiful brown eyes that were filled with resentment and determination.

“I want you to rebuild the churches you destroyed,” she said. Commanded. Little sparrow.

“One for every night,” I told her.

“That’s just one -”

“One church. One night,” I bit out. “And then, when they are all complete, you will have the option to leave me and hide away in whichever one you choose.”

She froze at that. It was a risk, of course. But I had waged destruction up and down this land, and I knew how many places were lying in ruins. I had enough time to convince her to stay by my side.

“I accept,” she said, and then her little hands removed her belt and it slid to the floor. The dress followed, but there was no shift that I understood underneath it.

“What is that,” I asked, wanting to turn my nose up at the hideous brown covering.

“My undershirt,” she replied. There was something in her voice that made me focus on it.

I came closer to her, crowding her again. And that was when I realised.

“You’re protesting,” I said. The hair shirt must have been a fight against our marriage.

“I wear it every day,” she replied coolly. “So no. Not everything is about you, *prince* .”

My hand gripped her shoulder, rubbing that coarse fabric into her skin, pinching her. It itched to hold her neck.

“Call me King, or nothing at all,” I hissed to her. She smirked, despite the fact that I must be hurting her. I yanked the shift over her, and I wished I was in control enough to take pleasure in her gasp.

But when it was off - my anger was edged with lust. I stepped back so I might see her. All of her.

The firelight gilded the edges of her body. Too slim, probably denying herself more because of that misguided idea of faith. Her flesh was not clean. It was marked. Covered. Red scratches all over. I tossed the shift to the floor. My desire at seeing her marked was at war with my anger that she had done this to herself. I wanted to be the one who made her red.

“Don’t wear that again.”

“I won’t obey you,” she told me, cocking her naked hip. I liked that she seemed to be unbothered by her nudity.

“I’ll kill your father.”

There was a pause, and then she laughed. It was high and stressed and sounded like flickering wings in the space.

“You’ll kill him because of a shift?”

“I’ve killed for less, sparrow,” I told her, holding her gaze so that she might see what I was. So that she might know exactly what kind of man I could be. She swallowed, her throat bobbing.

“Please,” she tried, softening her voice. I snorted, hiding the fact that yes, I probably would succumb if she begged me. Particularly on her knees.

“No.”

“It’s just a piece of clothing,” she stepped forwards, brave girl. And then I sat back down, so that my mouth was at her navel. The skin was torn in different places, in various stages of healing. She hadn’t been lying about wearing it every day. And then I ran my tongue against her skin.

She squeaked, and tried to jump back but my arm was already there, holding her still, my fingers digging into her waist. She would not escape me any longer.

I could taste her, the mild tang of sweat, the iron of her blood, the sweet scent of her skin that made me want to dip my head lower and take more.

“You belong to me now, Hermione,” I told her. “And you will not wear it any longer.”

“What does it matter,” she asked, quietly. Her entire body was so tense I could feel her desire to bolt.

“Because I will be the only one who leaves marks on you,” I told her, looking up at her. She was glorious, red and scraped and her hair tumbling over her shoulders. I took one of her nipples into

my mouth and sucked, watching her. She cried out, as I tongued it gently. Another reason why I hated the shirt. I could not be as rough with her as I wanted.

I let her nipple go.

“How it must ache,” I murmured, running my other hand along the outside of her thigh. “Every day. Feeling these rub against that coarse shirt whenever you move,” my cock was throbbing at the thought, and I leaned over to lick the other nipple. A shudder ran through her once more, her gaze growing heavier. “Do you like it, little wife? Do you like the pain? Does it turn you on? Does it make you ache everywhere?”

Her breathing was coming heavier, and I skated my hand in between her thighs, brushing lightly against her hair there. She jerked in surprise, as though she had remembered that she was not supposed to want such things, and tried to pull away. This time, I let her, grinning up at her closed expression.

“You should not speak like that.”

“Why? Does your god seek to deny you every pleasure?” I cocked my head, and she looked around, trying to search for something to cover her, no doubt.

“It doesn’t matter,” she muttered, suddenly unsteady and confused.

“Sit between my legs.”

She stiffened.

“No.”

“Not even for your churches? Not even for your peace? Your faith? Your chance at a quiet life? I am not stupid, sparrow. I know what you want.”

She gazed at me, hatred there, and I smiled. When she relented I kept my crowing to myself, however, and reached over to where my belt hung, removing the comb from it.

“What are you doing,” she hissed. Her shoulders were worse-marked than her front, great sores all over.

“Combing your hair,” I told her, mildly, as though this is what I wanted to spend my evening doing. But she was unwilling to let herself enjoy my touches, and so I would tease her until she had no choice but to give in to me.

We sat in silence for a while, as I ran the comb through it. Her hair was curling, knotty, badly looked after. Had she denied herself this, too? Thoughts of her own neglect filled me with an uncharacteristic tenderness. I knew I wanted her. But the lengths I was going to make her comfortable were surprising me.

I could feel it working, though. She continued to sip on her wine, as my hands ran through her strands, massaging her head, distracting from the tugging of the teeth. Thoughts of doing this for her every night suddenly filled my mind.

“Stand up,” I told her, and she obeyed me. “Good,” I praised, my hands going to her hips to stop her from turning around. Knowing it would shock her, I ran my tongue lightly down the cleft of her

arse, chuckling against her skin at her gasp, and sliding one of my hands in between her legs. Cupping her.

“Don’t,” she said, seizing up again. But I was done listening to her words. Not when I could feel the heat and wetness of her body.

“Oh, little sparrow,” I murmured. “I know you don’t mean that.” I ran my finger along her slit, gathering some of the wetness that gathered there. “I know you want this. That you desire this.”

“I don’t,” she said weakly, as I lazily and lightly circled my finger around that small bead of pleasure in between her thighs. “I -” she broke off with a gasp.

“Good girl,” I told her, pushing her forward so I could stand behind her. When the length of my cock pressed against where my mouth had been, she gasped again. “I want you to turn around, and take my trousers off. And then, you are going to get on your knees, and take my cock in your mouth. Do you understand?”

I ran my hands up her, cupping both her breasts this time, toying gently with her nipples once more. They were perfect, and I couldn’t wait till she healed so that I might bite her myself, cover her in marks so that everyone would know who she belonged to. Remove any evidence that it had ever been anything other than me. She didn’t move.

“I asked you a question,” I said silkily, running my tongue along the cord of her neck. I still had not kissed her, but the taste of her skin was good enough to make me want to.

“I don’t want to,” she gritted out.

“Then I will burn every Christian in this land. I will ensure that no *church* is ever rebuilt. I will raze this new faith to the ground. And I will do it in your name.”

I could taste her pulse under my tongue.

“You would be resisted,” she tried, still trying. Little bird. She had no idea how trapped she was.

“I *crave* bloodshed. Did you know that, wife? I grew up knowing I would be the greatest warrior my people had ever known. I expected to raid and pillage and bring glory to my family name since before I was big enough to hold a weapon. It is in my blood. And there is only one thing I want more than that, that can stop me from tearing this place apart.”

She trembled in my arms, her head tipping back slightly as I continued to press wet kisses along her neck and circle her nipples with the tips of my fingers.

“What?” She breathed. And I smiled against her, knowing that I had won.

“Your pretty mouth, wrapped round my cock. You underneath me, begging for it. Your cunt, tightening as you come.”

I let the words sink in, waited for her to tense, which she did. And then I removed my hands, pushing her slightly forward, and waiting for her to do what I’d told her.

Watching my new wife obey me made me almost come right there and then. Her trembling fingers rising up to my laces as she sank to her knees nearly undid me. But I was a patient man. And the

sight of her, her pretty face sitting underneath my cock, the wide eyed expression of shock that she wore, was something I was going to remember forever.

I put my hand on her jaw, squeezing slightly so that she opened. I know that she had no idea what to do, but I also knew that I didn't trust her enough to fully let her have her mouth around me when she would be tempted to bite.

I guided my cock to her lips.

"I don't know what to do," she muttered quickly, and I grinned.

"Kiss it," I demanded. Her eyes flicked to mine briefly, before she pressed a chaste kiss to the tip of my cock. My breath huffed out at the feeling of her lips on me. "Good. Now, open."

She did, and I slowly slid inside her.

Fuck. The feeling of her mouth, so wet and warm and welcoming made me moan. I was still half bent over, ensuring her jaw was loose, but I wanted to thrust into her, to take her throat, to make her gag on me, to spill my seed all over her.

"Yes," I hissed. "Suck."

She did, hollowing her cheeks and pulling me into her mouth. I moved my other hand to the back of her head, pushing slightly, making her take more of me in.

She was so clearly inexperienced it was going to undo me. Just the sight of her, her brow furrowing as she tried to take me was enough to get me moaning. I continued, deepening my thrusts until I hit the back of her throat, and then I held her there. Her eyes widened, looking up at me as she struggled. It was only half in, and I knew she was scared for what was coming next.

I continued to fuck her mouth until I couldn't, and then I pushed her off, both of us panting, her still trembling.

"Was that -"

Gods above. She wanted to know if it had been good. If she had done well. It was then that I knew, really knew, that she was mine. Even if she didn't realise it yet.

"Get on the bed," I told her. "On your hands and knees."

She stood awkwardly, unsteadily, and the flush all over her belied her innocence. She was terrified. But I knew how to make this good for her. How to ensure that no matter how long she had to lie to herself, and tell herself that this was a sacrifice for the good of her church, that this was something she needed. Craved. And for this first time, I needed her to submit to me, utterly.

I ran a hand over her back, watching her jerk every time my calloused hands hit a particularly raw scrape.

"Beautiful," I murmured, and she tensed even further at that. "Do you not believe me, wife?" I asked. She didn't answer. My hand cracked as I slapped her arse.

"Answer me," I demanded.

“I - I don’t know,” she admitted, her voice small.

This would not do at all.

“You are,” I said, as I positioned myself behind her. “You are so beautiful. I had to stop myself so many times from coming down your pretty throat,” I ran my hand along her slit, circling my finger until I pushed inwards, shallowly thrusting and widening, readying her for me.

“Why did you,” she managed to gasp out, as my finger curled inside her, brushing against that sensitive and swollen bundle of nerves that I knew would drive her crazy.

“Because there’s only one place I’m going to come tonight, Hermione,” I said. “Do you know where that is?”

“I - in me?”

She was so nervous, her shoulders tight. But her breaths were coming faster, as though she was trying hard to resist making any more noises of pleasure. I continued circling her little bead, at the same time massaging her from the inside.

“In you,” I repeated. “Right in this sweet pussy. You feel so good around my fingers. I can’t wait to feel you clench around my cock.”

“Stop,” she begged, but then she was tightening around my fingers, gasping.

“Have you ever felt like this before?” I demanded. “Have you ever touched yourself? Do you know what I am doing to you, little sparrow?”

“No - I -” she broke off as she cried out, her arms collapsing underneath her, her entire body shuddering and clenching around me. I slowed my fingers, breathing hard at the sight of her letting go, my own hips wanting to thrust into air. I had waited long enough.

My arms bracketed her, lifting her back into position as she continued to make small sounds of pleasure. I lined myself up, and then pushed.

She cried out again, tight even after she had come. So wet. So good.

“Fuck,” I gasped, stilling myself, forcing myself not to move yet because then it would be over far too soon.

“Oh, God,” she cried out, her small body still trembling.

“He cannot hear you,” I told her, running my hands over her back, admiring how they looked on her. How much she already looked like she was mine. “Not now.” I pressed a kiss against her neck, my hands moving to hold her neck in place. She looked perfect. And then, I started to move.

Every thrust was perfection, every sound she made, her small moans, her hard breathing, her loud cries when I repositioned her and managed to go even deeper. My perfect little sparrow. My queen.

“You’re mine now, Hermione,” I kept telling her, over and over again. Kept wanting her to know that she would never escape.

“I’m going to have you every night. Every morning. Until you bear me as many sons as you can, until you cannot even think of disappearing because you’ll miss this cock too much. *Mine* .”

I came with a roar, collapsing on top of her as she continued to twitch underneath me. For a moment I just lay there, enjoying the feeling of her, the slick of sweat that lay between our bodies, the hair that had managed to make its way into my mouth. I chuckled, and shifted to move off her, still holding her close.

“I should go,” she said quietly.

“Go?”

“To...to my rooms. To sleep?”

“You sleep with me,” I told her, infuriated that she might think she would be able to escape me. That even after that, she wanted to. I turned her, not letting her hide, and finally pressed my lips against hers. My tongue ran along the seam of hers until she opened for me, and then I explored her mouth as thoroughly as I had explored her cunt. She tasted like wine and pleasure and I was half-drunk on it myself.

“No separate beds, little sparrow,” I pulled back eventually, still breathing hard. “No hair shirts. No shitty clothes either.”

“Draco -”

“No,” I kissed her again. Blood covered both of us, smeared on her thighs and on my cock, better than any battlefield prize. I didn’t give a shit that this wasn’t part of the bargain. She was my wife, now. Queen. And she would remain at my side.

Chapter End Notes

A note on historical accuracy:

This is loosely (read: very loosely) (I cannot emphasise enough just how loosely) inspired by the marriage of convenience between Cnut and Emma of Normandy, when Cnut successfully invaded England in 1016 and defeated Edmund at the Battle of Assunden, in October of that year.

Edmund Ironside, the man who Cnut defeated, actually had two sons, not a daughter. Queen Emma was the previous queen of Æthelred the ‘Unready’, Edmund’s father, and she and Cnut married in 1017 (he also had an earlier wife, who was passed over in favour of the more politically advantageous Emma). Emma herself had already been married before, and also had a son at the time of her marriage to Cnut.

Cnut did convert to Christianity and became a generous patron of the religion during his lifetime. Emma was also an active participant in royal life even after the death of Cnut, continuing to be involved in politics during the reign of her sons.

An idea of a cohesive 'England' or sense of 'Englishness' from this time probably did exist. In the 9th century, the landmass was made up of multiple kingdoms (the Saxons, the Northumbrians) who were individually ruled. However, in 927 Æthelstan was the first to control the entire area, and styled himself as 'king of the English' on coins and charters.

The opening quote by Wulfstan of York comes from his famous homily 'Sermo Lupi ad Anglos', or 'Sermon of the Wolf to the English', where he claims the Viking attacks are God's punishment to the English for their lax ways.

'Sigra' means to defeat, or to conquer in Old Norse.

I wrote this for the magnificent [midnighttomoscow](#), because what says happy birthday more than dirty filthy smut!

If you wanna read what others created for this auspicious occasion then you can!

[Consolation prize by toofadedtofight](#)

[It's Midnight Somewhere by diplobeanz](#)

[Planting Seeds by ChelsieWhitlock](#)

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Generously given permission to expand by the glorious MidnightforMoscow, who this was for. Equally generously beta'd by Bremonster. They both currently have new works- go go read!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

I spent the next day in bed with her, my wife, this strange little sparrow. There was much to do - too much. And yet, I could not find the desire to leave her. At one point I thought I ought to, to let her rest, and horror at this strange sort of care made me take her again. She was sore. I called for a bath afterwards, and left her to be attended to by her own maid, a woman who looked at me as though I were one of these devils they talked of.

There was no peace for me in the Hall - I found the jeers of my men irritating. It was late, time for the evening meal, and the fires were roaring and mead was flowing, the celebrations of my union continuing even without my presence. I should have sat and shared a plate, or returned to my bride, yet neither felt right. I went to train instead, seeking that ache in my muscles that would distract from the scratching underneath my skin.

I returned to her hours later when she was bundled under the furs already, the bath water still next to the fire. I dipped a finger in as I watched her, so small on our bed, her breath steady and quick, even in rest. The water was not too chilled so I stripped off, sliding underneath the surface as silently as I could. I was capable of being quiet, this skill thus far only having been used to take things. To steal from my enemies - belongings, jewels. Lives. Strange to be at the other end, to try to keep her asleep. I kept my eyes on her as I washed slowly, ignoring my thickening cock. I was disgusted with myself for the tenderness, and weighed waking her so that I might use her. I slid in next to her, gathering her to me, and then I remembered nothing more as I slipped into slumber, her hair tickling my chest, our scents already the same.

When I woke she was still there, though the bed clothes had been thrown back, tangled and sweaty. She had turned in the night, her little nose pressed against my chest, my leg thrown over both of hers, keeping her against me. I turned her onto her back, she slept still. I must have worn her out the day before. That same uneasy humming filled me, and I opened her legs, looking at her.

She was red and puffy. I stared down at her, wanting, not wanting. Her scent rose to me, and then her body tensed, my sparrow awakening.

“My lord,” she said, syllables still sleep-soaked and easy.

I did not want to hear her speak, and so I bent my head, kissing her round bud lightly. She gasped, and I continued, wetting my lips so they might be softened, running my hands along the inside of her thighs softly, licking her as soft as I dared, even holding back from pressing my own beard fully against her, soft, soft, soft. Though the beast inside me rebelled at such tender conduct, I could not bring myself to change.

She was hesitant, and I knew I had much to do to convince her to allow herself to want me. To let herself sink into this desire and join me, to keep her legs as open as I wished them to be. I wanted her free from her own imagined shackles, I wanted her full with my seed and my heirs, I wanted to keep her in my bed, take her on my lap, have her as relentless as I was with my desires.

She began to move against me, her body slackening in my onslaught, and that was a reward that I drank greedily, lapping at her more, letting her begin to seek her pleasure and thrust against my mouth. She was silent, her breath coming heavy, I wanted her screaming. I was contemplating sliding a finger into her wet heat, testing to see how she would be able to take me, when she stiffened, her legs clamping around me holding me in place, the only audible acknowledgement of her orgasm a gentle mew that she was unable to keep quiet.

I rose once her shuddering stopped and legs untangled themselves, though in truth I missed the pressure of them against me, missed the clear indication that she wanted me there, that she was seeking something only I could give her. I was not ignorant of the way her eyes went to my cock, which was thick and red, beaded with dew already, desperate again to be buried in her. Her eyes were wide and a little afraid, as my sparrow was of me.

I had enjoyed her fear the day before. I was not sure why this was different.

I got off the bed abruptly, turning away from her to the chest at the side of the room, yanking out a fresh shift. I had washed the day before silently so as not to wake her, I had held her throughout the night. My men would not expect me to return to them yet, but if I stayed in the room I was anxious the humming within me would increase. Even her bearing - pliant, mewling, seeking me this morning - was a world away from the day before, from the day before that.

"I will send a compress to ease your aches," I said on my way out of the room. I did not wait to hear her response.

The servant I caught on the way to the stables was one of the English by the way she skittered away from me. When she nodded her acceptance of my order I contemplated briefly taking her - it would certainly soothe my suffering, but as soon as the thought had entered my head I discarded it.

That angered me too. I should not be so soon bewitched by my wife, especially as I took her to humiliate her father and break her spirit. I was supposed to be in control, and yet I did not feel it. I tried to force interest, though my thoughts quickly turned. Instead I began to think about the woman attending my wife. How she would enter my chamber to see her spread out as I had left her, legs open and cunt glistening, her chest heaving still, her head tossed back and curls strewn across the pillows. How the woman would approach her, applying the compress, making my wife gasp, the two of them entangling on the bed, her lips skimming over the same tracks mine had left only minutes before...

I stalked off to find somewhere private, before I vowed I would spend the day on horseback, getting to know the land that was now mine.

Hours later I returned, still unsatisfied. The smell of the air was on my tunic, the feel of the wind in my hair. Usually these things pleased me.

I had also not found anywhere private - this godsforsaken castle being hardly more than a hovel - and I had ridden too hard and now my mare was limping. My men were hungover and miserable, the rest of the inhabitants of the place hostile and furious. There were far too many hooded individuals turning their backs on me, and I knew I had to do something, soon. I could not bury myself in my new bride, which was just as well.

I was not used to lying to myself. I was not used to wanting things I did not know how to take.

The weather was turning, a bite in the air that indicated soon winter would be here. There was so much that I needed to arrange, the least of which being a new wardrobe for my wife, who was intent on dressing like one of the peasants in the field, and who likely would happily freeze to death if it meant she met her God sooner. I had not thought about whether she had eaten either. That thought interrupted my string of worries with yet another worry. Would she refuse? I might force her, might feed her from my own hand (the thought was distracting), but then what? I could not attend her day and night, I could not spend my days concerned over her bodily functions, I could not sink further into this cunt-madness that had seized me.

She was not in our room when I re-entered, which angered me further, though I had given her no instruction to stay. A small basin had been filled with clear water to wash, the fire was banked. The bed had been re-made. There was no lingering scent of us on the air. The mirror propped against the wall had been shined and my reflection glowered back at me. I washed quickly. Though I was not often alone, this I insisted on doing myself. My father taught me never to allow another man near my throat. I was sure of that much of his limited wisdom, tidied up the line of my beard with my knife.

It was only after I had finished that I realised I was primping like some gods-turned woman.

The basin clattered to the floor, water seeping into the rugs, the pottery shattered. It looked old and fine. I hoped it had been precious to someone.

“My lord?”

“Where is she?”

The man shrunk back, and it took everything in me not to throw him against the walls.

“Where -”

“The chapel, my lord,” he stuttered, before I could finish my sentence. I turned my eyes from the broken bowl to him. Godwin - one of the many defeated English. He had spent the day showing me the fields, telling me of the yields of this land, telling me where else I might be more comfortable. Larger abodes, further inland. It was too close to the coast here to be truly safe, he had said. Godwin was a survivor. He would be useful.

At this moment, I wanted to kill him.

“Show me.”

I followed him instead through the warren of rooms that made up this place.

It was my black mood that made it ugly and small. In reality it was warm and well-appointed. The sheep here were plentiful, and there were markers of this everywhere. Thick tapestries hung from nearly every wall. Brightly coloured cushions and tightly woven rugs kept surfaces soft and comfortable. Sweet-scented herbs were strewn liberally about, the filth from the shared garderobe's unable to be smelt on the winds no matter which way they blew. Yet as I followed Godwin out into the bailey and off towards the smaller shelter in the heart of the Keep, I wanted to burn the place down.

"She is within," he said, hovering in the doorway. I stared up at it, its triangular roof piercing the fading light of the sky. There was chanting, though I could not make out her voice. Godwin fidgeted next to me. I wondered if he wanted to be with them, then I found I did not care.

"Wait here," I ordered. "When the singing stops, send her to me."

I walked away as though I had always intended to be dragged throughout the keep, only to turn back when the thought of disturbing my wife made that odd displeasure launch in my chest once more.

I was tiring of my new self. For the second time that day I walked through the gates, out into the training pits to see who might fall underneath my sword, practice or no.

She beat me back to the rooms, my little sparrow. I entered to find her standing there in an undyed gown, hair covered again by that hideous veil, hands twisting underneath her overlong sleeves as she stood before the fire. She turned as I entered and gasped at my appearance. I had finally forgotten the time and indulged more than I ought to have. One eye was blackening, and my knuckles were split on both hands. My back and arse were stiff, my ribs sore with hits from the back of the blade. I had no doubt under my jerkin would be dark purple bruising, and I was looking forward to inspecting them. I had also not bothered to change, engaging in fights in my woven red tunic, trimmed with silver silk. It had been ripped along my shoulder. Mud covered one arm, sweat stained the pits even through my undershirt.

"Sparrow," I said, tugging off the tunic and undershirt and dropping it at her feet. "I thought I told you no more shit dresses."

"I have no others," she said, trying not to stare at my chest, and failing. I glanced down.

"They look worse than they are," I said, satisfied at the markings.

"What happened," she asked, flatly.

"Practice," I replied, turning away from her, feeling her eyes on my back as I strode over to the basin. It had been replaced by someone, and I approved of Godwin's attention. I approved of her attention, also. Sparrow. I was messy with the water, letting it run over me, turning so that she might see the droplets as they fell over my chest. She kept her eyes fixed on my face.

"Does that hurt?"

“Care for me, little wife?”

She turned red, and stuttered, and then I felt - strange. Like I had when I undertook my first long journey, the sea underneath me, the not knowing what was in front, and whether I might ever see home again.

“I care for all God’s creatures,” she said, in her haughty voice once more. My cock rose in my breeches, remembering this morning. I did not hide it, and she did not hide her attention, either.

“Is that why you called for me,” she asked. Her voice was cold, unfeeling. And yet. Her colour stayed high on her cheeks, her big eyes betraying her interest.

“Were you attended this morning?”

More blush, as though she had known of my fantasies. She nodded.

“Good. Take off your dress.” I did not want to be gentle with her again. She hesitated before lifting it above her awkwardly, the gown snagging against her elbows and hair, her stumbling slightly as she could not see. I chuckled, and moved to help her.

“You are not a natural seductress,” I said, as I released her from the tangle of fabric. I was tempted to burn this one, too, though I cast it to one side. Someone could dye it a better colour. I was King, it did not mean I should be wasteful. Especially if I was going to continue to ruin my own wardrobe as I had been too distracted and angered by hers.

“Then why bother,” she snapped, her hands coming to cover her chest as she shivered under the shift. I laughed, grabbing one hand and placing it on my cock. She had not worn the hair shirt. This improved my mood.

“Do you think you need any help?” I asked her, as I rubbed her hand along me, nearly groaning from the pleasure. She was silent, but she did not fight me. “Answer me,” I said, my voice already roughening with the feel of it, her small fingers gripping me even through the finely woven material of my trousers.

“No,” she said, in a small, quiet voice. I stopped. I did not want to spill too soon. It had been a day since I had been inside her, a day too long.

“Lie on the bed,” I told her, my voice low. She did as she was told, and I savoured watching her walk away. The completely natural way, free of artifice or intended seduction. The awkwardness of her body, the scrapes on her back. She clambered on - limbs ever so slightly uncoordinated, as though she were still unused to them. I did not chuckle, though I wanted to again.

Her knees were red. I kissed them as I moved towards her, opening my mouth to lick her. She made no noise but a faint exhalation, her leg muscles relaxing ever so slightly.

“Tell me about this morning,” I said, as I moved up. “Did you like it?”

Tiny fists clenched into the furs.

“Tell me, little sparrow.”

She opened her legs. I moaned at the sight of her. Not sore, but pink and perfect. Wet. I kissed her there, licked all the way down her, thrust my tongue into her heat, all while her fists were tightening

in the bedclothes, her breaths coming faster. I pinned her leg open with one hand, my other going underneath her, lifting her closer to me. It wasn't enough. I wanted to be surrounded by her. I was vaguely aware of myself thrusting eagerly into the bedclothes, my control fraying. A day of no release, a day away from taking her, from feeling her tightness clench around me, from watching her surprise as she experienced the pleasure only I could show her.

The thought made my movements urgent. I moved up, running my finger inside her, stretching her, as she writhed and gasped and tried to keep hold of control. Failing, she even cried out as her first orgasm overtook her. I wasted no more time.

Her stretch around me as she still convulsed with pleasure was obscene. I stopped once, twice, trying to push into her, trying not to come that instant. I could not help my moaning, my skill-less thrusting. It was as though I had never felt a woman's pleasure before.

She was small underneath me, my hands on her overlarge, I fantasised I could see the tip of my cock distending her stomach, I knew I could feel the ends of her passage, each thrust hitting her solid inner wall, with just enough space for me to fit and no more. My cock was drenched with the two of us, and I looked down at where we joined, her stretching around me, my wife. My queen.

"Churches," she said. "I need building to start."

She *was* my queen, the future mother of my children. I could be breeding her now, placing my heirs in her, she might already be with child, a son to inherit my rule over this whole kingdom.

The thought made my thrusts quicken, yet she was holding back from meeting me.

"Yes," I agreed, would agree to anything to get her to move against me, to thrust back. "Whatever you wish," I moaned, as she flexed her pelvis again. "Yes - yes - "

"A dozen," she said, though I had not taken her a dozen times.

"A dozen," I agreed, sweat beading on my forehead, as then she moved, moved her arms up to touch mine. Though we were joined in the most intimate way she had not ever reached for me, and I was overcome again by that same strange sea sickness, collapsing on top of her as I spilled into her with thoughts of my, of our, future children, of her belly growing and full, of her breasts huge and leaking.

It was only once my heart rate had returned to normal that I realised what she had done. I propped myself off her, caressing the hair out of her face, easier as it was still braided back from underneath her veil.

"Clever wife," I said, and her eyes flashed with something - approval, pleasure perhaps. My hand trailed down, down to her neck. I held it.

She was so fragile, really. So small. I could snap it easily. One-handed, should I wish.

"Don't ever manipulate me again."

I was **very** sure I would not be continuing this, at **least** until I had finished my PhD. However, the end of last year saw me hanging about in the 11th century, and I couldn't resist.

Uploads will be every two weeks, as said PhD is still very much ongoing. Please, for the love of god, do not assume that this is historically accurate. It is very much researched, and things are hopefully mostly decent. But I have also stuck to the golden rule of historical fiction, which is: 'never let the truth get in the way of a good story'.

If you have any questions about any of the attitudes, environments or personal items and their accuracy please feel free to ask away! I will endeavour to give as many recommendations and facts as I possibly can.

(this was actually meant to be uploaded yesterday but I had the primal urge to go through all of my clothes and get rid of as much as possible and it took the whole day. I don't make the rules sorry!! future uploads will be on Sundays).

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

I ordered dinner to be brought to our room. Again, I avoided the Hall, something I should not be doing given the ongoing festivities for our wedding and the ongoing ripples of unease running through the compound. But after her stunt, I wanted my wife to myself. I wanted her close to me, I wanted her to know that I still owned her, however she might try to carve out something for herself. She was mine. A prize.

I pulled one of the stools to the fire, sitting her on it. When she made a move to cover herself, I held her arms against her sides, forbidding her.

“Why don’t you just do it,” she muttered, looking into the fire. I didn’t know what she was talking about.

“Do what,” I replied, crouching in front of her. I, too, was naked.

“Kill me,” she said, in an empty voice. “Why don’t you just kill me.”

It took me a moment to control my response.

“I don’t want to kill you, sparrow,” I told her. She turned to me, her eyes hurt and angry and huge, too huge in her face, like pools of amber, her pupils crystallised in their depths.

“Then what do you want,” she said.

“You are my queen,” I told her. She had been clever - she spoke three languages, she spoke eloquently, she bore herself well. What was confusing about this?

“I am your slave,” she replied, holding my gaze.

“You belong to me,” I pointed out. “You are my wife.”

“I do not belong to anyone,” she argued. “You cannot possess my soul.”

“This is a war,” I said, pushing up and away from her. “This was a war, which I won. I am king. You are my wife. And so you will obey me, and you will not attempt to manipulate me!”

We were both quiet for a moment. I heard the footsteps retreating outside, no doubt already rumours of our disagreements would be spreading throughout the encampment. I did not have time, or patience, or, if I was being honest, the men to face down further disagreements throughout the kingdom, and so my little sparrow’s resistance was costing me more than my sanity.

I was not a fool. I did not think she would come willingly to me after I had murdered her people and threatened to kill her father. But I was tiring of her attempts to resist.

“You already know this is the cost of peace,” I told her harshly. “Have you decided that it is too high? You can leave. You can walk out this door right now, should you wish.”

“You know I cannot,” she retorted. “You will kill my father.”

“Then I suppose you have your answer,” I replied. This fighting was getting us nowhere, and any pleasure I had from taking her was evaporating quickly. That self-same itching began, but I resisted the urge to storm out. I needed to win her over, if not entirely, then at least enough for us to be crowned properly. To establish myself as king of this isle, to establish her.

“I do not want to fight with you,” I told her honestly, as I brought the food in. Again, strange that it was not strange at all to wait on her. The wooden platters I placed in front of the fire, and I stretched out on one of the furred rugs, gesturing for her to come to the floor with me. It was barbarian to eat off the floor, but I wanted to watch her lick the stew from my fingers. She sank awkwardly into the rugs, a little out of my reach, her back to the flames.

“Like the ancients,” she remarked, snorting.

“You have knowledge of their customs?”

“Some,” she replied, allowing me to spoon the broth into her mouth, though clearly disliking the practice. “There is a great poem that speaks of their achievements, and their ruins dot the land. Some great mosaics depict feasts and beasts from far-flung places.”

“You know the poem?”

“Yes?”

“Will you recite it?”

She hesitated for a moment. She must have heard how my people valued storytelling, and I wondered if that was why she weighed her response.

“ These wall-stones are wondrous —

calamities crumpled them, these city-sites crashed, the work of giants

corrupted. The roofs have rushed to earth, towers in ruins.

Ice at the joints has unroofed the barred-gates, sheared

the scarred storm-walls have disappeared—

the years have gnawed them from beneath...”

Her voice fell into a cadence I was familiar with from the storytellers of my own people, a rhythm that made me automatically want to prop my head on my hand as though I were a small boy, crossed-legged at their feet as they sang of great kings of the past. And I supposed this was the very same - the rising and falling of her voice along with that self-same tale of a once-great civilisation that had fallen. As she painted a picture in her native tongue I allowed myself to think of my own legacy, to wonder what towers I would build, and when they would fall.

We sat in silence for a moment once she finished.

“You speak well.”

“Thank you,” she murmured, still far off in the flames.

“Will you eat more?”

“I am not hungry,” she said with a shrug. I did not like this, and I did not trust the fact that I could see the faint outlines of her ribs. I traced one with the tip of my finger.

“Do not think to escape me,” I said, quietly. “For I would follow you into death just to drag you back.”

We were awkward the next morning. I decided that I was done with whatever game we were playing, and I ought to turn my attention to what really mattered. Power.

I was surprised when a visit from the dressmakers was accepted with minimal resistance. The women who came clearly knew of my wife, and their reverence was both interesting and useful. I had anticipated having to remain to oversee, but in the face of their woman-ish discussion, and the forthright attitude of their leader, who appeared as unwilling as me to let my bride walk about poorly attired, I left them to it.

It was to warm cheers that I re-entered the Hall, though the voices were fewer than they should have been. I summoned those who had helped my claim my victory, alongside Godwin, and we met in one of the smaller Halls, reserved for such discussions.

The room was warm, with a bright fire burning, despite the fact the sun was high in the sky and light was streaming in through the windows. Ale was brought to all of us, though I did not want the servants to linger. At a notice, the shutters were closed, the air immediately taking on the air of subterfuge, of plans, of spoils.

We numbered five. Myself, Eadric, Thorkell, Erik and Godwin. The others, though they knew me well, had known me since I was a small boy, I could tell were doubting my inclusion of the Englishman. Their suspicion was good, it meant they cared for my safety still. In light of the treasure awaiting us all, it would not be to overtrust them, though the knowledge that I could not ailed me. They were well-seasoned men who had seen many skirmishes and survived to tell tales to me as a small boy round the fire. Though silver streaked more than one beard, I mourned the trust I had lost when I became king of this place.

“Konung,” Eadric said, stealing glances at Godwin. “Tell us your concerns.”

“I do not wish to linger overlong here,” I began, looking in turn at each of them. “Our victory is assured, but even in my marital chamber I hear whispers of dissatisfaction among the English. We cannot let them have too much time to grow their unease. Winter is nearly here, and long nights around the fireside with hungry bellies and sore pride is good for no kingdom. There is much to do before snow comes to ensure that we will not face rebellions in the Spring.”

“Wise council,” Thorkill said, his shoulders ever so slightly bent, as they always were when not on the battlefield. Even so, he towered over us all. “What do you propose?”

“I intend to divide the kingdom,” I said, pausing to assess their reactions. “The land has only recently been united, and so returning to the natural kingdoms will likely not be overstrange. While you will pledge fieltly to me as King, you will be free to run your own territories.”

“Us?” Eadric was looking at Godwin.

“Godwin will assist me in ruling Wessex,” I continued smoothly. “I intend to manage that part of the country personally. But for the three of you. I can think of no greater honour than to entrust my new kingdom to you. You, who have fought alongside me, who have taught me more than my own father. I would like to see you receive the honours due to you.”

A moment of silence. We were not emotional men. We fought, and felt, and we understood the ties of loyalty that bound us together far deeper than any surface level show of emotion might reveal. But for a moment, I saw these men transformed, their faces lively and tender and unfamiliar for it.

“You are a good ruler, Konung,” Eadric said, gruffly. “And will make a fine and fair king of these lands.”

“Aye,” the others echoed. Godwin himself looked slightly seasick at his place in this inner sanctum, but I needed an ally on the inside beyond the reach of my wife, and I knew that there was no better way than to ensure loyalty than to be the one to offer it up first.

“What say you, Godwin,” I asked him. The man started, but otherwise hid his nerves. I like to think I was a good judge of men, and he seemed able to hold his own.

“I will not fail you.”

“Good. Then tonight in the Hall I will swear you all to me anew, and tomorrow we make plans to depart.”

“So soon?”

“So soon,” I said with a sigh to Thorkill’s question. I was tired, we all were. But we needed to make moves.

“Where to, my lord,” Godwin asked tentatively into our silence.

“Why don’t you suggest something,” Eadric snorted. I did not bother telling him to be polite to the newest among us, as Godwin would need to hold his own against all of them.

“The kingdom craves stability more than an English ruler,” Godwin said, astutely. “If we can prove that we intend to let them carry on, to protect them, to let them live their lives as they always have done, then you will win over the people faster than any battle.”

It was good advice.

“And how do you propose we do this?”

I returned to dress for dinner, not expecting to find my wife perched at the end of the bed, but she was there nonetheless. I started, unused to seeing her so willingly in a state of undress.

“What are you doing,” I asked, with only half my mind on her response. The other was on the shadow of her peaked nipples underneath her chemise, just as I had imagined on the day I had seen her.

“Mildred is to dress me,” she said, ignoring my interest. Her hair was unbound and brushed out, the curls frizzing around her head. I did not want Mildred to return.

“Where has she gone?”

“To take the bathwater out,” she replied with a sigh, as though these questions were irritating. I was still in the doorway. “She is going to return, shortly,” Hermione said, pointedly. I was not sure what had changed about her, but she was no longer looking at me as though she were afraid of me. Despite my hand at her throat. Perhaps she had liked it. My cock, half hard already, rose in my trousers.

“How soon,” I murmured, moving forward towards her. I could not help it. I wanted her. There was a faint line of gold embroidery at the neck of her chemise, and even that minute luxury made me even harder. That she had obeyed me in this made me feel as though I had won the battle all over again.

“Soon,” she said, her voice dropping, too. I reached her, kneeling in between her legs, pushing aside her thighs. “My lord,” she whispered, as I ran my hand up the inside of her leg, dipping beneath the fabric. It was so fine I could see it move towards the apex of her thighs, see the darkness of her curls.

“What did you buy today, little sparrow?” I stroked a finger along the seam of her cunt, she swallowed. “Tell me,” I whispered.

“Gowns,” she replied, shifting slightly.

“Mmhmm.” I wanted to kiss her, but I did not. She held my gaze as I teased her. “What kind of gowns?”

“Too many,” she said. “I could buy grain for a village for a year from the cost of them.”

“Then you shall pick your village,” I told her, enjoying her mouth dropping open.

“Do you mean it?”

I slid my finger into her, enjoying the tight clench of her around me, and grazed her bud with my thumb.

“I do,” I told her, wanting to reward her. Her breath came quicker, her eyes widening. “Will you wear one tonight? Or are they still to be made?”

She took a moment to respond.

“There is one that will be ready,” she replied, her breathiness nectar to my ears. “They were making it for another Lady.”

“I am glad it will be yours,” I replied. Footsteps suddenly halted outside the door, a garbled apology. Mildred had returned. My little sparrow was rigid, my finger almost trapped in her. I grinned at her, my body blocking anything from being seen. “Do not apologise,” I halted the serving girl’s jabbering. “I was merely admiring my wife’s new undershirt.”

I removed my finger from her pussy slowly, then traced it along the gold, smearing a little bit of her along it. As I stood, I sucked the taste of her off my finger.

“I will leave you to ready yourself for tonight.”

I left them both open mouthed and went to find somewhere to rub my cock in private.

The roar of the Hall was audible from the very edges of the Bailey. I would know, seeing as I nearly strode out into the inky darkness of the landscape around it to try and find somewhere that I could be alone. Lit braziers illuminated the path towards it, the fires spitting into the dark sky, stars still visible over the smoke of many roasting meats.

I was to return tonight, my bride-time over, and this feast would in a way mark the beginning of my rule as King, not just my wedding to an English bride. I let the anticipation distract me from my aching cock. I would have to find ways to have her in the day, if I could not even spend a handful of hours apart without growing needful again. We would celebrate with gifts, and stories, and the men who had committed acts of bravery on the battlefield, from both sides, would be permitted to tell their tales and drink their fill. Tonight, more than any other night, I had to show them that I was worthy. That I was worth it. The years of fighting, the continued pressure, the time away from home. They would all walk away rich men.

The roar solidified into a wall as I stepped through the doorway. The priest, a red-faced man I only knew because of his proximity to my wife, and our own *god̥i* stood either side, both greeting me as I stepped across the threshold, into my new kingdom. I saw many horns and more cups being lifted to the wooden beams, though with the steam and the candlelight the atmosphere was hazy and rowdy, thick enough to swim through.

I had put on my great fur cloak, and though I went un-armed, as all men did, I wore the gold chain of my office that I had taken from Hermione’s father, still spattered with blood and dirt from the battlefield. My tunic was long and ceremonial and fine, finer than I had dared wear before. The whole thing was made from a single sheet of silk from the East. I had bought the fabric years ago and waited for the day I might be King enough to wear it.

As the people cried out for me, I knew that day had come.

I took my time moving through the crowds, greeting everyone, by name if I could, taking the time to learn those I did not already know. It was working even among these English, their eyes glassy from the drink, their head spinning from the adrenaline of surviving, of being here, of being allowed to live.

I did not want to linger with them, though. I wanted to make my way to the dais where the long table holding my wife lay. My wife, resplendent in white and gold, shimmering in her great, dark chair, such a small figure yet emanating a power that I knew did not just call to me. I would be a fool if I overlooked the sway she held on these people. They loved her.

I felt those ancient amber eyes on me as I circled in closer to her. Watched her watch me from the corner of my eye, as she sipped, and leaned in closer to Eadric on her left, laughing at whatever joke he was making, never once looking away from me, the conquering king.

“Wife,” I said, finally approaching that table. Though I spoke softly, all quietened, waiting to hear what she would say next. She stood, the gold circlet about her brow glinting in the candlelight, her beaded neck reflecting a soft shimmer onto her face. She shone, she glinted, she was treasure itself.

“Husband,” she replied, in a voice loud enough to carry across the room. “I welcome you, Great King, *konung inn ríki*, to this Hall. As your wife, I welcome you.”

A great roar met her words as she held her cup up to me, and they drank. After drinking deeply - far more deeply than I expected - she held the cup out to me. I turned to my men.

“As I am welcomed, my brothers, I welcome you! To new lands, and new friends. May we drink deep and share our stories until the dawn breaks. Skál!”

I settled into my great, carved throne next to her as the roars echoed, turning to her before I acknowledged Godwin on my right.

“I am surprised,” I murmured, so that no one might overhear, so that she might be forced to lean in closer to me.

“Why,” she replied, equally softly. I could hear the way her necklaces brushed against each other as she leaned in, a soft clinking that reminded me of silver hoards.

“You did not feel like defying me publicly,” I asked, half teasing. She rolled her eyes.

“Not tonight, *Konung*.” The word had bite, though not as much as I would have expected. She eyed me, taking in the chain, the great cloak that I was itching to remove in the heat of the room.

“I meant it,” I said. “About the village.” She held my gaze, and then gave a small, yet regal, nod.

“And I thank you.”

“I think you will enjoy tonight,” I said, sitting back and speaking at a normal volume again.

“And why is that, my lord,” she asked, placing a bland smile onto her face that would appease those in the Hall who could not stop sneaking glances at her. I did not blame them.

“Because tonight, we shall tell stories.”

Chapter End Notes

Oh its so nice to be back <3

The poem Hermione recites is called *The Ruin*, and it survives today in fragmented form! It survives in *The Exeter Book*, which was compiled in the tenth century and contains lots of early medieval poems and riddles. The *Exeter Book* likely would have been put together around 50 years before this story, though many of the poems and riddles from it probably date from an earlier tradition. This poem has been dated several centuries earlier, to the 8th or 9thC. Some people think it describes Bath. The 'ancients' Hermione refers to are the Romans, and it is difficult to ascertain how early-ish medieval people considered them. The poem itself is one of the key indicators of their opinions. It refers repeatedly to the great stone structures that they constructed and the wealth of the times, and has a sort of *Ozymandis* feel.

A Viking ruler would also very likely be able to get their hands on some silk. Vikings were traders; there are silver hoards of Islamic silver (among other things) found that indicate trading routes between the two empires were well-established, and Vikings loved shiny, beautiful things. I know it probably seems like I'm placing a lot of emphasis on what people wore, but this really was an easy and important way to demonstrate status. Hermione's insistence on heavy veiling, for instance, is one way to indicate that she still desires a religious life, as religious women would have been the most thoroughly covered.

A goði is a name for a Norse spiritual leader, though most of the duties would likely have fallen to the actual leader (ie, Draco). If someone knows more please expand, as I am less familiar with Norse pagan practices than I ought to be!

Also! Yes - lots of baths! People bathed!

Here ends your Sunday morning lecture!

Oh - and there's a playlist.

<https://open.spotify.com/playlist/1TzVk4EkLBUWVCLTAVQ1UG?si=f380e1ed4e9744c9>

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

please note updated tags *the smut continues*

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

The scent of roasted meat and spilled ale filled the air. The sharing of horns and cups was well underway, and I drank deeply from all those who approached and requested to share with me. Soon the gift giving would commence, and each man who came to receive something would be able to have his moment, to speak of his battlefield exploits, before returning to his seat with various spoils. But first, my men would be given their lands. I rose, steady on my feet despite the amount I had drunk, and the Hall quietened.

Eadric, Eric and Thorkell all stood, too, knowing what was coming.

“Men!” I called, though their attention was already on me. “Today we mark a great victory.” Cheers erupted already, even from those who had been defeated. In this Hall, they were no longer losers, but part of the new regime. However they felt about their losses, they at least knew enough to survive. “Today, we mark a new dawn. A new rule. One where our wives will grow fat and old, our children strong and brave. A time when our people will flourish, where we will enjoy the fats of the land, where we will never know hunger again!”

Godwin had been right. The hunger in these men’s eyes was for more than spoils. It was for stability. For a safe bed at night, for a lifetime free from fear.

“We have fought for this. For peace!” I had laughed at Edmund, though I was not above twisting his desires to suit mine. ‘For peace!’ echoed throughout the Hall.

“Tonight we honour the men who have fought for this new world!” More cheers. “We honour Eric of Hlathir, son of Earl Hákon Sigurðarson, brother of Aud Haakonsdottir of Lade!” At the reference to his sister, Haakonsdottir, the crowd erupted. Eric circled the table to where I was standing in front of it, taking a knee before me. I raised the drinking horn above my head, the horn that I had brought with me from home to this place, with this in mind. Gods were carved into the outside, its rim encased in silver. It was a horn of victory. “Eric of Hlathir, I give to you Northumbria, over which you will reign as Earl.”

The din echoed throughout. Erin drank the horn dry, passing it off to be refilled for the next man. He turned to the Hall, as was custom, telling tales of his prowess in war, telling the tale of how he came to be my man, how he took me in as a small boy after my father’s request, how he trained me, knew what I was to become, honoured me, and finally, because of me, could claim the title Earl. We knew from our brethren in Jorvik that Northumbria was a fertile place, and though the Christianity my wife was so fond of was held in high esteem there, it would still be a fine place to rule over. A place worthy of him.

The evening continued in much the same way. I announced Eadric and Thorkell's roles, and then spent the rest of the time handing out spoils from the battle to those who filled the Hall. The process was long. I drank heavily each time so as to honour my men, though I was aware that I could not appear drunk. They had no such restrictions, and those approaching me by the end of the eve were staggering and spit-stained. These received heavy helms, shields and armour recovered from the dead, and under the weight of the spoils they were even more unsteady as they returned to their seats.

I was aware of my sparrow's eyes on me the entire time. It was strange. I realised I was proud. I was often proud; of myself, and my men. But this was a different kind of feeling. I revelled in her attention, was eager to prove how well-loved I was as a leader, how respected. Things which I had wanted for myself took on a new sheen under her attention. Though I handed out land and jewels as though I did not care for them, I knew that I had won the greatest spoil of all.

The giving of the gifts and the sharing of their stories took most of the evening, but the drink continued to flow once the procession had been completed. I returned to my seat next to her, sweated and drink-soaked. I could not help the huff that left me as I sat. And though she was seated as tall as she had been at the beginning of the night, the lines of her body were weary.

"Your men speak well," she said, politely rejecting another glass of the spiced wine I ordered to be made ready for her. "They are proud to serve you."

"They are good men," I replied. "And they are proud to serve you, also."

"Who is that man," she asked, ignoring my compliment. I tore my eyes from her, her upturned nose, her high forehead hidden by the glowing bands that adorned it, then grinned.

"Ottar!"

"My lord," the man bowed, his necklaces clinking against one another, his black tunic richly dyed and trimmed again with silver, his fingers sparkling with rings. "And my lady."

He bowed deeper to my wife, taking her hand, pressing a soft kiss against the back of it. It was only the faint amusement emanating from her that quelled my sudden rise of rage. Nevertheless, he would not be paid for tonight.

"My skald," I told her, as she flickered her eyes towards me. "Who will be lipless, if he does not remove them soon," I added. Hermione was discreet when she did it, but she wiped the back of her hand against her skirts, and it was this, rather than Ottar's grovelled apologies (said with a glint in his eye), that calmed me.

"I have come to entertain," he told me, though I knew perfectly well why he was here, and that did not excuse him kissing my wife.

"Then do so."

I was pleased that Ottar's presence drew the attention away from us. I had enough, I realised, of what had started out as sideways glances, but now were openly appreciative stares at my wife. I did not want my men to think that they had leave to approach her, to talk to her, to even look at her.

"My people!" Ottar was starting, close to the fire, his eyes flashing with pleasure at the attention he was garnering alongside the flashes of his jewels. I paid him too well. "Tell me we still know how

to speak of kings! In the old days, everyone knew what men were: brave, bold, glory-bound. Only stories now, but I'll sound the Spear-Danes' song, hoarded for hungry times."

I knew the tale well, but appreciated his introduction to it even less than his mouth on my wife. Signalling to my advisors, I rose. My wife raised her eyes, a little red from the smoke, a little hopeful, perhaps, that I was done with the night. I did not give a shit about interrupting Ottar, and hoped that every man in that Hall noticed the snub.

The rooms felt small when I entered them, and I understood the itching under my skin as eagerness to move on. No matter things were still unsteady between my wife and I. I had a feeling that if I were waiting for her to accept me, then we would never leave this place.

"We will depart the day after the dawn," I told her, casting off my cloak onto the chair in front of the fire. I nearly groaned aloud with the relief of it.

"For where?" She asked, tired. I heard her splash water over her face, then sigh. "I will call for Mildred."

"Come, sit in front of me. I will help."

"Like a maid?"

"You should formally appoint your women before we move on."

"I already have women."

"You need a new court. The wives of my leaders will need appointments."

"Must we talk of this now?"

"If you will not let me undress you then we will talk of nothing but political appointments until you fall asleep where you stand."

She stomped over to me, the little creature, and sat heavily in between my legs. Her back was stiff, the redness in her eyes more pronounced now we were in the softer glow of our own rooms.

"It is not always better to defy me," I told her, as I picked the pins out of her head covering, one by one, as I had on our wedding night. She did not reply immediately, but the silence was not uncomfortable. When I removed the gilt bands that held the veils in place she audibly exhaled, rubbing her temples.

"It hurts?"

"They are heavy," she said, sleepily. "It is not just because of the Lord that I do not care overmuch for finery."

I let out a little laugh. She was right, my sparrow. The headbands were made with gilt thread and studded with pearls and clear crystals, and I was not surprised her head ached.

"If you ate more you would be stronger to wear them."

“I don’t think bigger portions will make my head stronger,” she sniped.

“Try wearing a helm for hours a day.”

“Mmm,” she said, as my fingers began a slow massage in place of hers along the edges of her hairline. “I think I will leave such things to you.”

We could still hear the roar of the Hall from here, but the muted sounds of the night and the crackle of the fire lent a cosiness to the room that I was not expecting to appreciate. I felt myself relax, my earlier pique against Ottar beginning to be forgotten, my wife letting me comb out her braided hair. It had been a handful of days since we had been married. And yet, the familiarity of the movements already felt... Something. It felt like something.

I bade her stand, and she did, swaying slightly with fatigue. It pleased me, to fuss over her. I propped her on the end of the bed, removing her necklaces, unpinning her cloak and her overtunic. When it came to her stockings, I knelt in front of her, sliding her feet out from the embroidered leather shoes she wore. They were pretty, and I admired them as I ran my fingers over the soles of her feet. She made soft, pleased noises, more vocal than usual. Perhaps it was the wine again which had unwound her, perhaps she was just too tired to keep up her resistance. Though I enjoyed her fight, I found I liked this version of her, too.

As though I were unwrapping a gift I unwound her leg coverings, inch by inch revealing silky white skin that I had felt, but not seen earlier. Her scent intensified as I moved up her legs, but her body remained languid on the bed. The skirt I lifted higher, my cock stiffening in readiness for her. I glanced up to watch her watch me, and was...disappointed.

She was asleep. My sparrow spread out on the bed, dress and chemise still on, legs splayed open, braided hair spreading across the fur at the base of our bed. Her chest rose and fell in regular rhythm, her mouth hung slightly ajar.

I could still take her. Though I generally enjoyed a partner who was awake, there was something thrilling about the idea of using her in this way. I paused a moment to consider it. The silence was made more apparent by the soft noises that surrounded us. There was no one awake who would ever see, or hear, or know, and if they did they would hardly begrudge me for indulging in my own wife, spread out in front of me. I had eaten heartily at the feast, yet my mouth watered.

I pushed her legs wider apart and she did not stir, did not stir when I ran a finger over her pussy and pressed it inside, did not stir when I leaned in to lick her, when I inhaled her because I found the scent of her after an evening at my side intoxicating.

I fisted my cock at the same time as I continued to make her wet, half hoping she would wake to find my mouth on her pussy, half hoping she would not. She mewed, pressing herself closer to my face, something she would not dare to do when awake. I stopped myself from moaning, my heavy breaths in the quiet of our space alone sounding loud enough to wake her. She had proven her sensuality, it was clear that though she denied herself this physical pleasure she still sought it, and that made me move my hand faster, squeeze my cock tighter. I stood, shakily, reluctantly, working my hand over myself, pointing my cock at her thighs, until I erupted all over them.

As though she sensed the injustice even in her sleep, her hips kept moving, flexing, seeking, wanting friction when I had removed it. My breathing returned to normal, my legs feeling oddly hollow. I looked down at my seed, glistening all over her thighs.

Slowly, my care returning along with my sanity, I undressed her, tucking her under the covers. I did not wipe her legs clean, I wanted her to wake with me smeared on her, I wanted her to wonder why her legs were sticky and why she felt so unsatisfied. The thought of her, restless and empty, desperate to be filled, stiffened my cock once more. I tried to hold her, to sleep. But she was restless, physically tossing and turning, and that I knew what she wanted - needed - only made my own rest all the harder to discover.

As she turned over I took my opportunity. Snaking one hand around her front I pulled her back against me, nestling her against my stiffening cock. That same hand I slotted between her thighs. Now I was the one sticky with my own release, and I smeared it against her, letting my finger rest against her clit as she burrowed further into me. I knew then that I had her - that she would be mine, truly, body and soul. She did not know it yet, but she would be. I nuzzled into her neck, kissing and licking along the edges of her ear, her jaw, not caring if I woke her.

Her movements became more intentional, though she did not open her eyes, or make any other indications that she had woken. Perhaps my little sparrow was scared of what she wanted. I was happy to wait, happy to fill her cunt first and then torture her about it after.

The marks left by her hair shirt were starting to heal properly, too, and it would not be long before I would be able to teach her about more than just pleasure, about the pain that could go alongside it. Given her desire to punish herself, I was sure that she would want it. That she would crave it, as she was already starting to crave my cock.

With every little whimper I grew more hard, more desperate to be inside her. Her upper leg was relaxed as I raised it, though by this point I was sure that she was awake, mewling softly into the mattress base. I eased myself into her, under the pretence of not wanting to wake her up. Yet she was the one who drove the pace in a move that both surprised and thrilled me, eagerly pressing against me, trying to take more. Only when she was finally seated on me fully did she relax, and lying there together we lazily fucked as the banked embers of the fire smouldered in the pit, and the dawn birds began to blearily sing outside, the darkness of the oncoming winter still heavy in the sky. I kept my thumb on her clit, my other arm trapped underneath us, my face buried into her neck as my cock was buried in her cunt. My head was starting to pound slightly from the wine, and I was sweating and hot, yet there was nowhere else I would have preferred. Not on the battlefield, claiming victory over my enemies, not finally succeeding where my father failed and making this land mine, not anywhere, but here. Inside her.

She came with a trembling cry, muffling herself too assertively to be truly asleep. I followed her soon after, moving my hand to hold her stomach, fantasising once more about the life we would create there. I let her continue her pretence, myself closing my eyes and lying my head against the pillow. I could feel that she did not sleep for a while, though for how long I did not know. The lateness and the wine and the pleasure soon lulled me to sleep, and when I woke up late the next day, she was not there.

The beginning of Ottar's story is from Beowulf! Specifically, an adaption of the translation by Maria Dahvana Headley which came out a few years back. It's not the most accurate but it is my absolute favourite favourite version, mainly because I think it's a great example of what translation *can be*. Like, her foreword in that is worth a read even if you're not a fan of the poem.

Anyway! A short lecture this Sunday - I'm horribly behind on everything (to paraphrase a hermione quote from one of my other fics).

MWAH xoxo

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

I did not care that my wife had left, and I did not feel bad the next day for taking her the way I had, either. There was too much to do, and too few men with clear enough heads to set about to it.

“Your wife is in church, my Lord.”

“I did not ask, Godwin.” I had not broken my fast yet, and I was hungry. The Hall still held bodies from the previous evening, more than one who had fallen asleep where they had sat. It felt early, though I knew it could not be. The herb-strew straw was now sodden with ale and other, worse-smelling liquids.

“Very good, my Lord.”

“Where is everyone?”

“Still abed, I believe -“

“Wake them,” I interrupted, not caring for whatever ailments they might be suffering this morning. If I was awake, then they should be too. “Bring my advisors to the Hall and begin packing. We leave tomorrow. Anyone who does not come with us can remain here to rot. And send me someone to fight,” I added, hearing only silence from the training space. “I will not have us grow soft.”

I did not look back as I strode out of the Bailey gates, tired of this place.

“I hear you put Godwin in quite a place.”

“So she emerges.”

It was nearly noon, and the castle was in shambles. Men and women scurried around, the sound of trunks slamming shut echoing throughout, the raised voices as people squabbled over which hangings to bring and which to leave, the questions over who would arrive at Winchester and who would stay in Assundun to overlook the borders. I was happy to leave dealing with such tiresome nonsense to Godwin, though I was wary of becoming over-reliant on the English Lord. I spent the morning pummeling whoever crossed me in the fighting ring, and once again entered bloody and bruised to my rooms, to find my wife in a state of undress.

“Leave us,” I snapped to Matilda, but Hermione placed a hand on her arm.

“Matilda needs to stay. She is helping me pack.”

“You can pack later.”

“I cannot, given I have so many new gowns to take with me.”

There was poison underneath her sweetness.

“Pack later.”

“I pack now.”

“If you intend to return to your church -”

“I have much to do to ready the household in Winchester,” she said, overcutting me. Matilda continued steadily to fold the many new dresses I had indeed ordered be made. Given by the number of pins in each of them most were still in various states of production. “I have sent word ahead - as you imagine the castle has been under intense fortifications, and will hardly be in a fit state to receive you.”

“I don’t care.”

“You should care.”

The two women admired a bolt of finely dyed linen as though I was not there.

“I need to wash,” I said, belatedly.

“Shall I call someone, my Lord,” Matilda said, averting her eyes from me.

“No.”

“I hear they have not even cut enough wood for the winter,” my wife said. It took me a minute to realise she was talking to me. I muttered under my breath. I could not believe I had wanted this land so badly, not when they appeared to be incapable of running this tiny isle without making the most obvious of mistakes.

“Not enough wood.”

“They had problems with moths, too, over the summer. I believe a whole casket of winter tapestries is now threadbare.”

I concentrated on inhaling and exhaling, so I did not make a hole in the wall.

“And I presume you are about to tell me that there are no deer, or pigs, or chickens, or even cows to eat. And the rivers have run dry from fish, and the water is contaminated, and the beer has been left to ferment too long, and the honey has run out,” I sniped. She shrugged.

“Matilda heard from her cousin, who heard from his wife’s daughter, that things have been very hard there indeed.”

“Matilda,” I snapped. She squeaked, and dropped the veils she had been carefully folding. “Is this the truth?”

“Yes, my Lord.”

“Look at me when you answer.”

I was glad she was loyal to my wife, though she was a terrible liar.

“Leave us.”

Both women tried to speak. I had had enough.

“I said go.”

My wife stood there, her shoulders stiff, staring straight at me as her serving girl left swiftly, no doubt to immediately spread the news of our quarrel. She was so regal at times that I fought the urge to bow to her, even in my temper.

“Tell me the truth,” I asked, softly. “Why do you not wish to return to Winchester?”

“I care not where you take me.”

“I said the truth, wife. What is it that you fear there?”

At the notion she might be afraid, her eyes flashed furiously.

“I fear no one.”

“Yet something about that place -”

“It is my *home*, ” she cried. “It is my home, *my Lord* . Where I grew up. Where I hoped to live in peace, without the interference of you.”

“It is still your home.” I could tell by the emotion in her voice that she was finally telling the truth, yet I could not understand her anguish.

“It is not mine anymore,” she replied, surprising me with the bitterness. “It is yours now, too.”

I blinked. I was not often surprised. But this - I had, in truth, thought she had started to warm to me. I had thought she was beginning to get used to this new life beside me.

I left.

I should not have ridden so hard when we were to be leaving the next day, but I could not stay there. One of the English horses - stocky, but fast - took me as far from the encampment as I dared to go. In my anger I had brought no weapons, only the blade that always hung from my waist. Should anyone approach they would know me for who I was - my bright white hair stark enough against the rolling green hills to be an easy target. I thought of these things all too late, and it was not until the sun had passed its peak in the sky that I realised how foolishly I had acted.

The landscape was soothing, even in its foreignness. So rich, so green. Scores of birds filled the sky. An omen, though in my own turmoil I could not tell if it was good or bad. We should do something before we left the coast, bring some sense of spiritual ease to our men who had not converted. I had been lacking in my own attentions to that side of their needs, and was sorry for it. Hermione seemed to fill every crevice of my mind. Perhaps that was her goal. Perhaps she intended to bewitch me so thoroughly that I would rule badly and her people would depose me.

I shifted in my saddle, uncomfortable with that thought. The thought that she might still hate me. I know I brought her pleasure in bed. I had thought last night that she was even starting to seek it for herself. And yet today - the flimsy attempt to get me to avoid her home I had not anticipated.

I had been stung by a bee when I was a child, and I remembered the pain all the more because of how shocking it had been. This was like that. A slap when one had not been expected. Should I try to get her to warm to me? How might I even begin that, when I had already given her so much and she still despised me?

I wanted to tell her how lucky she was. To remind her that I might be cruel to her. That her own father's life was still hanging in the balance. I had not killed any of her people. I had treated her with respect. I had given her an endless stream of gifts - clothes, money for the poor, her promised churches that would be reconstructed when the seasons became more forgiving. I had done all of this, and yet.

I pushed the horse onwards, towards the cliffs. I needed to see the sea, to feel the coastal wind blow away the black mood that had seized me.

The ocean was vast and wine-dark that day, which felt appropriate. White crests on the waves were appearing regularly, and the wind was strong. A good day for sailing. I missed the feel of the longboat underneath me, the rocking of my ships, the sensation of a great fleet leaving port, the anticipation, the excitement. It felt like years had passed since we last set sail on a journey like that. How strange to be at the other end, and to still feel so unsatisfied.

I was peering out, trying to see the landmass of the continent, when I heard the other rider approach.

"Ho!"

Erik. I loosened my grip on my sword, half turning to watch him pick his way towards me. The horse he was riding could not have been more than a pony, and it was ridiculous the way he dwarfed it, weighed down with his cloak and all manner of weaponry. I snorted.

"What kind of horse is that?" I asked, and he laughed, reaching besides me, almost a foot shorter on his tiny steed.

"These English have a strange sense of humour," he said in reply, staring out at the sea with feeling in his eyes.

"A good day for a sail," I said, also turning.

"Aye."

We were quiet for a moment, taking in the view. Gulls screeched above us, the wind blowing their bellows inland, the roar of the ocean filling the air with a sacred sort of silence.

"You left in rather a hurry."

"I do not need a lecture," I replied, sharper than I needed to be. Erik snorted softly.

"You are king of England, now," he reminded me, as if I could forget. "The days of you running about on your own are behind you."

"I can protect myself."

He did not reply to that, as we both knew that it was a stupid thing to say. All manner of things could fell even the mightiest warrior, if the Gods thought he was not being careful enough.

“I will be sorry to move on,” Erik said, changing the subject. I could not work out if this was more of her influence at play.

“You wish to stay? Here?”

“No. But I will be sorry to move on. The next phase of the journey. I fear it will not be half as much fun as this one was.” I snorted. He was probably right. No fighting would await us in London and Winchester, but politics instead would fill the days. And then I felt, too, sad that it was over.

“Is this why you have come to stare at the sea?”

“No, though she is good encouragement for reflection,” Erik had always been open. Open and warm, in a way that did not come naturally to me. “Do you wish to talk about it?”

“The sea? You are far more poetic than I.”

“Not the sea,” he said. I swallowed, feeling suddenly young, and small, and stupid.

“There is nothing to talk about.”

“Oh? So your lady’s ladies’ maid nearly in tears muttering about a fight, the uproar that you’ve forced the camp into before riding out practically unarmed in the middle of it, and your own bride looking miserable and sitting fireside with Ottar, who desperately wants to sleep with her, are not connected at all?”

“Ottar?” I was turning the horse before Erik’s hand landed on the top of my saddle, holding it in place.

“He will not succeed. And that is not why I came out here.”

“Why, then? I am not in the mood for riddles.”

“You are besotted with her,” he said, his voice dropping so even the wind might not overhear us.

“You are mad,” I hissed back.

“It is you who are mad if you cannot see the truth.”

“She is a good choice -” I felt compelled to defend my actions, but Erik interrupted me.

“I am not saying it is not a bad thing,” he told me. “I am pleased you have found someone who might rule alongside you, who is strong enough for you. But you are acting like a boy when you need to be a man. You cannot let the camp see how much she affects you. It will make you vulnerable.”

“She is not -”

“Lie to yourself if you must, but at least acknowledge this is how it appears!”

“Appears? That I am some love-struck youth who cannot think because of a woman?!”

“Yes,” he said, throwing up his hands. “For the gods’ sake, Draco. Yes! That is exactly how it appears, and I know you well enough to know that is how it is, also.”

“So what do I do,” I said, ignoring his argument that it was true. “Am I to become indifferent to her? To beat her in front of them?”

“You are being ridiculous,” he chided. “This is what I mean. Of course you must not hurt her. But you must also calm down. Every time she is in front of you, you forget everything but her. Be more measured in your dealings. Do not storm out just because you have squabbled!”

I did not like how wise his council was. The sea, too, was unhappy, roiling and roaring beneath us.

“She does not want us to go to Winchester,” I said, relenting. “Because it is her home, she does not want us there.”

“It has been but a handful of days since her father was deposed. He still is at risk of losing his life, and her entire world has been shattered. She thought she was going to be a Christian nun, Draco. Give her time.”

“I already give her whatever she wants.”

“Everything but *time*. Let her get used to this new world. Let her get used to us. She is trying.”

I snorted.

“She is. She stayed by your side at the feast no matter how late it got. She is fair to your men. She is currently helping pack up the camp, even in your absence.”

“I thought she was flirting with Ottar,” I muttered, unable to resist.

“He is telling her stories of you.”

“According to you he was trying to sleep with her!”

“I said he wants to, not that he is trying to. He is trying to cheer her up. There is a black mood over the place. You cannot throw a strop and expect others not to feel affected by your actions. This is what I have been trying to say.”

I considered it some more in a dark silence, then sighed.

“So you have been sent to bring me back, I suppose.”

“We drew straws,” he said, undoubtedly referring to my other two advisors. We both chuckled, though I knew it was not true. Erik would have been the one to volunteer. He would also have been the only one capable of talking to me in such an open manner, and walking away unscathed.

“Am I so bad,” I said, quietly. I had not expected him to hear me, but he answered anyway.

“You are a good soldier, and a good king.”

He did not say I was a good husband, and as we rode back, I considered this.

Erik and I caught several ravens on the way in, and arrived with the intent of saying we had been out, looking for signs that our actions were approved by those in the heavens. The men, though

mostly hungover still, at least seemed to appreciate this. I ordered the apples to be spiced and brought out as part of our leaving feast, and I sat beside my wife. We made polite conversation, though I let Eadric, seated on her opposite side, occupy her attention for the most part.

I watched Ottar speak of my battlefield glories with only half a mind on the proceedings. Inside I was still staring at the ocean, still listening to the gulls, still wondering why it mattered so much if my own wife liked me.

Chapter End Notes

chapter count, shmampter count.

I was overcome with anxiety about Draco's poor provision for his army's spiritual health, hence the ravens. Sorry guys, daddy is too busy shaggin' and yearnin'!!

An interesting aspect or trend in recent medieval scholarship is the attention to the landscape, and how the landscape and the medieval person might interact. Draco, when riding out, would have been doing so along Roman roads. Bronze Age monuments would still have been visible and ancient to them already. The flora and fauna would be drastically more dense than they are today, the people much fewer. There would have been actual wild land across much of England, which is so strange to think about from a modern perspective?? Anyway. One fiction, non medieval book that I think does this really nicely is 'North Woods' by Daniel Mason, if that line of thinking intrigues you!

There is no porn in this chapter, and it is my great sadness to announce that there is now Plot. Forgive me, my lords and ladies xxxx

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

My wife went to bed before me, and I did not wake her when I finally retired. The next morning we were still quiet with each other, dressing efficiently. Mildred entered after I had finished to attend to Hermione, who needed help with wrapping her legs for the long day of travelling. I did not offer to do it for her, and I tried to ignore her slightly stilted response when she asked to call for her maid.

I took solace instead in the company of those who were coming with us. Admired the many wagons that had been stuffed full of trunks. We would be several hundred strong winding along the road. War banners had been hastily re-fashioned and the musicians would be travelling too, and I hoped that despite whatever turmoil was within me, we would make a cheerful procession towards one of the seats of power.

It would be a while before we arrived in Winchester, however. London was the first stop, able to be reached within a day, even by our bloated and slow procession. We would rest there before heading on to Winchester, with the goal of spending the Yule festivals in that place. I knew the Christians had a festival around the same time, and so the month could be taken up with feasting and drinking, and my men might be able to rest a little more.

But first, London.

Through all the battles we had fought here, in both my and my father's lifetime, we had never once managed to breach the city walls. The inhabitants of the place fought more fiercely than their counterparts. They made more coin. Controlled a large portion of the realm's wealth.

London. I grinned at the thought.

I turned to ensure my wife was being helped into the wagon she would travel in, and then paused in confusion.

The courtyard was a sea of people, but I would know her anywhere. I did not see her small, veiled head.

"Konung," Eadric pulled up next to me, bouncing slightly, his beast clearly eager to be on the move.

"Where is she?" He did not need to ask for who I spoke of.

"Ahead, I believe."

I had, despite appearances, listened to Erik's words the day before. And yet, the idea that my wife - the *Queen of England* - had galloped off into the distance without me filled me with something half-rage, half-panic, that I could not name.

"I am not ahead, I am here." Her voice was high and sharp and she was glaring at Eadric as though he were smaller than her, seated atop a dappled grey mare, by far the finest horse I had seen since I arrived here. Both beast and owner tossed their heads impatiently.

“My lady,” Eadric said, in a tone I did not particularly care for. “You must ride in the wagon. It is not safe.”

I found my voice at long last. “You wish to ride?”

“I do, my Lord,” she said, ignoring my aide.

“Very well.”

I kicked the horse into action, and she, obediently for once, followed in step. Perhaps it was because we were both displeased with Eadric, though I found myself cheered by the idea of her beside me. Our horses jostled only slightly, though mine was far too well trained to be truly bothered by hers. I had to stop myself from glancing at her as we rode out.

Those on horseback followed behind us in formation. The band struck up, the creaking of the wagons and noise of people talking, joking, laughing, making us loud and free. Even I found the corners of my mouth tipping up gently.

We made slow, but steady progress. Eadric rode just behind us, and he made small talk with my wife as we wound our way through the countryside, asking her questions on the lands, trying to regain her favour. I looked over the landscape with a new appreciation now that it was mine, taking in how healthy and verdant it was, even when approaching the winter depths of the year. The roads were well-maintained, even as the wilderness of the fens and marshland buttressed up its edges. It was a new day. A good day.

We moved inland, the marshlands quickly turning to densely forested areas which teemed with life. Rich hunting, though it also meant that our procession was forced into a more narrow order. Ahead of us rode the standard bearers, and I kept my queen by my side. Though I did not feel as comfortable in the dense undergrowth, the road was still clear, and she certainly appeared at ease.

“Do you need to stop?” We had made pauses, and indeed were walking so slowly it was perfectly natural for her to slip on and off her horse as needed, though it had been a while since our last pause. I thought of her frail legs and was concerned that she would have the stamina to ride the whole way there. And still, though I liked having her by my side, I wanted her tucked into the wagon out of sight. She merely looked askance at me.

“No,” she replied, as though I were fussing over her. Perhaps I was.

“You grip the reins tightly,” I pointed out, to her little knuckles gleaming white in the disappearing sun. She huffed. I realised, suddenly, that it was not a requirement to relieve herself that she was embarrassed to make. “You are cold,” I said, wondering why I had not realised she was so thinly attired. My rage again was sudden and difficult to control. Matilda should have known better.

“I am fine.”

“Where is your cloak?”

“I am wearing it.”

“That is not suitable for winter.”

“You sound like Matilda,” she muttered. Perhaps I would not kill the woman.

“Well?”

She gave a great sigh, the infuriating creature.

“In the baggage.”

I tried to keep my irritation in check, but it rose violently. As I called back for a cloak for my wife, I handed mine to her so that it might keep her warm in the meantime. She buckled slightly under its weight, though her back remained straight. I kept watch over her, transfixed, perhaps, by the ways she tried to resist physical comfort, and by the slight unbowing of her shoulders as she longed to burrow into the thick folds. She took a deep breath. I had a thousand questions, though I found myself unwilling to ask them and to interrupt our half-peaceful silence. Still, after a while, I could not help it. I tried to keep my tone light, as though I were just making easy conversation.

“Why do you resist material things so strongly,” I asked her.

“Because of what Matthew tells us - that it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter heaven,” she said, her voice taking on that scholarly bent it had whenever she spoke of her Scripture. I had seen a camel before, but only once, when my early travels took me East rather than West to meet with traders who brought us silks, the same time I had purchased the bolt that I had kept safe until I deemed myself worthy enough to wear it. They were large beasts. I hummed, as though I were considering her words, though in truth they irritated me.

“Plenty of your churchmen wear fine clothes and have many lands,” I pointed out. She shot me a glance, though I could not interpret it.

“I believe that only by resisting comfort on earth can we gain eternal reward in heaven,” she said, her own tone still light, though she was growing irritated with me already.

“Do many others follow you?”

“It is my own interpretation of the Gospels,” she said, cautiously. This intrigued me. Though she tried to keep even, there was no escaping the slight emphasis on *own*, as though she was protective of her studies.

“I have not heard of women leading the Church. Why do you not?”

“There were women leaders,” she argued back. “Hundreds of years ago, when the religion first came to these lands. Ethelburga, and Hild, and others who Bede tells us of, who converted many and were rewarded in this life and the next.”

I had, in my brief time in these isles, heard much of this Bede, a famed scholar and historian who had recorded recently the history of the place. I vowed to get a copy of his works as soon as possible, and even felt a little embarrassed by my own ignorance of them. I had spent too long only paying attention to works of battle or stories of soldiers, and I should not have overlooked other leaders of this place.

“Yet you cannot become priest. Or Pope. Or bishop.” This was not a question - it was well-known that all the Christians disliked having women in positions of leadership.

“It was not always so,” she said, and I felt as though the clouds that had covered the sun for so long parted barely, so that I might catch a glimpse of her burning gold ambition beneath the surface.

“Another thing I have taken from you,” I said, because it was the truth.

“Yes,” she replied, a little stiffly. I considered this some more.

“There are other ways to be powerful,” I said, picking my words with unusual care. She did not fill the silence. “It is not just pleasure that I can teach you.”

I wanted to say more, but I could not. At that moment, a blur flew from the trees, and I threw myself forwards, directly in front of my bride, who had been ever so slightly ahead of me. She cried out, as a blunt, warm pain hit my upper arm.

Adrenaline exploded, as the rest of my men did around me. My yelling was unfocused but my intent was perfectly clear - we had to protect the Queen at all costs. Horses bristled, hers, at least, was trained enough to not startle amidst the chaos, and I unslung my shield from my saddle to hold above us both.

“To the queen!” Shouts echoed back down the baggage train. I wanted to check her over for injury but I wanted retribution more.

The past few days had been so peaceful I had almost forgotten. These lands were mine, but that did not mean that their inhabitants accepted they were, also. I had much to do to ensure their obedience, and I was not about to lose another moment of it.

I threw myself off my horse in the next second, my sword still in my belt as I favoured my small axe, the better to hack through the undergrowth.

I ignored the cries of my men, they would fall into formation behind me. I was past subtlety, too, and let out an almighty roar as I stalked my prey. At that moment I was not thinking of whether there was more than one - no more arrows had been fired which suggested it was not a concerted effort, but even if there had been it would not have mattered. I would have killed them all.

It did not take me long to find him.

He was running. The shouts of my men were still echoing, a bloodthirsty drum beat to my own roaring blood. He was fast, and knew these woods.

My left arm ached somewhere in the back of my mind, but as I saw the man responsible for opening fire on my wife a new wave of fury surged through me, blocking out any pain and filling my arms with strength. My mouth filled with saliva, my muscles started to strain. Berserker.

I charged for him.

Perhaps when we got to the city I would have been more inclined to act like a man. But here, in the woods, I was beast. He buckled as I threw myself against him, knocking him down into the undergrowth. I threw my shield off, and discarded my axe. He was no competition, and had I been in a clearer mind I would have understood how wrong my attack was to fight a man so much weaker than I.

I was not in a clear mind. He had tried to harm my wife, and he would pay for it with his life.

I was accustomed to it - the blood rage. I let it take me, let my fists and body fly, let the screams of the man goad me, encourage me further.

It cleared eventually, ebbed from the corner of my vision. The blood soaked bushes started to come into focus. They were covered in dark red mixed with that yellowish tinge of the insides of his skull. So were my hands. I spat to the side, there was blood there too, and a chunk of flesh that was not mine.

When I came to, I felt the full extent of my injuries. Scratches on my face where the man had scrabbled against me, frantically, no more powerful than a rabbit. The ache in my arm - an arrow wound, I finally realised, one I probably should not have fought through.

There was little left of his head. I took in the wreckage calmly, my heart rate returning to normal. His brains and blood were decorating the leaves around him, his body limp, his shoulder an unnatural angle from where I had ripped it from its socket. That had not torn properly; it appeared my fist, raining blows upon the man's skull, had been what killed him. I rose on steady legs, exhaling heavily. As I took in the traitor's corpse I realised my fury was not fully dampened. But taking his life would have to be the only thing I had to appease me.

I hefted his limp and lifeless body above my shoulder, walking back towards the trail.

In my fury I had come further than I realised, but it was easy to make my way back, following the aggressively hacked trail I had made to find my enemy. My shoulder strained with the effort of carrying him, dead men always making the heaviest burdens. I continued to spit the taste of him out my mouth, smeared across my face. Still, it was with satisfaction that I made my way back, and it was with satisfaction that I emerged to find the road as it had been - filled with my people.

Messengers were sent to track down my soldiers and bring them back to me, and the shield wall hiding my bride from view pleased me as it parted, as did the small, beady gaze that landed on me quickly, that was filled with relief for a moment so sweet it was nectar from the gods. That was, until it saw what I carried.

I threw the corpse on the ground in front of her, and she stared, unblinking at its mangled frame.

"The man who attempted to take your life, my bride."

She swallowed.

"Let it be a warning to those who might wish to follow in his footsteps."

Her response surprised me, more bloodthirsty than I thought her capable of. That, naturally, pleased me further, and I was sure it was only the loss of blood that meant my cock lay flat in my trousers.

We made our way to London, leaving his body on the road.

Chapter End Notes

I have been having many debates about whether or not Draco's literal pummelling a man to death, outside the battlefield, would have been considered okay or not. Most of our earliest

English laws for instance are mainly concerned with how to manage violence, and so the idea that you would have been permitted, without retribution, to act like this doesn't seem likely... On the other hand, he was the king. So, yknow. If this were real he very easily could have been positioned by chroniclers as barbarian for the acts, or shown to be a strong and military leader. History is fun!

A note, also, on Hermione's ambition. I think, (and other early medievalists agree with me), that women very much did hold positions of power in the early Church, possibly even being female bishops and female abbots. This is as far as I'm aware, mainly unpublished so far, so take care when arguing as there hasn't, and probably won't ever be, a definitive answer to this. The women she mentions - Ethelburga and Hild, were both important. Bede also is like..theeee major source we have for early medieval anything, and I'd recommend reading his *Historia Ecclesiastica* if you fancy a primary source that will give you a good overview of early medieval life.

What is *definitely* true is that women were instrumental in the conversion process of England to Christianity. This is also true for Islam as well! Which isn't relevant, I just think it is interesting that two major monotheistic religions have had very important women in their beginnings.

I like to think that, even though hindsight tells us Hermione would have never been able to become one of these kinds of female Church leaders, she was still holding out hope for it. The eleventh century reforms did, sadly, work to distance women from positions of power, and by the end of the century Hermione and Draco are currently in, the best you could get would be to be an Abbess. (This is not to say that wasn't hard and these women didn't have power - they did! It's just complicated, and not as good as out and out being like...a literal bishop, probably). (Idk...just saying this in itself feels unsure because you could probably argue 'to what extent did women have power in the eleventh century church' whichever way you wanted endlessly, so, yeah).

ANYWAY. I'M SO SORRY I FORGOT TO UPLOAD. I've been suffering under two massive dphil deadlines, a GIANT eye stye, and (in nicer news) Mr Croft and I are gonna get married. Love you all! How is everyone?

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

I had been welcomed to the city, my horse fed and watered, my men shown to quarters, and myself ensconced in the ones belonging to the previous king. A steaming bath had been brought up the many stone steps that made their way to my chambers. A knock on the door, and it was my wife, rather than a healer, who entered. She hung about in the doorway, shy again, though eyeing my left shoulder with concern.

“It does not hurt,” I lied. It hurt more every blasted minute, the throbbing in time to my heart.

“I brought medicine,” she said, revealing the small pots she carried. “You should bathe.”

The room was quiet, and I awkwardly undressed, hating that she saw how difficult it was for me to move my arm. Eventually she crossed the great, rug-covered expanse to assist me, unbuttoning my jerkin and tunic with steady fingers, easing the undershirt over my head. Her hands lingered slightly on my chest, or perhaps that was the blood loss.

The city was abuzz with my arrival. Great thronging crowds had gathered to pave the way to the palace, staring, some cheering, most of them drinking and eating and using it as an excuse to celebrate, regardless of who I was. I supposed I appeared the perfect savage conqueror, my hands bloodstained, my appearance furious and still thrumming with that red-tinged rage. Still, with Hermione at my side, veiled and on horseback, swathed in fine cloaks and furs and our horses with bridles of gold, we appeared every part the rich and trusted rulers I wanted to become.

I was looking forward to exploring what it had to offer, but there was no denying as we approached the palace that I needed some sort of attention. I barely managed to stop myself from swaying as I dismounted, and it was not without urgency that my little sparrow called for a bath. I had not realised she intended to care for me herself.

She helped me into it, her small hands doing little to steady me physically, though the pressure of her fingers helping my shaking legs. I lowered myself, and groaned loudly as I eased back, breaking off into a sharp hiss as the water reached the edges of my wound.

“The arrow is still in you,” she murmured, her fingers light as they probed. “The tip must have broken off. If you had been wearing your cloak I doubt it would have pierced the skin.”

“Perhaps you will wear yours more often, then.”

She snorted softly, and I was distracted enough by the sound that I did not realise until too late that she was cutting further into my arm, pulling out the shard. I shouted, she soothed me, applying pressure around the wound and causing the throb to ache in a little more manageable way.

“You are doing well.”

“I have been injured before,” I snapped.

“Then you are not doing well at all,” she replied, tartly. “Because you are huffing like a woman in childbirth.”

I laughed again, briefly, and she smeared me with a stinging ointment that I was too manly to make a sound about. The worst of it over, we sat side by side, me in the bath, her on my left side, her left hand still massaging my arm, the two of us silent. The sounds of the city gradually filtered through my awareness, and a feast - or several - were already underway. Her fingers played idly in the water from her right hand. My fingertips reached up to hers, tracing around their edges. It was quiet and still, and in the stillness they threaded between each other, and then I was holding her hand, rubbing my thumb along the outside of her hand.

“I thought he had hit you,” I told her, my voice low.

“I thought you would not return,” she replied.

More quiet filled the room, but she did not let go of my hand.

“Did the thought please you?” I could not hide the vulnerability in my question, fierce as I felt, much as I wanted to be. She was quiet for a long time.

“It did not please me,” she said after a while. “It did not please me at all.”

I looked up from our hands to find her already staring at me, eyes large and luminous.

“It did not?” I asked. Tomorrow I would blame how childish I was acting on the pain, but tonight I needed her to need me.

“No.” She bit her lip, plush and plump as ever. “I realised that I was not ready to lose you.”

“You will not,” I vowed. “Not in this life, nor the next.”

“The next -”

“I will do it,” I said, stupid from the pain and adrenaline and the fact she was here, holding me and telling me she wanted me. “I will convert.”

Her bottom lip dropped down. I wanted to place my finger in between them, but I did not want to stop holding her hand. My left arm was stiffening already and I would have to be careful with the healing, and still she gaped at me.

“Why,” she exhaled, eventually.

“It is a good thing to do, politically,” I shrugged. It was true, of course. I had seen the number of letters she wrote and knew of the network of churches, priests and bishops, all of whom were indebted to her and had influence and control over their people. Today’s attack, however small and ill-thought out, had driven home the point that I needed to secure my position.

“Is that all?”

I was at once relieved at her own need for reassurance, and mortified that I would do this for a woman.

“No,” I told her. Our fingers tightened further. “It is because I want to make you happy.”

She bowed over our hands, hiding her gaze.

“You have given me much.”

“I know,” I said, snorting softly. “Too much, perhaps.”

“Is that what they tell you?”

“I am not a man who cares what others think.”

“You will be a poor ruler if you do not listen to counsel.”

“I have counsel enough,” I said, finally reaching up my stiff left hand to cup her jaw, her chin, gently nudging it upwards so we might gaze at each other again. “Here,” I told her. She looked vulnerable in the candlelight, but placed the weight of her head in my hand. At my wince, she lifted it out, and I went to reach for her further, and was stopped by the pain.

“Go slowly,” she told me, returning to her more official watch on my injury, stroking the top of my arm. “Do not strain yourself.”

The pressure on my muscles felt good enough to entice me to close my eyes, and she continued to massage the stiffness away.

“You will make me fall asleep in my bath,” I told her.

“You should sleep. It will make you heal better.”

“I should see to my men.”

“They are occupied, I am sure.”

“I am their King,” I said. “They need to know I live.”

She sighed, but I could hear her reluctant agreement in it. I found myself smiling at her, and even more surprisingly, found her smiling back. My smile faltered as she reached out, tracing her hand against my lips. I pursed them, kissing their tips, which tasted of ointment from where she had administered the medicine for me.

She leaned forward, moving her hand down. And then she kissed me, light and quick and innocent.

I was still slightly dazed from it as she dressed me to go down, meek and obedient as a child. We were halfway down the great stone tower when I stopped her, backing her against the tapestry-covered wall, encircling her with my arms. I tipped her mouth up to me and kissed her back, properly. Thoroughly. Tasting her mouth, licking into it, feeling her open underneath me, feeling her hands tighten, pulling me in tighter, feeling her want me for the first time, and perhaps I had lost my heart when I nearly ripped out that man’s, because I wanted to stay there forever in her embrace.

Still, we both had duties, and it was with uneven veils and half-ruffled clothing that we continued our descent.

That evening was hazy to me, not just for the woodsmoke and roasted meats and vegetables that marked our arrival, and likely the beginnings of the festive season, but because of the almost warm presence of my wife. She was attentive, serving me food and ensuring my own cup was not empty. I spoke with many people, including those who had kept the castle running throughout our assault. There were clever men here, clever and quick, and women who knew what they were doing. They did not need me to approve their decisions, and treated me as though they served the city, rather than a man.

I liked this approach. It felt modern. Fresh. I was able to converse with them openly, in the same way I might with my advisors from home. Eadric was once again at my wife's side, and Thorkell and Erik were interspersed between people. Already I was thinking of who I might marry, more ways I could intertwine the two peoples. Godwin seemed a prime candidate - he had proven himself invaluable in the organisation necessary to arrive here, and it would be good for the Englishmen to see me raise up one of their own. The old King still lived, something which made me uneasy. I knew why I had not killed him, for she sat next to me, fluttering her little hands across my plate. But I needed to ensure loyalty to me, not to her father.

As I allowed myself to brood over ways to solidify my reign, a new man slid in next to me.

"A moment of your time, my Lord."

He was young, with a slim face and darker colouring, a sun-tinged mirror to my wife. Thick eyelashes, thicker than any woman's I had ever seen, framed large, down turned eyes a deep brown. He was unnaturally beautiful, and dressed in the plain brown wear of a monk. His hair curled down around his ears, long despite the crown of his head being bald, in the way of all the priestly men I had come across.

"Very well."

"I am Stigand, my lord. I am a priest here, and I know you have expressed...reluctance in your embrace of the one true faith, but I wanted to speak with you further on the scriptures. I know your wife is devout, and I thought perhaps you might want to understand more of her worldview, and perhaps learn how you might be bound together not just in this life, but embrace the universal pleasures of the next, too. The lord and saviour promises eternal life, you see, one in which there is no pain or..."

My wife was studiously avoiding my gaze, listening, by all accounts, intently to whatever Eadric was muttering to her, the shadows playing over both their faces. I did not bother explaining to Stigand that I did not give a shit about eternal life, not when I would likely be turning my back on the true pleasure and glory of a seat at Valhalla. I was being stupid and cunt-drunk, saying I would convert. And yet, I was happily handing over the idea of eternal glory in exchange for my cock being buried deep in my wife's pussy in this life. Eternity without that did not feel like heaven to me.

"We will discuss tomorrow," I told him, to his evident surprise. The spilled mead dripped onto the straw-covered flagstones below, and I was forced to move my great chair back so that it did not cover my lap.

"I am sorry - so sorry - I mean - Yes, I would -" the stuttering was boring me. I had assumed he was bold for he approached me, yet perhaps I was mistaken.

We left shortly after, her hand in mine.

The new rooms were unfamiliar, though I liked them much more than the previous ones. They were larger, though were covered with more rugs and so kept the heat from the fire, so much so that I had begun to sweat before I could undress myself.

Again, my wife helped me, dabbing my own brow rather than let me wash my hands and face myself. She perched me on the end of the bed, as I had often done to her, and we were silent as she attended me. I stared at her, she avoided my gaze. I wanted her.

She noticed my arousal, stopping herself from smiling at my cock, standing up thick and hard and ready for her.

“You are injured.”

“Not so injured.” And really, after her attentions and the wine I was certainly feeling a pleasant ache in my shoulder, rather than the throbbing pain of earlier.

“You cannot hold yourself up,” she argued. Ah. I forgot, truly, how innocent she was. How little she knew of such things. I moved back against the bed, lying down, fisting my cock so it stood upwards, opening my legs a little wider.

“I do not need to. You are going to ride me.”

She couldn't take her eyes off it, her breath coming a little faster, her eyes a little glassy. Truly, I was expecting more resistance, and so when she spoke it surprised me.

“How?”

“Take off your clothes.”

It was warm but her nipples were still pebbled from desire, the marks that covered her already scabbing over, some of them fading entirely. Soon. So soon I would be able to do things to her - to tie her up, to take my hand to her, to dominate her truly in a way that I was certain would bring her pleasure.

“Come towards me. Sit astride, as you would a horse.”

She blushed a bit as she crawled onto the bed, the linens dipping under her slight weight, her shuffling up along my legs. I could smell her, see her pretty pink bud glistening amidst the curls between her legs.

“Perfect, just like that. Hover over my cock.”

“Like this?” Her voice was high and nervous.

“Like that. You look so good,” I said, before I could stop myself. But her colour deepened, and she seemed more eager after my praise. I had been so fixated on bringing her round to pleasing me that I had not thought she might respond warmly to kind words, not just gifts. “You do,” I continued, allowing my good hand to move up to her thigh, to rub small circles into it, which must have been sore from riding. “You look like you are made to take my cock.”

She gasped, blushing further.

“You should not -”

“No,” I stopped her, as she shuffled better into place. “I should have told you this before. Many times over. You should get used to hearing it. How good you feel around me. Now, take my cock.”

She did, her grip still light and unsteady, but more practiced, now. With my good arm I reached for her, finding her slick and wet already.

“Put me inside you.”

I watched as she did, her legs trembling, the tip of my cock disappearing into her wet heat. I could see and feel the stretch of her, enjoying this new angle.

I had had more adventurous sex with more adventurous women, and yet watching her sink onto my cock for the first time felt more erotic than any of those encounters. She was so small and innocent, taking me for the first time. I could not come before she had even fully seated herself, and yet I could feel my balls tensing up underneath me already. I was panting, the stretch of her tight, the feel of her warm, my desire to thrust overwhelming.

“Good,” I grunted. “More. Take all of me.”

“It -” she blushed, then broke off.

“Tell me.”

“It feels strange,” she confessed.

“Good strange?”

“I - think - yes.” Her words were punctuated with sighs, her acknowledgement that it felt good intoxicating.

“Good?”

“Good,” she agreed, finally seating all the way. “Oh.” I flexed inside her, making her gasp again. “*Oh.*”

“Now. You can move how you want to when you are taking me like this. You are in control.”

She gave a small chuckle, experimenting shifting on top of me. I watched her, fascinated by her tentative explorations. “Am I in control,” she asked, making small grinding movements against me, her clit brushing against my lower stomach.

“Yes,” I told her, half honestly. “I told you, did I not? I will show you about power and pleasure,” her movements became bigger, bolder. “I can show you how to take what you want.” We had not spoken when I fucked her recently, and yet I could not work out why I had not told her these things before. “I can show you how closely the two are aligned. How you need not feel shame of either. How you can rule over men and make them so eager to please you they would fall on their own sword.”

“You want me to fuck other men like this,” she asked, confused, and the jealousy stopped my rising need to come. But then I saw how she continued to move, continued to seek pleasure, and my anger was momentarily put on hold by my intrigue at her own desires.

“Would you like that,” I asked instead. “Would you like other men to know what this pussy feels like?”

She did not answer, but her eyes drifted shut, a thin sheen of sweat starting to cover her breasts and upper chest, a flush on her chest spreading deliciously.

“Would you like it right now,” I asked, my voice dipping. “Would you like that young priest to come stumbling in here, to see how you take my cock, to watch you chase your pleasure, to see your pussy spread open and filled with my seed? You would, wouldn’t you. You’d love to watch him give in to his desire, for him to take his little cock out, for him to rub it, watching you fuck me, wishing he was underneath you -”

She came with a muffled cry, falling forward onto me, her whole body convulsing. I held her body up, taking over, filling her quickly as I too came, still fantasising about it, still imagining letting others stare at her smeared in my seed and sweat. I would have to kill them all, afterwards. I wondered how many men would give up their lives for a glimpse of her like that.

“Would you actually let another man watch,” she asked, her voice small and confused as she lay beside me.

“Would you actually like it,” I asked in return. I trailed my fingertips along the edges of her flushed chest. She frowned, and I was mollified by the fact she appeared to be uninterested in the idea. Now that I had come, the idea of other men filled me with a jealous rage.

“I don’t think so. I cannot imagine you letting it happen.”

I chuckled, reached for a rag to clean her and let us both be distracted by the business of falling asleep. I was disturbed by how much I had been tempted, disturbed at how far I would go just to watch her explore her own sexuality. Erik had been right. I was dangerously obsessed with my wife.

Chapter End Notes

FINALLY some smut again wow about time am I right!

Plus a bit more on 'how to actually rule, maybe?'. London is really interesting for me. It doesn't play a massive role in this story, but when the real, actual Cnut took over he loved the city the most out of the various palaces etc around, and spent a lot of time there. It features a little bit next chapter too, but in general I don't talk too much about the actual reality of what the city was like, mainly because I kept getting distracted with what Viking London would have looked like and bogged down in even more details which actually bloated this story way too much.

Also: the real Cnut laid siege to London as he was conquering England! I did not include that in this story, because it didn't fit with the plot. I think sieges are probably an interesting backdrop if you are writing a political thriller. I think if you are writing a sexy, shaggy little

novella, sieges are snoozical. If you want to know more about medieval London, A. Reynold's 'London into the age of Cnut' is open access so you can download for free!
<https://discovery.ucl.ac.uk/id/eprint/10174188/>

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

We stayed in London for seven nights, each one marked with some sort of feast or celebration. The bonfires were kept burning high, and candles cluttered every surface, chasing away the winter gloom and the short days, though still lighter than I was used to at this time of year. It was a time of revelry, and the only interruption of these pleasures were my wife's prayers, and Stigand.

Hermione threw herself into prayer and personal reflection with a fervour that was both surprising to me, and deeply boring. She prayed all day, murmured with her priests, and would come to me when asked but without any real pleasure. I wanted our intimacy back, and then hated that I did, and distracted myself with other, more pleasant activities. Along with my advisors we toured the city, taking in the two mints, the cases of coins that they gave to us, the armouries that they opened for us, the treasures that we explored. Even the cathedrals I did not mind visiting, for the wealth that filled them now belonged to me, despite what the Pope may have thought.

And it was wealth, wealth so casually slung about that I had almost become inured to it. Great piles of silver and gold. Enormous books, filled with more gold, and priceless inks made from stones all over the world. Fine linens, even finer robes and tapestries that had been made within the city itself, created from fabrics that even I had only seen on a handful of occasions, these too studded with further precious stones and embroidered with metallic threads.

Stigand accompanied us on these spiritual trips, and I allowed him brief moments in the day where he might talk to me of scripture. The rumour that I would be converting was naturally all over the city. I put off confirming it purely because the way people responded annoyed me.

Thorkell and Erik accepted it for what it was: a good political decision. The cathedral treasures, I was sure, seemed to ease any lingering questions they might have had as to whether aligning myself with such an institution might be a good idea. Eadric, however, felt otherwise, and lost no time in telling me I was making a decision purely because of Hermione's influence. This turned into an argument which was not easily resolved. In my fury, I pointed out that he had spent plenty of time in her company anyway, as the two of them invariably found themselves together, though she appeared more distant in the days after my injury. He stormed out, and I flipped the table in our chambers, and Godwin, Thorkell and Erik rolled their eyes until I shouted at them, too.

Later that evening my wife asked me why my knuckles were bleeding when she knew I had not been fighting, the days being too busy to train, and I shouted at her as well. She laughed in my face at my accusations.

"Take off your dress," I said instead, needing something. Needing someone in this city to bow to me.

"No," she replied, making to leave.

"Take it off."

"Stop it."

“Take -”

I grasped her arm, too hard, but through it - the realisation of why she avoided me seemed to beat me across the face.

Something rough under the fine layers of wool and silk. Something that made her cringe as it was pressed into her skin.

That fucking hair *fucking* shirt was back on my fucking wife's body.

I usually felt the overwhelm of emotion when I was on the battlefield. It had been many years since I was unable to control myself in any other arena, and yet at the appearance of the shirt, that same blackening of my vision overtook me. Her wrists were too small and thin in my great bear hands, and I forced myself to let her go before I snapped them.

“You are scaring me,” she said, her voice barely loud enough for me to hear. “Draco? You are scaring me.”

“Burn it.”

“I will -”

“Burn it. Now. Or I will burn Stigand alive.”

She stuttered, shrinking back against the wall. I could not do it - could not control this rage. “Draco -”

“Do you test me?”

She paused. Undressed shakily. The sight of her scraped skin did little to soothe my anger, though I hated myself all the while I saw her fear. Her fear of me. She had never been afraid before. Not even on our wedding night.

“Does that please you?” She asked, throwing it onto the fire, standing there naked. There was no defiance in her voice. Only sadness. I wanted that fight from her, I wanted her to feel like I did, out of control and shaking. I did not know what I needed, only that I needed my surroundings to disappear, to go up in smoke, to burn like I was.

“Climb on the bed.”

“You are not in your right mind.”

“You will not be either, when I am finished with you.”

It was difficult to recall her movements, all of them being blurred by my own rage, the process by which I tied each ankle and wrist up, soup-like and confused. But I had done those things, because the sight of her restricted beneath me, her limbs pulled tight, her little chest rising with quick breaths, appeared before me, soothing.

Her skin was marked, the healing wounds reopened easily in the same spaces. I traced a finger along the edge of her armpit, along the grazing there. She shivered - fear, desire. Were they so

different?

I had wanted this, I had been waiting for this. Waiting to introduce her to these things slowly. Perhaps I could not wait any more.

“What is running through your mind,” I asked, moving my fingers up to her hair, sifting them through the braided tresses, caressing her. Touching her so softly, making her eyes close.

“I do not know.”

“Tell me.”

“Too many things.” She shifted, trying to avoid me.

“You cannot, you know.”

“Cannot what?” Her eyes flew open, as I pinched her ear lobe, and she gasped.

“Cannot escape me. Cease trying. I grow bored of your games. The little ways you try to hide yourself. The ways you try to keep parts of yourself away from me.”

I trailed my fingers over her, tracing over every dip and crevice, circling the marks. Still softly. For now. Her skin was pebbled from the cold. I wondered if her pointed little nipples were pointed for other reasons, too. Whether she would be wet if I touched her.

“My lord,” she begged, though I did not know what for.

“Do you want me to stop?” The question hung in the air as I regarded her. She was flushed and spread and naked and I wondered if I would, if she asked. My heart was still beating too fast, my muscles tight and taught, my body yearning to be inside her. We waited, her and I, for her to decide.

“No.”

She closed her eyes as she whispered it, almost flinching away from her own desire. And then I understood why she had been so distant from me, finally, the realisation clanging into my own brain. The hair shirt. The praying.

“You do not need to feel guilty,” I said, keeping my voice low as I pulled off my shirt and tunic, the slide of the fabric making my oversensitive flesh shiver, the chill of the room a subtle bite. I shook out my waistcoat from the tumble, seeking the fur trimmed round its edge. “Do you want to feel guilty? Do you want punishment, sparrow? Is that why you wear it?”

I followed the trail I had marked with my fingers with the fur, watching her sink further into her own need, watching her wrestle with whether or not she should admit to me what I could see that she craved. I did not want my wife to carry negative feelings about our bedsport, but if she wanted to use discomfort to chase away any lingering sense of guilt, then I would be only too happy to indulge her. Indeed, with the rage of the past few days and my own frustrations seeing the hair shirt back on her body, I wanted her to want this. I wanted to see what she would do. How she would feel. I wanted her to crave my punishment, not her own.

“Yes,” she whimpered, this one easier to admit to. I pinched one nipple sharply, where moments before it had been caressed, and she gasped.

“Like that?” The meditative stroke of the fur replaced my fingers again, and her body relaxed back into the bedclothes. “Answer me,” I said, pinching her other nipple, eliciting the same response.

“Like that,” she said, her voice a little louder, perhaps more uncontrolled.

“Good,” I praised, as her limbs relaxed once more, as I spread my fingers over her. She was still too thin and I wanted that to change, too, but there was a little more flesh stretching over her ribcage than there had been at our wedding night. I licked up between her breasts, then scraped my beard across them, scraped it across the abrasions which existed there before. She whimpered, but eagerly, her eyes still squeezed shut. Her legs tensed around me, wanting to close, unable to.

“Do you feel that,” I murmured, my breath hot against her skin. “How you are at my mercy.” That elicited another whimper and the flex of her hips, I moved away so that the friction she craved might not be granted. “How helpless you are right now. How I am able to touch you however I wish, how you must give yourself over to me for pleasure.”

“Yes,” she gasped, as I took one nipple into my mouth, sucking it hard. “Yes,” she said, louder, as I bit it. My sparrow. So needy.

“Would you be wet, little wife, if I touched you?”

She did not answer me but moaned as I took her other nipple into my mouth, eyes still closed. I bit that one, too.

“Answer me.”

“Yes,” she said, though I knew she did not want to answer.

I got off the bed, moving around the room, and her eyes flew open, confused, seeking.

“Do not worry, wife,” I said, amused, my temper almost entirely forgotten purely because of the tiny furrow that had appeared between her eyebrows. I found what I was looking for, holding up one of her unworn stockings, dangling it in front of her. The furrow deepened.

“I am going to tie this over your eyes, if you wish to keep them close.”

“Oh,” she said, her head falling back against the pillow, her limbs still spread. “Okay.”

Her voice was small again. I had to remember that she was new to this.

“It will heighten your pleasure,” I told her, moving closer to her again. “You will not be able to see what I do, just feel. You will not know what or how I will touch you until I do, yes?”

I placed it over her eyes, the thick material blocking out the light. She hummed, understanding, and I gently nudged her head up, so that I might tie a knot on the side.

“Can you see me,” I asked, my breath slightly raspy at the sight of her. She was biting her lip, wetting it with her tongue.

“No,” she said after a moment, swallowing.

“And?”

I could see her furrow return even underneath the blindfold.

“I do not understand the question,” she replied, finally.

“And do you like it, sparrow,” I teased.

Again, that pause. And finally.

“Yes.”

So soft and so perfect. I took up my belt from the floor, and snapped it lightly over her breasts.

“Good.” My praise was lost in her cry, her surprise. Her arms and legs stiffened, then relented, her breath coming faster.

“And did you like that,” I asked. I wanted to do this to her buttocks, wanted to use my own hand. But I wanted her to continue to be spread before me more, and this way I could see her face as I continued to snap the leather against her skin, bringing the blood to the surface, edging along the rougher grazes that dotted her armpits, tops of her breasts, hip bones.

“Yes,” she mewled as I moved the belt lower, almost on the top of her pleasure.

“Good,” I said, avoiding that area for now, stroking the leather along the top of her thighs. She was wriggling more now, as much as she was able. “Does it feel good, knowing that I am doing this for you,” I asked, still trailing the belt. “That I am punishing you, because I know it is what you crave?”

I did not wait for her to answer, replacing my question with more slaps to the tops of her thighs and lower stomach, concentrating them in the place I knew she was hoping I would go.

“Do you like knowing that you have done wrong? That you are bad, and I will be there to cleanse you of your sin?”

“Please,” she gasped, her little arms starting to shake, her skin remaining red for longer.

“Please what, sparrow? You must confess.”

“More,” she cried. “Please, more. Touch me, please.”

“Why?” I wanted her confession more than my own pleasure, though my cock was stiff and bobbing against my stomach, eager to be attended to.

“I want it, I need it,” she gasped, as I hit her a little harder. “I need you. Please, Draco. Please.”

I relented, snapping the belt over her little cunt, making her cry out. I continued to tap it, her cries were louder than they had ever been, I was certain we would be heard, I was thrilled by that thought.

“Do you need my cock in you, little wife,” I asked, climbing onto the mattress and feeling it dip underneath me. It was harder to bring about the element of surprise when I was positioned so close to her, but she was too lost in her desire to notice the regularity of my snaps across her body. I lined myself up against her, biting back my moan as I felt how hot and warm and ready she was for me.

“God! Yes! Please! More -”

She could not finish her sentence, as I pushed inside her and snapped my belt again on her bud, making her come apart at the seams, her orgasm unravelling her, her body shuddering around me, clenching me so tightly I could feel it, almost strong enough to make me come.

But I did not want to orgasm yet. I wanted to take her more, I wanted to make her lose her mind as I did mine in her presence.

I threw my belt to the side, gripped both hips with my hands and started to thrust aggressively into her, holding her in place as she cried and moaned around me, her hair tangling in the blindfold which was slipping down her face, thrashing from side to side.

“Do not move,” I said, as I thrust, watching her move up and down on my cock as though she was made for it. “I am going to take you so hard, little wife. I am going to make you so puffy and sore, so that every time you sit down you do not need a hair shirt to remind you of your wrongdoing. You do not need anything but my cock. Do you understand me?”

“Yes, yes,” she was chanting the word almost in prayer, her head now held still, though my thrusts were driving her deeper and deeper into the bed.

I fucked her as long as I could, long enough for sweat to drop down from my brow onto her body, long enough for my cock to start to chafe, too. I kept one finger on her cunt, watched her come a second time, crying out as the force of it exhausted her, as the overstimulation continued to overwhelm her, her body still flushed and swollen all over. Only when I knew I could not hold back any further did I finally finish with a roar, filling her, holding her against me, promising her that she was good, that she was good again.

We sat like that for a moment, my vision clearing. I stretched my stiffened fingers and breathed, she came into focus below me, whimpering.

I was exhausted, but knew I needed to let her go. Shifting, I untied her feet and hands, before pulling her into my arms and slowly removing the blindfold. She was shaking, and I stroked her, petted her, murmured in a hoarse voice how good she was, how she was absolved, how she did not need to punish herself anymore. Her shakiness surprised me, as did her desire to nuzzle into me, behaviours I had not seen from her before.

We lay like that until the candles burned low and she started to shiver.

I wanted to clean her, though I would not call for a bath now and have others intrude upon this strange calm. I felt emptier than before, though the absence of my rage did not feel like a bad thing. Instead I was filled with a surge of something sweet and intense, something that made me want to hold her forever, to do all things in her name. I did not trust myself to voice such foolish things.

In the absence of the bath I bundled her under the covers, fetching the water and cloth on shaky legs.

Slowly, methodically, I wiped away the sweat, moving softly over her welts, taking care to note the areas that were still red from the belt, pressing soft kisses after smooth wipes, soothing her as I could. Perhaps I had been too hard, though it had not seemed it at the time. I was not used to such an intensity of feeling, either, and felt relieved that she was so eager to cling to me, that she wanted to be close to me in the aftermath. Finally, she spoke.

“I,” she paused, exhaling.

“I know,” I said, softly, stroking her hair.

“I,” she tried to speak and stopped again.

“It can be..intense.”

“I did not know it could be like that,” she said finally, taking another deep breath.

“In a good way?” I did not mind asking her during our fucking what she thought, so I was not sure why I felt so small and stupid for asking after. And yet.

“I - yes. I think so.”

“Thank you,” she said, blinking and moving away from me. Not so far away that I could not hold her still, and I was further relieved.

“I - did - “ I did not know what to say. I had been so angry and now I felt empty, as though my anger was silly.

“Yes,” she blushed. “It was...good.”

“Good,” I said, with a slight smile, pulling her back. “Good.”

She tucked her head under my chin. “Do we have to join the meal?” She asked after a while, my hand still brushing strokes along her back.

“No,” I told her, sure that the whole bloody city probably knew what we had been doing. “We do not have to do anything you do not wish to.”

“We have to do some things,” she said, her voice small and girlish. It made me want to tickle her.

“No,” I said, indulging us both, trapping her under one of my legs. “The only thing we have to do is stay here. By order of the king.”

“Order of the king!” She giggled, and I pressed my face into the pillows so she might not see my smile.

“Yes. Not a foot out of bed.”

“Well,” she said, pressing a kiss to my chest. “If that is what the king wishes, then who am I to deny him.”

Chapter End Notes

warning: long author's note ahead.

medieval bdsm helloooooo! Do we have any evidence of this? Not that I'm aware of. Have people always been dirty little freaks? uh...yeah. **edit from the lovely tartarosechoes who kindly shared this blog post because OF COURSE there is evidence of this: <https://going-medieval.com/2022/06/24/on-medieval-kink-part-one/> Hooray for Eleanor Janega!**

Guys I am so bad at every-other-week uploads because I literally just forget. I'm so sorry. The whole thing is nearly drafted at this point, so once I finally finish it then we can hopefully be more regular and my brain hopefully also won't leak out my ears, which is what it currently is at risk of! Also, lol at this heavy smut dump on a Thursday morning. Whoops!

Some historical notes: I have recently discovered that chemises were a garment that came across with the Normans, isn't that interesting! Before, they were called smocks (from what I can tell, they are the exact same thing, just a different name). If I have used the word chemise in previous chapters, please disregard and substitute 'smock'. Thank you.

The mints! Cnut (the loose inspo for Draco in this) actually was a big fan of London, I think partly because of its wealth. It was the only (?) place in England which had two mints. After he became King, tribute from across England was paid totalling £72,000. £10,500 of this was from London. Cool, right!

England wasn't explicitly known yet as a centre of fine embroidery, though it is likely that there were places in the country that were already producing this. I'm referring generally to 'opus anglicanum' - literally 'english work' - which was c.12-14th centuries, though the term was coined in the 13th. If you want a book recommendation for liturgical embroidery then the V&A had an exhibition a while back, who's book you can still get I think! It is: Opus Anglicanum: Masterpieces of English Medieval Embroidery. This can give a general starting point of all the shiny things that our sweet Draco is very taken with.

Back to money briefly - I went to an interesting talk on Cnut's coinage a few weeks back that has vague relevance for this chapter. We actually have very few surviving examples of Cnut's coins, mainly because people did not bury them in hoards like they did for the previous king, Aethelred. This is because Cnut was such a good king that people spent their money instead of, as they tended to do in periods of economic insecurity, hoard it 'just in case'. Cnut's reign, allegedly, was bolstered by a sense of economic security and success. As the speaker said, he is very underrated as an eleventh century conqueror (William's Norman invasion in 1066 generally being better known). Anyway, I thought that was cool and had a weirdly misplaced sense of pride, obviously conflating the real historic person with the weird fan fiction mash up of him that I have in my head. Bad historian!!

Finally - for some reason ao3 won't let me reply to more than a handful of comments at a time so I'm REALLY behind on these. I'm sorry. I love them so much. I eat them for breakfast, gobbling your words up with a giant spoon. love you!!!

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

I was sad to leave London, though we had always planned to celebrate Yule in Winchester. Hermione, for her part, was eager to see the city she considered most like her home. We had been married for more than a month, and I knew she had not bled. Her slenderness and self-imposed punishments made me not get too hopeful, though I could not help but fuss over her as we packed up, and expressed my frustration that she wanted to ride.

“I am fine,” she muttered to me, her brow furrowed again in that way that made me want to kiss it and throw her onto the bed. She had worn her veils a little further back today, the pale winter sun reflecting on the reddish tints to her curls that frizzed up at the front. I wanted to curl them round my finger, I wanted to kiss them. I wanted Ottar to write songs and stories for her that would last an age, I wanted artists to immortalise her in paintings, manuscripts, mosaics. And then I wanted to kill them all just for looking at her so long, just for seeing the way the sun reflected in the amber tint of her eye, and how it was so different from the candlelight, just for knowing those things that only I knew.

“My lord,” she gave me a little prod, and I blinked.

“Yes.”

“Yes, we are taking the diversion because of the floods, or yes we should continue through and hope the waters have receded?”

“I -” I blinked, stupidly, aware now that Eadric had been asking me questions about the route. “What do you think,” I asked her, to cover how idiotic I was being. From her half-smile, and Eadric’s own smirk, I did not think it was so easily hidden.

“This time of year should be alright to press through, though if we return we should come the longer way. The rains usually get heavier in the first month of the year, and when the rivers are already swollen it becomes troublesome.”

“You did not need my approval at all to make that decision,” I muttered to her, as Eadric turned away, most likely to roll his eyes at my other advisors.

“No, but you did need to wipe the look off your face. It was most decidedly un-king-like.”

“There was no such thing. All my looks are King-like.”

“It certainly was not a King-like look.”

“Impossible.”

“Possible.”

“Describe it to me, and I shall decide.”

“Oh, moans about the floods but happy to use his great and mighty powers to adjudicate on this matter?”

“Exactly.”

She huffed, the corners of her lips affixed into a small smile since we had been alone.

“Well,” she said, considering. “I suppose you looked like this.”

Her eyes opened wider, a dopey smile pasted onto her face, a vacant gaze angled at mine. My wife pulled the most ridiculous thing I had ever seen, like a puppy who wishes to sleep by the fire rather than in the pens, a lovesick monstrosity that turned my stomach with its sickliness. I burst out laughing, startling a group of ravens in the tree nearby. They erupted into the sky, a black cloud, and I continued to laugh, loudly and freely as though I had no cares in the world. At that moment I felt I had not.

“I have never looked like that in my life.”

“You did,” she said, now laughing with me, as though we were old friends and there was nothing between us but - but whatever we had. “That was exactly your appearance.”

“Well,” I said, bringing her arm in and threading it through mine, resting my gloved hand atop hers, tightly and warmly swaddled. “I suppose only such a lucky King could have such a quick-thinking Queen to prevent others from seeing that monstrosity.”

“Indeed.”

“What do you require - another fortune in grain for a village? A roof for a leaking Church in some godforsaken corner of this world? A brace of eels for some hungry monks?”

She was laughing, but then quietened as we turned to watch the chaos of our people packing up our royal household. I squeezed her hands, to try to hold her attention. She was not staring off like a love-sick fool, like I had been.

“No,” she said, returning to the present. “I do not require anything, Draco.”

“Nothing,” I said, my eyebrows raised, though the humour had somehow left our conversation. I wanted it back. She sighed.

“Perhaps I would require you to arrive at our destination, not having been shot with an arrow.” I grinned again.

“But then how would you attend to me in my bath?”

She rolled her eyes, blushing.

“You have never had a problem with arranging that before.” And then before I could kiss her in front of every last person in the courtyard, she slipped from my grip and picked her way towards Mildred, who was waiting, exasperated. She turned to shoot me one more smile as she met her companion, and I knew all could see how enamoured I was with her as I watched her leave. I decided I did not care.

“My lord,” Stigand interrupted me, more brave now he was more comfortable with me. I gave a heavy sigh.

“What now.” Though he had warmed to me, I still found our lessons boring, and I was not inclined to seek his company out.

“A letter.”

“From?”

“The Pope.”

The Pope’s letter arrived with less circumstance than I had expected, only his seal, a great big enormous red welt of a thing marking it different from any other of the many letters I had since received.

“Well?”

“He congratulates you,” Stigand said. I was learning to read Latin but it was not coming naturally to me, and I did not have the patience to spend hours every day practicing my letters. Having Stigand interpret for me was growing frustrating. I wondered if I could convince my wife to spare an hour a day to teach me, and then I wondered how I might best be able to distract her away from the business of learning, and get her to ride my cock again. Or suck it. That, we had not done since our wedding night, and with her new appreciation she would be better, that much -

“What do you think?”

I grunted, startled to realise once more I had been distracted by thoughts of my wife.

“I -”

“My lord?”

Stigand regarded me slightly uneasily.

“I will confer with my wife,” I said, reaching for the letter. He held it, a little harder than he should have. “Stigand.”

“Of course, my lord.”

The young man blushed, looked down, displaying his tonsured head to me.

“What?”

“Nothing,” he said, quickly. Too quickly.

“Tell me.”

“There is nothing to tell, my Lord.”

I considered him. He was slight, but in comparison to me, most men were. He was certainly not unmuscled, and I did not want to underestimate him as a fighter, even if his hands were mostly soft and unscarred. His fear, that at least would be something on my side. I was fairly certain I could convince him to tell me anything I wanted, just using that fear. Then again, he did love to talk about martyrs. Perhaps he was hoping I would kill him.

“There is nothing,” he repeated, into the silence. His hands did not shake, though he was tucking them back into his wide sleeves. It might have been because of the cold.

“Very well.”

The letter and seal was uncomfortable and bulky, tucked against my chest. I had thought to carry them, and soon realised it would have been better to put it in my leather saddlebags. Still. I did not want rumours spreading of my correspondence with the Pope any more than I wanted people to know that I was carrying his letter as though my lover had written it to me, pressed up against my heart.

Erik rode with me that day, my wife hanging back to be surrounded by her household. She had appointed more in London during the days when I had been touring the city, and they were a mix of both our people, though mainly taken from the City itself. I had not familiarised myself with all of them, but Eadric had. He had informed me in the earlier part of the ride before again hanging back along with them, and I tried to hold my temper in check. Why did Eadric know more of my wife’s life than I did? I knew her body better than my own. I resented that while I had not been paying attention, he might have known her mind.

“Well,” Erik asked, interrupting my brooding. “Is she with child?”

“You ask, just like that?”

“Why not. I am sure we all grow tired of the half-speak.”

“You speak of my wife, like that?”

“Draco,” he rolled his eyes, I reached over and shoved him. Not hard enough, clearly, because he remained on the horse and merely laughed out loud.

“Her screams of pleasure have been echoing round the castle nightly,” he said, moving closer to me, our horses too well-acquainted to begrudge the lack of space. “And still, nothing? You are sure?”

“I am not sure,” I muttered back, still cross. “She was thin when I came here and needs to put weight on.”

“And in the meantime...” he trailed off, and I could not help but smirk a little.

“In the meantime. There is no harm in practising.”

He laughed again, always laughing these days. Erik and Thorkell had been mostly filled with good humour during our stay in London, and I realised that it was only myself and Eadric who had a

heavier brow. I knew what was causing mine - again, the thought that my wife was the cause of Eadric's foul mood once again frustrated me.

"Stop brooding -" Erik shoved me back, and I swore to the gods as I wobbled. "What could you possibly be unhappy about."

"Eadric is spending a lot of time with her," I admitted. "And Ottar. The two of them circle her constantly." This caused another hoot of laughter from Erik.

"Eadric is old enough to be her father, and more patronising than all of us put together. Ottar talks too much and flatters too fiercely. I would not worry about your young bride. She clearly only had eyes for one man."

This eased my irritation swiftly.

"You think?"

"Shall I compose a great epic about the way your wife looks at you across a room? Perhaps a bawdy tune would be more fitting, given the way you spend most of your time -"

This time, I was successful in unseating him. He was still laughing as he crashed to the ground.

The Pope's letter was a good thing, in the end, to carry with me. We arrived at Winchester late, braziers and lamps keeping the city lit, but all of us too weary to take in much. Only Hermione, and those who had been in her household before, seemed to express any real enthusiasm.

I showed it to her as I undressed, calling for a big basin to wash with, despite the late hour. I should have realised sooner that the way to get her to want me was to shower her with words and not jewels. And then I castigated myself, because getting her to want me was the last reason I bought her things - I had to ensure any companion of mine looked as though they deserved to rule, as I did.

"Read it to me," I asked.

"You don't know what it says?"

"Stigand translated. I don't trust him."

She crawled into the middle of the bed despite not washing, sitting there cross-legged in the glow before abruptly crawling back to the side, closer to the light so she might read.

She read carefully, picking out the Latin phrases that she could not translate easily, gesticulating with an energy I did not feel, though the sight of her enjoying herself so much was certainly stirring some parts of me. I drifted to my earlier fantasy of her sucking my cock as I waited for the water.

"You are not listening," she accused.

"I am."

"You are not. You are..." she drifted off disapprovingly. She knew exactly what I was thinking.

“You get excited when you translate.”

“Yes.” She stiffened, as any reminder of the life she had wanted tended to make her do.

“Come over here.”

“You wanted me to translate.”

“It all sounds fine,” I waved it off.

“Draco! It is not fine!”

“It is not,” I asked, genuinely bemused. She gave me a devastated sort of look, the kind that made me want to laugh.

“He has heard of your decision to convert!”

“I am going to convert,” I said, still mystified.

“He has invited you to ROME.”

This truly did surprise me.

“He has?”

“Did you not listen to Sitgand at all?”

I shrugged, unconcerned. “I was thinking of other things.”

That gained me a pillow to my face, which made me smile wider and give thanks to whatever God I was supposed to believe in now, that she was so comfortable with me.

“Rome! *Rome* .” The word was laden with holy mystery, despite the fact that I knew of it, and it was just a city, like any other.

“Then we will go to Rome,” I said, still not knowing what the problem was.

“We can’t,” she trailed off, abruptly.

“Why not?”

“I - I mean we can’t just go,” she said, stumbling a little. “We can’t just go to Rome, and meet the Pope. We can’t just do that. People don’t just do that.”

“I am the King of England,” I pointed out. “I can just go to Rome.”

“But what if something goes wrong here?”

“Do you want to stay, to make sure?”

“No,” she said, quickly. Then reconsidered. “Well, maybe I should.”

It was adorable to watch her war with her desire to go versus her duty to stay. “I have appointed governors for this very reason. We will not go immediately, of course. Give the people some time

to accustom themselves to my reign. But then, my sparrow, we will go to Rome.”

I was bored of the conversation, and wanted to bathe. The water was taking too long, but then I had a better idea.

“Come over here.”

“Why,” she asked, petulantly. I grinned.

“Come lick my cock clean, little wife. And if you do it well, then I will give you a library.”

Chapter End Notes

Happy Easter mooning and yearning to you all!

(fuck JK Rowling)

Latin would have been the official language for correspondence like that between kings and popes, and probably most official documents. It's difficult to know what everyone would have been speaking, but the Benedictine reforms which have resulted in many manuscripts containing Old English 'glosses' (where someone has written the OE word on top of the Latin one, or other extra-text scribbles in the margins) and the production of OE texts in general suggest that they probably do speak OE to each other. Latin was a courtly language. French becomes a courtly language with the Norman invasion in 1066, but I am fairly certain that at this point it was probably OE...?

Draco would have learnt this in addition to what he spoke before - Old Norse. However, he would have had to also learn Latin just like you or I. I think we forget that when we hear of all the languages people knew in the medieval and early modern period! Learning languages is difficult and can be very boring, no matter what century you live in.

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

I did not know why things went wrong after that. It was as though, back in her home, Hermione had remembered that she did not like me. Whatever detente we experienced before that, was gone. I reached for her as she avoided me more than ever, and in light of this I felt foolish and ignored. I did not like how clearly she favoured the place. Everyone in our household was well aware of her preference, but I could hardly voice my frustration, sounding petulant even in my own mind. Perhaps I was being oversensitive. I could not consider the city without thinking back to her earlier attempts to keep me from this place.

She left our bed early the next morning to visit the chapel, murmuring about seeing old friends as I was only half awake, slipping easily out of the chamber as though I had conjured her from my dreams and she was only half real. I slept for a little longer in her absence, unconsciously rolling to her side, finding my head on her pillow and her scent in my nose when I was eventually awoken by a stronger dawn light. I snorted to myself. This had to stop.

So did the dawn church visits. When I converted I would ensure that no one expected me to rise with the light.

Thorkell was waiting for me, a surprise. We had not spent much time together recently, or at least no time alone. But I was glad he was seeking me out, given he would be leaving shortly to return to East Anglia. Together, we walked through the palace gardens.

There was life in them, even in the frosts. Herbs and hardy plants surviving in the cold and frozen earth, tiny shoots of life. I considered a snowdrop as he spoke.

“...there have been no records, no stories, even. Not a family name, not a nearby village would claim him. It is as though he emerged from the woods.”

He spoke of the man sent to take my life. The man whose skull fragments were pressed into the road by our horses' hooves, who's brains had trailed behind our procession, whose blood I rinsed from my hands only hours later.

“Nothing?”

“No,” he said, shortly. He did not need to express his frustration for me to feel it.

“His family are being hidden? Protected?”

Thorkell exhaled heavily. “I do not know. I have questioned some. They seem honest people, *Konung* .”

This did surprise me. Not the fact that Thorkell was defending them, but that he believed them. I trusted his judgement as I trusted my own, the same for all my advisors. And if he did not think any guilty, then what did it mean?

"It would not have been difficult to know which road we would take," I said, slowly, staring at the snowdrop hard, as if it could give me answers. "They might have fled from the battle, lain in wait for us to leave. We were moving slowly."

Thorkell made an indeterminate noise.

"But why wait," I murmured, this time to myself. "Why wait for me to be armoured. Protected." I sighed. I had left, on my ill-advised ride that time and others too. I had been practically unarmed, and it would have been easy to spot me. The road leading to the coast was the same as the one that led to the city, just the other direction. If a man was driven by revenge, if a man was mad enough to attack a king and his queen - my stomach curdled at the thought again of my wife being hurt - then surely when I had been riding for the cliffs would be a better time to strike?

"I do not think he was at the battle," Thorkell said. "We have scoured the woods. There is nothing - no hint of a dwelling, or armour left. If he had been part of it then these things would be somewhere. There is no trace at all."

I wished I could remember his face. As it was, all I saw was the bloodied mass of his head whenever I pictured him. That, and the feeling of rage so great it might overtake me.

"I am sorry I do not bear better news."

"You do not need to apologise," I replied, tearing my attention from the flower, finally. I exhaled, looked him in the eye. "We must think of other things, too. Like your sister, who comes from home I hear."

This managed to bring a smile to his face, and he chuckled.

"I do not think the men of this Isle are ready for her."

I, too, laughed. Thorkell's sister was nearly as tall as he, with arms as wide as any man I had come across here. She would certainly make a fine lady, should she be able to find a man brave enough to wed her.

"Perhaps she would enjoy meeting my wife," I said. They were so different physically, though there was something of Britta's fire in Hermione. Something in the way neither seemed to back down.

"She would like that," Thorkell snorted. "Though I am sure it would end badly for us both." He clapped me on the back, and the conversation was over. We turned to walk inside, the tips of my ears starting to cool, my breath emerging in great plumes in front of me. And then, hearing the gravel crunch underneath me, he asked me a question I had not expected. "Will you see him?"

It took me a moment to realise who he was referring to. I had not thought of Edmund, of Hermione's father, since I had sent him here to rot, out of the way. I had been so wrapped up in her, in my new lands, that he had not crossed my mind.

It was a risk, keeping him alive. I should not have done it.

I thought of my wife, of how she was beginning, perhaps, to warm to me. Of the sweet kiss she gave me when we arrived in London, in the way she rode me, opened to me, took my cock in her mouth.

I could not kill him.

I exhaled, frustrated. He was close. I wondered if she would ask to see him.

“I won’t,” I said. I did not want to speak more on it.

I found my wife after the midday meal, changing in our rooms. Mildred was wrapping her legs, her hands on her thighs. I shifted in my trousers, eyeing Hermione as she warily eyed me, knowing perhaps what I was thinking. We had not spoken of it, and I knew she was far too shy to ever let another person, let alone a woman, near her cunt. Still, I enjoyed thinking about it, thinking about those quick little hands rising higher under my wife’s skirts, and what they would find there.

“Where are you going,” I asked. Mildred, wisely, made herself scarce. I liked her more every day.

“I thought I would - I would see if you wanted to go for a ride,” she stammered, blushing more aggressively without her lady to see.

“A ride,” I moved closer, taking Mildred’s place, kneeling between her legs. I pushed them open, slipping one hand underneath the dip of her gown. That explained the leg wrappings. I traced them, feeling the fine material that encased her legs, moving upwards, as I had thought Mildred might.

“What are you doing,” she said, a little breathless. I smirked, enjoying seeing her desire, her confusion. I hope she felt confused. I hope the way she wanted me made her feel as I did - panicked, unsure. Aroused.

“Checking your leg wrappings,” I replied, smoothly. “I do not want to cause you any discomfort, wife,” I told her, reaching the top of her thighs. My other hand on the outside of her gown, I pushed one leg further back, opening them further, seeking the warmth and wetness of her slit. I found it, stroking the downy hair there, pressing lightly. She gasped.

“They are secure,” she managed, as she tried not to move her hips, tried to pretend she didn’t want this.

“I didn’t make you come this morning, you slipped away too soon,” I told her. “Did you miss it? I missed feeling your cunt clench around me. I missed emptying myself into you, filling you up with my seed.”

I wanted to fuck her; I wanted her to ask me.

“My horse is being readied,” she murmured, as I continued, slowly sliding my finger in her, stretching her. “My - *oh* .”

She screwed her eyes shut, her mouth going slack.

“Should I stop,” I pushed. I wanted her to say it out loud. I felt the urgency of my desire, my need for her. She had ruined me, she had made me reckless with my want of her. I wanted her undone, too. Her breaths became choppy, like the restless sea. “Sparrow,” I said. “Should I stop.”

She still did not answer, her eyes still closed.

“Tell me,” I said, trying not to beg, failing at it. She did not answer me, turning her head instead further into the blankets, as though she could pretend it was not me, touching her like this. As though she could ignore me.

As though she did not want me.

I pulled my hand from her, standing abruptly, and ignoring her mew of surprise. I turned, so she might not see that I was stung by her actions. I did not want... I did not want any of this, I realised. I did not want this place, or these problems.

“I cannot ride today,” I told her, already making to leave. “Perhaps tomorrow.”

I could not the next day, in the end. The Archbishop of York arrived, and the place was frantic as a result. Hermione stood next to me as we prepared to greet them, her veils once more tightly wrapped, in a way I had realised was similar to the nuns that were nearby. I wanted to tug it back again, to rip it from her, to feel her hair in between my fingers as I tugged her hair back, as I watched her take my cock.

We had not fucked since London.

“He does you a great honour,” she murmured, her scent slightly different here. Different incense, she had said, in the chapel. I did not like it.

“He should,” I pointed out. “I am his king.”

“He does not always bend to the rule of kings,” she said, as I snorted.

“He will bend to mine.”

Processions snaking towards the city were visible, banners flapping in the wind and baggage carts miles long. I wondered what treasures they would bring to me, what they would ask for in return. I wondered if I would give it to him.

“My father gained his approval slowly,” she continued. “But once secured it was invaluable.”

“Yes, it certainly made him incapable of defeat.”

She stiffened even further, the gold of her circlet freezing in the weak winter light.

“He will have eternity to reap his rewards,” she murmured, not rising to my own cruelty. “That is what matters.”

I had promised to convert for her, and now I was not sure why I even bothered, still grumpy from her withdrawal from me the day before.

“May I see him,” she whispered. I do not know why she chose that moment to ask. She should have waited until I was fucking her. Except we had not, for days. And so I suppose she was forced to beg like a normal person, and I had the benefit of being able to think straight.

“No,” I replied.

“He is my father.”

“He is alive. What more do you want?”

“To see -”

“Do not ask me again. You may not see him.”

“It is all I want, I beg -”

“All you want,” I hissed, finally turning to her. “All you *want* ? I have given you more than any. I have been told, by many of my advisors, that I give you too much. And now you have the audacity to say it is not enough? When you, yourself have given me nothing in return?”

“Nothing?!” She gasped, her eyes filling with furious tears. We should not have been having this conversation out in the open.

“Nothing,” I replied, turning from her. “You are crying in front of the court,” I added, uselessly. “Stop.”

We stood in silence until the great men reached us. I wondered if she would ever speak to me again.

Chapter End Notes

Draco, a Nordic, Viking King in this, would absolutely have not used the word 'detente', which obviously comes from the French. However, I could not think of another one that so neatly did what it was supposed to do - detente meaning an easing of hostility or strained relations, often between countries at war. Sometimes I lie awake at night and think why did I not set this fifty years later, and base Draco on William the Conqueror (1066, when the Normans came and Frenchified-things. William the Conqueror, after all, also had Viking blood - allegedly).

Anyway, then I tell myself off because Viking Draco is sexy and **needed**, and if it means I need to write another, later medieval fic version of the two of them, then so be it!!

Hermione rises so early because she still sort-of keeps monastic hours. She certainly doesn't need to and wouldn't keep all of them all the time, not being a nun, after all, and being busy being the Queen. However, she definitely would be rising for Prime (the first service in the first hour of daylight), especially if she was feeling guilty guilty guilty...

Anyway, have you guys seen the art that @landbeorht has created for this? I have added it as a title image to this fic but also including a link here: [here](#)

I nearly cried!!!

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

I probably would have disliked the Archbishop under normal circumstances. His presence, after my wife was ignoring me and my cock was unattended, was unbearable.

I had taken to pacing the gardens, as though I might find some sort of solution in the tilled earth. I had contemplated taking another woman - I was not, after all, short of soft touches and glances from the many who made up our household. I had even gone so far as to follow one of the kitchen slaves out to the icehouse. It was only when she turned, a question on her lips, that I realised I could not imagine following through with it. And the fact that I could not even bring myself to fuck anyone else made me angrier at *her*. I wanted to punish her for making me feel as I did. There was no way I could without admitting my own inner turmoil.

The archbishop, a tiresome man named Wulfstan, joined me on one of these walks. He had already spoken to me of conversion, he had already lavished me with praise and gifts. I knew what he had said about us, and his attempts to win me over fell flat.

“My lord,” he said, falling into step behind me. Another one of these Churchmen my wife idolised, another one who seemed to dress in fine fabrics and enjoy all the benefits of his position. I wondered if he wore hair shirts, if he denied himself pleasure and food and drink as my wife had. I was furious for a moment, and did not answer him.

“What do you want,” I said, after a moment where I fantasised about ripping his robes from him to inspect his own ribs for marks of loathing. Given his belly protruded from him along the path, I doubted it.

He did not answer straight away.

“I have spoken with your wife,” he said, which made me stiffen. I grunted, every inch the barbarian he thought I was.

“She speaks highly of you,” he said, surprising me. “Of your intent to convert.”

“I do. Once I am king,” I replied.

“She says you have sent money already for the reconstruction of churches, for the poor who have suffered over the past several years of war.”

“I have,” I said shortly.

“Then I must thank you.”

This stopped me. He had of course made much already of my success, but this felt different. Genuine.

“I have seen leaders who care for power, I have seen leaders who care for peace. But is rare that you have a leader who cares for *people*. How they live. How they die. How they find peace in this

life and the next.”

I did not know what to say to this. It was all Hermione’s doing, after all. I did not care for any of them. But I did care for her.

“I was well-advised,” I told him. And then I returned to the training grounds, my thoughts a tangle I needed to unravel.

We rode out the next day, our guards behind us. In their presence it was awkward, and I regretted bringing them. Then again, the memory of the arrow loomed large in my mind. If she had been struck I did not know what I would have done to this place. I did not want to find out.

Hermione, for her part, was sulky and unhappy with their presence.

“Seven men?” she asked quietly, with a raise of her eyebrow. I had not asked her to ride with me, I had just told her. I was considering the possibility I had made a mistake.

“I do not know these woods,” I said. “And I am not risking you being harmed again.”

She looked away. Perhaps she, too, was still shaken by it. Then again, the sweetness with which she had tended to me would have been welcome at that point. I felt like one of the hunting dogs, begging at the table for scraps. With a sigh, I dismissed the men.

“Is that wise,” she asked, snarky.

“What do you want,” I snapped, wishing we were not on horseback so I might push her against a tree, so I might crowd her and take her. “Is it this? To be left alone, with me, in the woods? Or is it to be followed wherever we go? Please, return with them if you wish. I am only here on this ride because you have asked it of me.”

“I thought you would want to see,” she exclaimed. “I thought, considering your desire to be here, to *invade* , that you might want to explore the lands that were now yours!”

The hurt was palpable, and it hung between us. We rode forward in silence.

I did not know what to say. I was supposed to be making amends. At the least, I was supposed to be sharing what good her own requests were doing.

The birdsong was thick in the air, the woods full of creatures even in the winter. It would be good hunting, eventually. Holly was drenched in bright red berries, ancient oaks were dotted throughout. There were thick, tangling bushes filled with thorns, and though there was little green I could imagine it in summer, even denser than it was now. The narrow trails made it hard to ride abreast, and she led her way deeper into the place. The air was full of life and yet there was an eeriness to it, a barrenness to the branches that made the blood-red berries seem too lifelike, collecting in pools along the paths.

She paused when it opened up briefly to accommodate both our beasts, and I drew alongside her. I wished I had not dismissed the guards. At least then I could hide how uneasy I was in their presence.

“There is a clearing,” she spoke suddenly. “If you wish to visit.”

“I wish to return,” I said instead. I did not want to go to a fucking clearing. She stiffened.

“Very well,” she muttered. She was fidgety, her fingers twisting in her reigns. I hoped she was regretting whatever was souring between us, I hoped she was trying to make amends. She took a deep breath, squaring her shoulders.

“We can cut back through there.” Her voice wobbled. Instantly, Erik’s council echoed in my mind, so strongly it was as though he were next to me. She needed time. Her entire life had been upended, and now she was home, and I had forbidden her seeing her father.

I felt like a fool. I had been unkind. I had been unkind since we arrived in Winchester, if I was honest. I was jealous, and a fool, and I needed to fix this before I ruined it further. I sighed, dismounting and crossing to her.

“What are you doing,” she asked, as I placed my hands on her saddle, my face at her knees. I propped my chin onto one of them. Even this small intimacy calmed me.

“I am apologising,” I said. I might have laughed at her shock, if I wasn’t feeling so unhappy. “I am sorry.”

“I -” I had, momentarily, stunned her. I took the opportunity to run my hands up and down her leg, making long and soothing strokes, enjoying the feel of her muscles underneath my hands, knowing that she was stronger because of me. Because she was finally not denying her body what it needed.

“I should not have been unkind to you.”

She was quiet, before laying her hand on my head. I thought I felt it tremble as she stroked through my hair, I could have laughed for the pleasure of it. She did not say anything, she did not need to.

“Let us return,” I said hoarsely, wanting her. Wanting time with her. Wanting to make it up to her.

“Husband -” I moved quickly from her, returning to my horse. Whatever she had to say could wait. I needed her in my arms, in our rooms, first.

I mounted, and started off down the path quickly, not waiting for her now she had showed me the way. She was calling after me, but I was too eager, eager to return, to shirk my duties and instead pin her beneath me, to feel her cunt around my cock. It had been too long, and I was sure that what we needed was that, what we needed -

I did not notice the hole before it was too late, and I did not know I was falling until I heard her scream my name.

I came round a little later to find her scent enveloping me, my head in her lap. She was shaking, dabbing at my brow. I must have been bleeding.

“Draco,” she whispered. I groaned.

“My gods.”

I felt as though I had hit my head on a rock.

“You nearly did,” she said, her voice wavering, responding to words I realised I had said out loud. “You came off your horse, you nearly - it nearly -” she started to cry, her hands trying to keep my own down though without any real strength. I sat, slowly.

My horse was thrashing in the undergrowth. It was a miracle I had not been caught underneath him, a miracle that I had not, as my wife had said, hit my head on a rock. The path was littered with them, the hole - my vision swam, a little. I needed to return, and quickly. But first.

I crossed to the beast. His leg was the wrong angle, the animal clearly in pain. I did not have the strength to do it, my head pounding. Yet the horse deserved better than to be left here for hours longer, deserved more than whimpering in pain, deserved more than a foolish rider who had been so distracted by the thought of his wife’s cunt that he did not even watch where he was going.

I would get blood on the back of my wife’s gown as we rode back to the palace. I suppose it did not matter whether it was mine, or my horse’s.

Hermione shook the whole way back, her face ashen and grey, a sheen of sweat on it. She could not stop twisting to look at me behind her, as her own beast picked his way carefully back. The added weight meant we could not ride fast but I was grateful, not feeling able to bear the rocking for long. As it was, even the sensation of the creature walking underneath me made me grit my teeth in pain, and snap at my wife, again, to keep her eyes on the path.

“I am sorry, I am sorry,” she was saying, and other things, but I could not focus on the words. More of that incense clung to her robes, and it made my head hurt even more. Despite it, it was the closest we had been to one another in days. I tried to focus on that, on the pleasure of having her between my thighs again, on the ability to wrap my arms around her, even under the pretence of keeping my hands on the reins.

“Please, sparrow,” I murmured, as the castle appeared and she was still near-hysterical. “You must calm yourself. No real harm has come to me.”

My words made her weep harder.

As though they had known something would befall me, the stables and courtyard were filled with people. I was helped to dismount, to my shame, my head throbbing harder, my balance worse. Hermione was still incapable of speaking, and even after the arrow I had not seen her so hysterical. Eadric’s face swam before mine before I was whisked away, concerned and interrogating. I waved off his questions, allowed myself to be taken to our rooms instead. I wanted to lie down. There were things nagging at the edges of my consciousness, things I should have been able to untangle. Another attempt on my life? I could not tell, not until my head cleared.

It was only as I was being rushed inside that I realised Eadric had smelled like my wife, smelled like the incense in the churches. Was he converting too? Had the Archbishop finally made him see sense? The last thought I had was that I could not wait to tease him about it when I was better. And then, finally back on my bed as others were frantic around me, I slept.

Archbishop Wulfstan of York (Wulfstan II), is a famous figure in medieval history mainly for his sermon - 'Sermon of the Wolf to the English.' He is considered a major writer and also worked with Cnut, eventually, to write laws for the English. Wulfstan, who styled himself after a wolf as a play on his name, initially was anti-Viking. The extract from his sermon is right at the beginning of this fic. In it, he blames the English' own lack of moral discipline for the Viking invasions, which he saw as a punishment from God. Something to consider when bearing in mind Hermione's own difficulties with her faith and her desire... not that I'm saying any more about that...

Thank you all SO much for the response to last chapter. I got the best comment from under_umbrella that fully ignited something... I'm working on something else but I guess now we're also going to be returning to the eleventh century much sooner than I thought, to spend some time with good old Armand Malfoy...

This fic is now fully drafted!!! and I'm realllllllyyyy excited to share it with you all. hehe
xxxxx

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

“It has been hours.”

Her words were soft, as was the feeling of her hand on my head, the sensation of a cool cloth, the whispers of a veil dragging along my arm as she bent over me.

“Wife,” I murmured, and she was there, squeezing water droplets from the cloth into my mouth, quenching my thirst. I chased them, chased her lips, pulling her to me. I kissed her, sweet and soft, tasting the salt on her lips. Tears?

“You are awake,” she breathed, and I inhaled the smell of her. “You are -”

“Shush,” I told her. I did not want to hear it, did not want to think of it just now. I just wanted her. “Come to me. Forgive me,” I murmured against her mouth. “Please.”

“You are still weak - you are not -”

I chuckled against her, hollow. “I am always weak when it comes to you, wife.”

And then she was crawling onto the bed next to me, and the relief I felt at her next to me, in my arms, in my bed, made me feel as though the darkness was closing in again.

When I next woke she was not there, and I panicked.

“Here, drink.” A cup was placed against my lips, silver from the taste of it. She held it herself, and I was glad. I would not have wanted to see me tremble. “How do you feel?” She was next to me before I could rise, her small hands fluttering over my shoulders as if to press me back. “There was a lot of blood.” Her words were tense. Her whole body was.

“How long?”

“Less than a day.”

I did not think I would slip under again, and I let out a relieved exhale. My head throbbed, though I could smell something herbal and assumed she had been the one to bandage me. She hovered.

“Do you remember what happened,” she asked, crouching next to me. She touched me easily, unafraid. I thought for a blinding moment that maybe it had been worth it, if she forgave me for forbidding a visit to her father.

Thinking about the accident, though I did not want to admit it, scared me. The feeling of falling, the split second of pain before nothingness. I was scared. I was not a person who felt scared. And yet, the suspension before I hit the ground, the knowledge that something very wrong was about to

happen did not leave me. There was something terrible about the thought of it, so I tried to pull her towards me, to let me forget.

“No,” I admitted. I turned to look at her properly, taking in her wrecked face, the puffed lips and eyes, the red nose. “You have been weeping,” I said, though it sounded more like a question. She turned her head from me.

“I am so sorry.”

“Don’t be,” I told her, the sense of wrongness easing at her upset. Maybe I was right. Maybe it was worth it, to get her to want me like this. “Do not be sorry. Let me hold you.”

“There was so much blood,” she said, unable to reach my gaze, her fingers twisting and tugging the cloth between them. “Draco, there was so much blood.”

“Heads bleed,” I told her. “I am awake, I am not dead, and I have my wife by my side.”

She got up abruptly, going to the basin, and plunging her hands in, scrubbing them.

“I can still -”

“You cannot think of it,” I told her bluntly. “You cannot. It will send you insane.”

She was too kind-hearted to bear it, my little sparrow. I was glad I was still alive, if only so that I might kill all those she wished dead, if only so that I might keep her hands clean.

“Enough of this,” I said as she continued to scrub. “Please.”

It was that that made her stop, and she exhaled, bending over the bowl. A great sob, greater than her body could contain, ripped out of her, bowing her back under the weight of it. The sound was animal, feral and wild and *mine*, and I was a monster because it pleased me, chased away the worries I had, the knowledge I had displeased her, that she hated me. She splashed water over her face, and I managed to sit up in our bed, moving slowly but steadily to my feet.

I crossed to her, pulling her into my arms. Her body convulsed as she tried not to cry, as she pressed her face against my chest - I was not wearing a shirt, and she must have cut my riding clothes off me as I lay unconscious. I was glad of my strength already returning, glad I could hold her like this, feel her against me and warm her. Her nose was cold, the fire banked low in our rooms.

“Have you not let anyone tend to the fire, little one,” I murmured, rocking her. She shook her head against me. She stiffened as I bent to rub my cheek upon her veil, tried to pull away from me. “Do not run from me. Come into the bed. Let me warm you.”

“You should rest.”

“I have rested all day.”

She pulled back, frustrated at me and it made me want to laugh, happiness bubbling up within me despite the consistent ache in my skull.

“What will it take for you to lie down again?”

“You,” I said simply, and she rolled her eyes.

“Very well. Go - I will bank the fire and then join you.”

“You can not go back on this deal,” I told her, heading with relief to the mattress again. I hated injury, weakness. I did not miss the way her back stiffened as she cast on another log.

“I have a gift for you,” she said instead, straightening, absently brushing ash from her skirts, though they were already ruined. This surprised me. “The first of the feast nights is tonight,” she explained, heading towards the side, pulling from her trunk a small thing, wrapped in cloth. A ribbon had been tied around it, and she fidgeted.

“A gift?” I had not intended to sound so hoarse, but I did. I had not even thought to arrange one for her, in truth. I needed to recover quickly, if only to be able to send for one of my advisors. What might she want?

She came to the edge of our bed, and it was then I realised a stool had been drawn up next to it. By her. To sit by my side and watch over me.

I had already promised her a library. What else? She did not care for jewels, or clothes. A horse? She had several. I needed to get her something perfect.

“My lord,” she asked, and then I realised I had been frowning at the gift she was presenting to me, so occupied with thoughts of how I might please her.

“Forgive me,” I said.

“Your head -”

“It is fine,” I shook it, and then regretted that movement. “I was moved by your thoughtfulness,” I admitted. “I was not expecting a gift.”

I could not look at her as I said it, but reached instead for the package.

She had wrapped it in silk, tied with golden ribbons. I smiled at them, imagining them threaded through her hair, the silk wrapped around her body. Underneath was finer still, a box carved from a heavy, dark wood, where runes had been twisted into tree trunks and beasts stalked women running from them. I snorted softly as I took them in, running my hands over the craftsmanship. It was beautiful.

“The box is not the gift,” she said, fidgeting slightly.

“I am enjoying unwrapping it,” I said, my voice dipping low. The hem of her gown was stained with dark soil, and I let my eyes drag up over her, taking in the soft swell of her bosom that had become more pronounced recently, now that she was eating, now that she was allowing me to take care of her. Her cheeks were pink and bright as berries, the look she was giving me, reproachful.

“You are injured,” she reminded me. The blankets were tented over my arousal.

“I am,” I told her.

We stared at each other, my cock straining upwards even underneath the tossed blankets.

“I am feeling unwell,” I said. This caused her to leap up, hands fluttering over my skull.

“Where?” She demanded softly. “Where does it hurt?”

It was hard not to laugh.

“Lower, I think,” I said, making an effort to be serious.

“Lower?”

“I think I might have struck something else on my fall,” I made up. She was still so eager to heal me she did not realise what I was doing. “Lower,” I urged. “Beneath the blankets.”

She stopped, turning to regard me with an arched eyebrow.

“You are fine,” she snapped, and I did laugh then.

“I promise you, I am not.”

“Draco -”

“I am aching,” I said, because that was true. “My cock is aching for your pretty cunt, wife. Do you know how many days it has been since I filled you?”

Perhaps it was because we were not fucking that my words shocked her so much.

“Touch me,” I teased. “Take my cock in your hands.”

“You do not want my present?”

“I will open it when I am inside you.”

“You cannot,” she said, and then seemed to sober of something, physically taking a step back. “We cannot,” she repeated. “I -”

“What,” I asked, confused. “Why not?”

“It’s dangerous,” she said, her voice shaking a little. I could not keep up with the changes in her mood. I exhaled. I tried not to be churlish, considering she had once again solely attended to my side. At the same time, I wanted her.

“Will you lie next to me as I open it? I believe we made a deal.”

This, it appeared, was allowed, and she came closer to me again. Placing the box to one side for a moment, I gradually unpicked her hair pins once more, tugging up the covers even as she lay fully dressed. Her prayer book was open on the side next to her stool, her beads across the page. She curled up against my chest, her hands red and rubbed and dry, the skin around the nails cracking slightly. Underneath the herbal scent filling the rooms and clinging to her clothes, I could taste the tang of blood, of sweat.

“You did not let anyone in,” I said to her, and she shook her head against me. I suppressed a smile. “You are the queen,” I reminded her. “You cannot lock them out.”

“I am the queen,” she agreed. “And therefore I can do what I want.”

It was too much, and I started to laugh again. "It is not funny," she snapped, finally looking at me. "Do not laugh. I thought you would die."

"It will take more than that to kill me," I replied, knowing I should not taunt the gods so much but unable to resist. Technically they were no longer my gods, so what did it matter? "I do not intend to be taken from this world, especially when my wife is still cross at me."

"I do not want to speak of it," she said, trying to tuck her head against me once more. I continued untangling her hair. We were quiet for a bit. My head ached still, but I did not want to say so. I wanted to keep her against me.

"What happened," I asked softly, when I could bear to know the answer. She stiffened.

"There - there were rocks, scattered across the path," she spoke into my chest. "I did not see until it was too late. You rode off so fast - your horse tripped, the way was narrow, and then I saw you falling. I saw you falling and I screamed."

"And then?" I was sure I heard her cry out before I fell, though I did not trust my own recollections after such an injury. It was normal for them to be muddled after a head wound, and I doubted I would be able to recall the incident with any clarity.

"There was this -" she took a deep breath. "I heard your skull strike the stone. I will never forget that as long as I live."

I continued to comb my fingers through her hair, rubbing the strands together, admiring the curl that so resisted taming, that was so full of life.

"You did well to get me back to the palace."

"I was terrified you would fall again," she confessed. "I did not realise how terrified I was - I did not realise -" she broke off, taking in another jagged breath, calming herself. My heart started to race. Did she -? I did not know what I would do if she confessed she cared for me. The way my body reacted made me realise how desperately I craved it, how I needed it, needed her to want me.

"There were other healers, I remember a swarm of people. Eadric," I said suddenly. "He was there."

"I threw them all out," she told me, and I smiled. "They were crowding you and I could not get to you and I could not bear it. I did not want them near you. I needed to make you well."

"I have a very clever wife," I murmured, cradling her. "I am a lucky man."

"You are not lucky to have me," she said suddenly, pushing herself up and away from me. "You are not. Draco, I -"

"Enough," I said. "I do not want to hear more of this. I want to open your present."

She came back to lie against my side, a little reluctantly. I was the one with the head wound. I was not the one who should have been reassuring her.

I opened the box. Inside was lined with velvet. A thin razor shone in the light, its handle made of intricately carved bone. A comb made from a matching material lay next to it.

“They are carved from ivory,” she said, quietly.

I was stunned, in truth. Such an intimate gift - I did not know what to do with it.

“I know you do not let anyone at your throat,” she said quietly, running a finger across the edge of the box. “And so I thought I might be close to you in this way.”

I swallowed heavily, suddenly wishing she was not lying next to me so that I might be able to hide my emotions better.

“What were you reading?” I searched for anything to say that would not give away the raw emotion within me. It was clear she was not expecting the question, but she answered for me.

“One of the Psalms.”

“Which?”

“Fifty,” she murmured. She did not fill the silence immediately. But then she spoke. “Because of your great mercy, wipe away my sins. Wash away all my evil, and make me clean from sin.”

I ran my hand over the handle of the razor, then took it out of the box. I shifted, so we were lying next to each other instead of entangled, and handed it to her, stretching the side of my neck out.

“I would trust you at my throat,” I told her. Her eyes were huge, and I saw it in them. Fear. “I trust you, sparrow. I trust you. I know you. You need not fear.”

She made a sound I did not know how to place. Injured, animalistic. I watched her swallow, though I could not understand why.

I moved her hand to grip the razor, and there was grief in the fear, too. I brought it to my neck, laid it against the skin. Her hand was still gripped round the thing, and yet she appeared horrified that I would make such an offering. I waited, in the lamplight, for her to explain.

“There is a plot to kill you,” she murmured, not meeting my gaze, fixated instead on where the razor met my skin. “There is a plot to take your life.”

Chapter End Notes

let's GOOOOOOOOOO!

Okay lots of notes for this one! Firstly: I had the pleasure of going to a talk on cups in medieval english literature (god I love being a medievalist). The speaker basically said that they are powerful narrative devices in medieval storytelling - when a cup turns up, you know that shit is about to go DOWN. Draco obviously is given a cup to drink from at the beginning of this chapter, one which is held by Hermione, who is, in some ways, gaining more control (more on that next week). And after that talk I came back and was like IN WHICH CHAPTER MUST DRACO DRINK FROM A CUP!!

The comb and razor set!

There are a couple of things I wish to say about the comb/razor set in this, and they demonstrate a few key aspects of medieval gift giving that I would like to illuminate, if you would indulge me. . Firstly: combs by themselves generally are more associated with women than men. This is very clear from the 12thC, when combs are listed as an ideal gift to give a lover. However, I think there are roots of this association from *at least* furnished burial in the 7thC.

Combs in inhumations between 5-7thC are found in much larger numbers in female-sexed graves. When they are found in male graves it is possible that they were gifts *from women*. There is more I can say and probably shouldn't yet because it is my literal research lol but basically what I'm trying to say is: The comb in the grave as a gift is a way to demonstrate connection to the dead person, who was a person of power. It acts as a proxy of their (the woman, the dead man)'s relationship and demonstrates to the survivors that this person, because of their relationship to the deceased, is ALSO important.

Medieval gifts are often used as proxy objects. In Hermione and Draco's time there is increasing limitations on women's access to religious spaces. The 11thC eventually sees the breakdown of clerical marriage and the restriction of where they can go in churches. One way women try to circumnavigate this is actually to put work that they have commissioned (altar cloths, priestly vestments etc) in these spaces that they themselves cannot go in.

SO: the gifts are Hermione's way of placing herself in this position of power - literally at his throat, during a very intimate moment (the razor obvs being able to like...kill you). And while I don't know of any examples in stories of combs and razors being given to men, I do know that the relationship between intimacy and combs and grooming implements, AND the understanding that objects could easily represent a person, were all common and accepted things in the medieval period. So while this might not be cut-and-dry accurate, it still has lots of little accurate bits and bobs in terms of the medieval worldview.

If you want more on women commissioning religious clothing then Maureen Miller's Clothing the Clergy is just fantastic. And if you want more on combs and gifts and women then...TBD on that.

OH GOD I also want to talk about [Psalm 50!](#) (sometimes Psalm 51). This is a beautiful, heartbreaking psalm, where David begs for forgiveness. My favourite setting for this is on the [playlist!](#), which I keep forgetting to plug. I had the fortune of seeing it in a MS I was studying and the scribe had written that particular one out over and over again, which was very moving. More on my [tumblr](#) if you want because I need to end this essay!

Love to you all!!

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

“There is a plot to take your life.”

I reached up automatically, moving her hand from me. She did not fight it. And I -

I -

I breathed. Continued to live. Could not understand what, or how, or when, or where or *who* .

We were frozen, both of us. She continued to stare at my neck. Her wrist was in my grasp, the razor drooping.

“Who,” I whispered. What I wanted to know, was how did *she* know. What did *she* know about this. “Has Thorkell been -”

“It is not Thorkell,” she said, louder than perhaps she had meant to, because even the sound of her own voice made her jump.

“Then who,” I asked. I had to ask. She still did not meet my gaze.

“Eadric,” she said, as I was about to question again. The name was a sigh, a lance into my chest. “Eadric wishes to replace you as King.”

There was something sitting on my chest, preventing me from taking full breaths.

“The - forest,” I asked, trying, wishing to get my mind to work better. “He knew?”

“Yes,” she confessed, the word broken. “He knew. He arranged it - the rocks, the pit. Everything - he arranged it all.” Her voice shook, though she did not cry. I could not -

I could not believe it.

“You smelt the same,” I said, dazed. “You -”

She moved away from me.

“You smelt the same,” I repeated. I knew, and yet I did not. I could not. I could not bear it, could not understand it. “You smelled the same - the incense, the - you -”

For a moment it all hung in the air. The unspoken. The unknown. The sweet ignorance that I wished I could cling to.

And then it broke.

“Yes,” she said. I was glad I had moved the razor away. Her hand was shaking so much she would have slit my throat by accident. “Yes. I knew.”

How strange, to be so betrayed. My body felt the truth of her words, and yet my mind could not grasp them. Could not see what she had so clearly done.

“You plotted,” I said, waiting for her to deny it still.

“I -”

We were close to each other, and yet I was watching them from a great distance, as though my body was elsewhere. Detached.

“You plotted to kill me.”

She seemed to weigh her next words for a long time. Maybe it was a long time, maybe it was just moments. I could not tell.

“I did.”

The rage came, then. The anger. No, the *fury*. At her. At my wife - my wife who had wanted to end my life. I laughed at her, cold and empty.

“Well, little wife,” I said, watching her flinch at my tone. “You have me, do you not?” I brought her hand back to my neck, still grasping the razor. “Do it.”

“What,” she gasped.

“Do it,” I snapped, holding it tighter against me. The blade was at an angle. All it needed was for her to twist her wrist, to turn it ever so slightly, and it would run red. “DO IT!” I bellowed.

She was trying to pull away from me, though her strength was no match for mine. Did I truly want to die? I could not tell. The tearing in my chest certainly felt as though I was.

“Stop,” she was saying. “Please.”

“Is this not what you wanted?”

“I did not think -”

“Is this not what you plotted? For months, have you not wanted to kill me?”

“I do not -”

“I do not know why you did not act before,” I snarled. “You had plenty of opportunity to, after all. All those times I was fucking you, you could have -”

“Stop!”

I had never heard her scream like that. I released her, and she tumbled backwards, the razor clattering over the floor. I sat up, she was sprawled across the floor, both of us panting though we had not run anywhere. I could not look at her.

“You will not plot and get some vermin to carry it out against me,” I told her, staring into the corner of the room. “You will look me in the eyes as you end my life. You will see me bleed out, your hands will be red as mine were when I defended *your* life. You will not stab me in the back. If you are to kill me, wife, that is what I ask. What I demand. You will look me in the eyes as you betray me.”

“I will not kill you,” she said, each word bitter and short. “I. Can. Not. Kill. You.”

“You should have realised that before.”

Did she know what she had done? Even as she professed her inability to end my life, what did it matter? I had discovered that she had acted towards it, had plotted to bring it about. Who cared if she was unsuccessful? I had been betrayed by my own wife.

“Coward,” I whispered. “Coward.”

“Coward!” She cried, finally wrenching herself from the floor. “How dare you.” I could not tell what she was feeling - her own emotions a whirl of anger and weeping and fear. “I am not a coward. I am not afraid!”

“THEN WHY DO YOU NOT,” I shouted, shifting away from her, standing from the bed. “Why? Is it because you wish me to live with the knowledge -”

“Enough!”

She had drawn herself up, and even reeking of betrayal, she still looked like a queen.

“Enough,” she said. And then she spoke.

“You took everything from me,” she began. “You took everything - my life, my dreams, my future. You ripped it from me. Everything I had ever feared - you made it come true. You filled my days with horror and my nights with pleasure. I did not - I could *not feel*, and you stole it from me, all of it. I wanted to be a nun. I was called - I had heard the calling of the Lord and I was meant to serve him, not you and your...your...your desires. Not your kingdom, not your future, but mine.

“And do you know what it is like? Do you know what it is like to be nothing in this world, to have nothing? To be a woman? To be powerless? I was meant to have something of my own and even that, I knew, would be at the service of others but this? I am beholden to you, *always* to you, even when you are not there. Even when you are halfway across the world I would still be beholden to you, now. You have ruined me. I can never again know a life without the things you have shown me and never again feel the things you have made me feel. And how dare you! How dare you destroy so fully that I cannot even want the things I used to want! You have forbidden me my father, you have forbidden me my power. You made me powerless, made me crawl to you, beg for you.”

“You wanted -”

“That is the point!” She cried, tears coming, then being banished quickly with angry swipes of her hand. “That is the point! I cannot know another day without the feel of you and in return I must give up everything. My independence, my studies. My *family*. They are gone and will never return. Everything. That is what you took from me. Everything.”

“And what did you think would happen,” I sneered. “What did you promise Eadric in return -”

“*He* promised *me*,” she said, firmly. “*He* plotted against you. He promised me that I could return, that I could have my father, that he would rule and I once again could -”

I broke her off with a laugh, wanting to hurt, to twist, to injure.

“He lied,” I said. The man I had known my whole life, who had been more my father than my own sire. “He lied. He would have taken you and fucked you. You think I have robbed you? He would use you, and every other woman here if he wished. He would truly give you nothing. You would exist to be fucked and used and beaten if you did not bring him pleasure. He would care nothing of yours. Is that what you want? To be raped, day after day, night after night until you gave him a son, and discarded like chattel?”

“You do not know -”

“I know!” I shouted. “Do you not think I *know*? Do you not think I know of the ways women speak of him? Or the ways he celebrates after a great victory? Do you not think I know what he *does*, what he *likes*?”

She was silent.

“You are a fool. You are a stupid fool. And you deserve, both of you, to die for it.”

“Then do it,” she said finally. “Do it. Kill me, instead. Why not? Why bother keeping me if you -”

“Because I am in love with you!”

I had not meant to speak the words. But I had, and I could not take them back. She stepped back, her face slack, as though I had slapped her.

“I also - I cannot - because I -”

“Do not even speak it,” I spat. “Do not dare.”

“I do not lie -”

“You have. You have done nothing but lie, and scheme. And I will not hear another word.”

“Then -”

“Get out.”

“Dra-”

“GET OUT.”

I did not want to be near her any more. I could not process what she had told me, could not understand the depths of her resentment against me, and I could not bear to think of the reasoning underneath it all. Erik had warned me of the dangers of becoming too close to her, of not giving her enough time, and I felt foolish for even wanting her to want me. Foolish and useless and powerless, too. She complained of having nothing, what did she know?

“I have nowhere to go,” she said. Even her words were steady. I could not even trust her impassioned words, because what if they were more lies? “My rooms have not been made up. Not since Assundun.”

I had demanded that. I had forced her to share my space from the beginning. I had told myself it was because I needed to keep an eye on her and in reality it was because I was in love with her. I had not even kept an eye, clearly, if she had been capable of plotting along with my advisors.

“I do not care,” I said. I did not want her to go. I wanted her to stay, I wanted her to not have plotted to end my fucking life, I wanted to have not told her that I loved her, to think that maybe she felt the same, as twisted and awful as it was. “I do not care.”

I did care. I could not kill her.

I needed for her to leave. And when she did, I only wanted her back.

Chapter End Notes

eeeeeee.

Not much historical to say...but thank you all for your comments last chapter!! I loved seeing what people thought was going to happen...<3

xxxx

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

I did not sleep. I paced, up and down. I thought of her words. I thought of mine. I broke her prayer beads, scattering them across the room, ripped the parchment from her book. She had been asking for forgiveness before I woke. For what? Plotting to kill me? Or failing to follow through? Why had she not slit my neck when I offered it to her? Because she had not known how she might get away with it?

As much as I wanted to trust her words, I couldn't. There was no reason why she would kill me in our bed, not if *she* wanted to live. And that was the whole point, was it not? She thought I stole her future from her. She did not want a life with me. She would rather risk her soul to end mine. She would rather suffer eternal torment than endure a life by my side.

I thought I had calmed when the sky began to lighten. Perhaps fittingly, there were no rays of sunlight. There was no piercing dawn to clear my thoughts. There was just a gradual gray emergence of the new day, and with it, no clear way forward.

I opened our bedroom door to find her, curled up in the antechamber attached. The guard was standing near her but not touching, and she was bleary and huddled under a cloak - one of mine, fetched from elsewhere. I was stopped short by the image, furious once more.

"Eadric has been arrested," she said, rubbing at her eyes. "I thought I ought to send word."

Fuck. I had been so fucking stupid. In my rage and my betrayal I had not even thought to imprison the very man at the centre of all of this.

The guard hovered, awkward.

"Go. Sleep." I told her, jerking my head towards our chamber. The chaos was evident even through the cracked door. Belongings strewn across the floors, destroyed manuscripts, dresses of hers. She would have heard me rage all night. "I will visit him now."

The guard shrank into the wall as I passed. "Call for Godwin," I snapped at him, "Tell him to meet me in the gaol."

I did not want to see any of my advisors. The only man I could even think to trust was one of the English, and the realisation of that made my rage reignite. How far did it go? Who was involved? I, truthfully, had no appetite for this kind of kingship. For a moment I thought to call for the Archbishop, before I cast that idea aside. There was no God of mine that could hear me now. And Hermione's was of no comfort, for all His connection to her. For a moment I was stopped short by it, the adrift. The same feeling when falling into the sea, as you are yanked by the current. I had everything I had ever wanted, and yet nothing and no one at all.

I reached the gaol before Godwin, and so I had the pleasure of taking in the beaten and stinking form of my former, closest advisor, alone.

I was pleased to see he had been hurt. I was also pleased to see that he had pissed himself in the process. That, or someone had pissed on him.

He opened his eyes - bloodshot, tired - and laughed at me. It was a slow, wheezing sort of laugh, the one a man makes when he has nothing left. It stuck in my mind.

“So,” I said, settling myself against the stone wall. Eadric looked to sit up, though he soon gave this attempt up, collapsing further in on himself. Broken ribs, surely. I watched, and waited.

“I underestimated your wife,” he said.

“So did I,” I snarled. He huffed again, I did not find it funny.

“What do you want.”

“Truth,” I replied.

“You sound like them.” The sneer was obvious - Eadric did not like the new religion. Was that enough to plot against me? I was impassive as I watched him squint at me through swollen and bloodshot eyes, yet inside the fracturing that had begun last night continued. I had been so distracted by thoughts of my wife’s betrayal that I had not contemplated what Eadric’s meant.

“What will you do with me, then,” he asked, wearily, though he was putting effort into making the words feel airy and light.

“I don’t know,” I replied. That was also a lie. I knew. He knew, too. I would kill him for his betrayal. I did not know, however, how I was supposed to stand it. Eadric laughed, softly.

“It was worth it.”

“Really?” I asked, before I could stop myself. “Was it really worth your life?”

“It would have been, had your wife not been useless.”

I hated her and we were not speaking and still, the rage which came over me was sudden and violent. I was next to him in a flash, pulling him up heavily, making him cry out in pain. His body I pushed into the wall, scraping the wounds on his skull anew.

“Do not speak of her,” I said, close enough to feel his hot, rank breath skate over me, close enough to smell the blood and piss and fear underneath it all. “You do not get to speak of her.”

“She tried to kill you, and you still protect her,” he wheezed.

“Did she,” I asked, because that, in truth, was what I needed to know. “What did you promise her?”

“Why should I tell you,” he sneered. I released him, and stepped back. I needed distance from him, needed to be far enough away so that he could not see the hurt. He knew he would die. But he knew there was one more way to hurt me. And that moment I realised that Eadric might never tell me the truth, and I would be tortured by his silence for the rest of my life.

I returned to my rooms afterwards without remembering that I had sent Hermione in to sleep. I just moved without thought, pushed and pulled to be close to her by habit. My clothes were stinking and bloodstained. Godric had met me down there, and Eadric had not spoken one more word to either of us, even as he cried out in pain. I was weary, it was not enough.

She was sleeping when I returned, and the sight of her body huddled under blankets made my jaw clench and my chest ease. There was no bath yet, so I dropped into the chair, removing my garments as I watched her slumber.

Her eyes flickered open, I suppose I had not made much effort to be quiet. We both stared at each other, as though we were seeing one another for the first time. At least, that was how I felt.

"In London you were glad I had not died," I said, my voice hoarse. "I was shot then. You attended me personally. You could have easily let the wound fester."

"I know," she said.

"Did you lie?"

"No."

I exhaled and stood. The bath was drawn in. Maybe the news had already spread through the castle, because the serving girls moved quickly, as though they were terrified of me.

I undressed, dropping into the water. She watched me from bed, but even her presence could not stop me from tipping my head back against the rim, breathing out as the warm water moved over me. She was holding her knees against her chest, her hair messy and swarming around her.

"I did not lie."

"Can you not see why I am confused," I bit out. "You save my life, you plot to kill me. How am I to know the truth."

"I was angry," she said softly. "All I had to do was take you out to ride. That was all. And I would have everything I wanted. My father, my peace."

"Everything you wanted," I said flatly. The words stung. "And what does your God think of this."

It seemed I had asked the one question she did not want to answer.

"I was to be Judith," she muttered, eventually. My rage was ignited again.

"And who the fuck is Judith!" I roared, splashing water over the side. "Who is Judith, Hermione?"

"You see!" She exclaimed, as though she had won a great victory. "You say you wish to convert but you do not even listen!"

"So she is in the Bible? You justified killing me, all because of a *story* ?!" I could not believe it.

"She - it. It is complicated," she said, backtracking perhaps as I said the words out loud and she heard how hollow they were. "She was - it was permitted under the circumstances."

“What circumstances were those,” I replied, each word clipped and ugly.

“Holofernes was invading. She was protecting her people.”

I just stared at her. And then I turned away.

I washed myself in silence, methodically. I knew I had the castle to explain to, I knew I had to tell people the truth. I did not even know what that was. I did not know what to do, and I wanted my wife’s council. That is, the council my wife would have given me, had she not also been embroiled with the scheme. I still could not truly believe that she had been. I still did not know how deeply she had plotted.

It was when I stood that I realised she had been staring at me the entire time. Warily, hungrily, a little bit of both. I turned to face her.

I did not know her or trust her. When her eyes landed on my cock, I forgot to care.

“And how did Judith kill this Holofernes,” I asked, coldly.

“She came to his tent, late at night,” she said after a moment, my cock thickening under her gaze. I raised an eyebrow. “She...”

“She what, sparrow,” I asked. “Did she fuck him?”

“No,” Hermione said, her eyes on me. I took my cock in hand, pumped it once.

“What a shame,” I murmured. “Then I suppose you, too, do not want to be fucked. Do not want to be reminded of how good it is when I stretch that tight little cunt. You do not want to feel yourself shake around me.”

Her breaths were already coming faster, eyes a little glazed.

“You wanted to give this up,” I said. She flinched at my words. I was glad that they hurt her.

“I di-”

I ripped the bed sheets away, grasping one angle and tugging her towards me, so quickly she cried out in surprise. Manoeuvring her in front of me onto her hands and knees, I tore her shift, exposing her backside. And without even testing to see if she was ready, I pulled her back onto my cock.

She screamed around me, as I started to thrust into her as hard as I could. I did not want to be gentle. I was not even sure if I wanted to make her come. I just wanted to remind her, to show her. To make her lose her mind.

“You wanted to give this up,” I said again. “So you better enjoy this,” I told her, fucking her hard into the mattress. “Because it will be the last time you get to feel me. If this is what you want. If you want to give this up. I will fuck a child into you right now and after he is born you will be free to leave. You can leave it all.”

I was speaking and fucking her so strongly I did not even realise at first that she was begging. Crying. Scrabbling at the sheets and begging me not to stop. Not now, not ever.

I grabbed the back of her neck, resting my knees on the bed and pulling her up against me, where I encircled her, her ear close to my mouth as I fucked her with her back pressed against my front.

“Is that not what you want,” I asked heavily, biting down on her shoulder, tightening my grip on her neck. I licked her throat, tasting her sweat. “Is that not what you always wanted. In your great abbey, all alone. This cunt empty. I bet I will have stretched you out so much that even when you slide your fingers inside yourself, when you’re all alone in that little nunnery and desperate to be filled, it still won’t feel enough. You’ll still be empty and craving my cock.”

“Please,” she cried. “Please.”

“Say it,”

“I can’t.”

“It’s what you want.”

“I want you,” she shook, and I realised she really was crying. “Please, Draco. I choose you. Please.”

I slowed, catching my breath, holding her even tighter against me. She continued to beg me to listen to her, that she wanted me, that she wanted this. I did not know how I could believe her, did not know how I would let her go if that was what she wanted, not when her cunt was so slick and warm around me, not when even the mere thought of getting her pregnant made my balls tighten. I did not know how it had happened, but the tenor of us fucking changed. I flexed once, wrapping my arms around her whole body, burying my head in the crook of her hair as she cried.

“I am sorry,” she was almost chanting it, praying to me rather than her God. “I am sorry. I was so scared. I was so scared.”

“Of what,” I managed, my voice hoarse.

“Of losing you, of not being able to live without you. Of feeling like this. Of wanting you. Of giving up my dreams. Of never seeing my father again. Of all of it.”

Perhaps I was being a fool. It would not be the first time she had managed to wrap me round her finger. Perhaps I just wanted to believe her so badly I was letting myself be manipulated once more. But it felt true to me. I kissed up where I had bitten on her neck, still inside her, still moving slowly. She turned her face towards me, and then my lips were on hers, my tongue in her mouth.

I moved her off me, settling her underneath me, sliding inside her and unbreaking the kiss. She had looped her arms around my shoulders, pulling me to her, her legs wrapped naturally around my waist, as though we had always fucked like this. We did not speak, though I unwrapped one of her arms and guided it to her pearl. Whatever rage I had felt mere moments before was gone. I wanted to watch my wife come. I wanted to forgive her.

She tasted like the salt of her tears and I pressed kisses all across her face, covering her as best I could, kissing away the proof of her betrayal, silently forgiving her, asking her to forgive me. Her breaths came quicker and I realised with a jolt of surprise that I would come, too. That we both would. And as she shuddered around me I buried my head in her neck again and filled her as I said I would. And when it was over, when we lay in each other's arms, my softening cock still inside her, I did not think I would lose her.

Chapter End Notes

Eeeeh I'm bored in the library and have an absolute mountain of work to get through. Have a Thursday chapter!

Shout out to @forsara who correctly picked up on the Judith/Holofernes reference!!!! There is a great article about the 10th century retelling of the Judith and Holofernes, which waters down Judith's own actions to make her more appropriate for a religious audience. The actual Biblical Judith, who is permitted much more agency than this medieval version, was Hermione's main inspiration for this, or the weak link in the chain that allowed her to be manipulated into agreeing to this.

article is Mary Clayton, "Aelfric's "Judith": manipulative or manipulated," *Anglo-Saxon England*, 1994, Vol. 23 (1994), pp. 215-227.

Aelfric, in his Letter to Sigeward, also says however that his retelling: '...is also set down in English in our manner, as an example to you people that you should defend your land against the invading army with weapons.' I've taken it to suggest that Hermione very much understood that acting in this manner would have been spiritually permitted in this instance.

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

We lay together for a long time. I found myself smoothing her hair, running my hand along her back. Touching her, always. Staring at each other, as though we really were newlyweds who had met under kinder circumstances.

“I do not think I realised what might happen,” she said, quietly. Confessing. “I did not - it was all so sudden. The return to Winchester, the letter from the Pope, you suddenly - a barbarian,” I snorted, “receiving the highest honour, an honour I myself longed for. My father, close but not close enough. I saw the collapse of my old life and the beginning of my new and in my fear I tried to hold onto something that was already - it was already gone,” she said, her voice cracking. “I did not realise until I watched you fall. I grieved those things deeply. But I couldn’t make my way back to something that was already lost.”

I think she said these things to soothe me, but I still felt the sting of rejection.

“I do not know how we ended up here,” I told her truthfully. “I do not - I was as confused as you about my feelings,” I said. I turned to face the ceiling, despite our intimacies, embarrassed to be voicing them out loud. “I was not expecting it, but it happened and I was glad of it. And then for you to fight so hard against it -”

“It is wrong to feel like this,” she interrupted gently. “At least, that is what I was taught. That is what I thought. Any desire I had experienced was - I was not supposed to give into it. And then you made me,” she said. “And I was terrified.”

Her fingertips drew circles on my chest.

I did not reply. I believed her. But I did not know what to say.

“Eadric will die,” I said. “I will kill him.”

“I know,” she said, quietly.

“Who else knows you worked with him,” I said after a moment. “Will you be accused?” Word of her betrayal could not escape. It would ruin her, not to mention weaken me. My threat to send her away might even become true, if it were common knowledge. Hermione stiffened in my arms, perhaps reading my unspoken thoughts.

“No one,” she said. “Except my father.”

My arms tensed.

“Eadric told me my father was working with him,” she said, feeling the tension roll off me. “I think - I do not know. He might have said it to get me to acquiesce. I do not know what is true anymore.”

I sat up, away from her. I knew she had seen me as a beast, barbarian, as she had said. I knew I had behaved like it in front of her. I exhaled as I knew the truth.

If my wife's father had conspired against me, then I was going to kill him too.

We went to visit him the next day, surrounded by a full escort. The castle was filled with rumours, Eadric still mouldering in his cell. The trial would happen soon, though it was obvious which way it would go, it acting more to flush out any remaining supporters of this plot. I had not wanted to leave him, lest he manage to escape, lest his supporters used my absence against me. But it was necessary, and I trusted Godric enough, at least, to keep control as I visited the monastery I had imprisoned Edmund in. Hermione came with me, I knew better than to ask her to stay. Besides. She deserved to hear the truth.

It was hardly imprisonment, in truth. The man lived in simple luxury, the monastery well-heated. He was surrounded by books when we found him, scraping carefully away at a manuscript under an enormous window. I watched him and Hermione greet each other, both of them holding back their emotions. The clouds were dark and heavy outside, it would snow soon. Unlike the noise of the castle, here all was still. I missed it, but Hermione seemed at peace. I stared at the way the candlelight licked against her, picking out the soft gold trim on her cloak and covered head. Was this what I had taken from her?

Her eyes kept glancing to the page her father was copying, he was speaking in a warm tone of the difficulty of the work, the meditative nature of it. He did not sound like a king, he sounded like an artist. A man. I dismissed the guards who came with me with a glance. The door to the scriptorium closed, the candle guttered. And I waited.

Hermione and Edmund appeared uneasy, then. She was flickering, her hands wanting to fuss over him I could tell, her own desires to be dutiful to her father warring with what she knew I would ask.

Edmund straightened in his chair. He was older than when I had last seen him, as though it had been years and not months. He met my gaze. And then he turned away.

"Is it true," I asked, softly. Hermione swallowed.

"I do not know what you speak of."

"Father," she said. "Please. Speak truthfully."

"Of what?"

"Of the plot to kill me," I said. I felt my temper rise, that beating in my breast starting to hammer. It would not do to lose control here, though I wanted already to direct my strength somewhere. To crack and squeeze. The image of my wife, strung up underneath me flashed through my mind. I exhaled through my nose.

"I - I did not know of any plot," he stammered. Nervous. Because of guilt, or just fear? My nostrils flared again. I glanced at my wife, who was looking down at her father, her short breaths the only indication of her anxiety.

"Have you conspired, father," she said softly. "Please. Tell me truly - did Eadric ever write or send word?"

“Eadric?” He said, his eyes widening innocently. “That is who?”

He appeared shocked, but there was something about the picture that was not right to me. Some long buried instinct was awakening. We questioned him longer, yet he continued to deny it. I could tell my wife was being convinced, and I wanted to be, too. I wanted this to be true so I would not have to look at her and know I had to kill her father. But it seemed too - too something.

We left not an hour later, saddling up in the courtyard. None of the monks made eye contact with either me or my wife. Hermione did not ask to visit the church or pray. I kept glancing at her, she was deep in thought, barely looking as she mounted her horse, the little furrow between her brow.

“What is it,” I asked, quietly. The whole place was quiet, as though it were holding its breath. There was a hostility to it that I did not like, and as we bid our farewells and rode out through the gates, I glanced to my guards. They were close, closer than usual, and clearly felt it too. Our horses were tense and unpredictable, and more than one of them tossed their heads, angrily. I tried to exhale, but could not.

“It is nothing,” she told me, but I could tell she was not sure she was right.

We had ridden for a while in silence before her head whipped round and she brought her horse to a sudden halt. The movement sent shockwaves through our group, as tightly together as we were. Instantly I was by her side, my sword drawn, my hackles raised. My horse seemed eager to fight, too, to be able to direct some of its uneasiness towards something. The clattering of weapons, of hooves on the road, of strategic calls as we bristled around her, filled the air.

“We need to go back,” she said, looking at me. Her face was blanched of colour, her lips as white as her skin, the red rim of her eyes the only other shade.

“What is it,” I urged. “If it is dangerous -”

“He lied,” she said, her voice breaking slightly. “He lied.”

“Hermione,” I softened, moving as close as I could get to her, though still not close enough. She was exhausted, she was stressed. “He promised you.”

I did not trust him, but I did not also want my wife on a whim to believe her father was capable of endangering them both in that way.

“No,” she said, gripping my hand. “I know this sounds wrong but - Draco - I recognised the drawings.” Her voice had dipped low, I did not know what she was talking about.

“What -”

“The manuscript - the piece he was working on?” She was restless, turning her horse back. My men were looking for answers to me, and yet we all followed her as she immediately struck up a trot.

“Hermione - do not run back when -”

“The manuscript could not have been created by my father’s hand, Draco,” she shouted, her words reaching me over the wind. She was driving the pace harder, her words more difficult to pick out over the noise of the wind. I urged my beast forwards, drawing level with her. I had not ridden this hard since I had come off my horse, and I tried not to think of that as I clenched my teeth.

“What do you mean,” I asked, half shouting it across to her.

“My father had scribes, he did not write himself,” she shouted back at me. “He has been in the monastery for a few months - not enough time to reach that level of skill. And Matthew’s face - it is the same style as a copy I saw from Canterbury!”

“What are you saying?”

We were travelling even faster now, she bent over the saddle, urging us all on.

“He is lying,” she said, choking on the words. “He is lying and the entire place is lying. They are all against you. All of them.”

They had not been expecting our return, though it seemed miraculous they had not heard the thundering of our hooves as we rode back to them. Hermione’s own veils were nearly ripped from her head with the speed she was travelling, bent over the saddle, close to her horse’s neck. I was alarmed by the intensity of her gaze, by how she shook while holding on. Not from physical weakness, but emotion.

She was forced to choose again, between me and her father. I closed my heart to the guilt.

We dropped off our horses, and I grabbed her arm at the last minute, holding her.

“We must plan,” I said, as gently as I could despite my heaving breaths. “We cannot just -”

“Hermione?” Her father was walking out to us, eyes widening. “Child, what is it?”

“Go inside -” I started to say. But she interrupted me, her voice shaking.

“We are here to arrest you for conspiring to kill the King.”

Chapter End Notes

I'm a really bad historian because I've lost my whole note on manuscript production centres, so this is going to go off what I remember and be un-cited :)

Anyway, manuscripts at this time, especially religious ones, would have been produced pretty much entirely by religious communities - monks and nuns. I like to think Hermione fantasised about doing this sort of work herself. These MS could have been commissioned, sent around, borrowed, visited, and ideas about style, and training also for the scribes, would have travelled. We know that manuscripts (MSS) often have convoluted histories that involve them being sent all over the place, and many medieval MS that survive today do so in bits, where various single texts have been stuck together. When you work with MS you have to spend ages working out which text came when and all that stuff - I hate it, personally, because I am *not detail orientated*. (see, aforementioned lost note).

SO! Even if you see all the funny looking animals online, creating them involved a lot of skill and was very hard! It's kind of dumb that Hermione and Draco didn't realise this as *soon* as Edmund was 'working' on one, but they have been distracted, I suppose. Also, it was pretty

normal for multiple people to have worked on a single MS at one time. You definitely would have had different people work on the illuminations (pictures), vs the text. So we can give them a pass. We can also give them a pass for narrative reasons, because nothing gets in the way of silly fun more than historical accuracy....right...

I initially had Old Sarum listed as the place Hermione had seen the other MS - I was *sure* I read something about Anglo-Saxon MS production there, but now I can't find it. So I've changed it to Canterbury. I swear everything I ever look at, at some point, has turned up in Canterbury. If you like medieval history they've got loads of it.

Clearly, what everyone fancies after a big dramatic 'traitor!!' reveal, is a long note on medieval manuscripts :))) Have lovely weeks!!!

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

Hermione insisted on seeing her father as he was placed into the cell. More comfortable than Eadric's, though God knew he did not deserve it. We returned to our rooms, wading through the rumours that were swarming wildly. I had a strong feeling that Ottar was behind some of them, and determined to speak with him the following day. I already knew what he would say: I was being portrayed as a strong leader, so what did it matter? Fighting off dastardly plots to end my life was the sign of a good king. Thankfully Hermione's name was left out, though plenty of others were included. My head still ached, especially so now, in light of both what I knew, and the experience of riding so hard, so soon after the accident.

I knew it was important to get back on a horse after a fall. I had never had any troubles before. And though I had done it, I had not liked how nerve wracking it had been to gallop so fiercely towards the monastery, had not liked the presence of my wife so close to me when I was scared of falling again. I was glad we were not to move from Winchester for a while, and would stay at least through twelfth night, still some days ahead. And I hated that I was glad - I felt weak, womanly. It left a bad taste in my mouth.

We both undressed on our sides of the bed, and I was halfway through removing my clothes when I realised how familiar we were acting together. Had I decided, then? To forgive her?

I watched her shrug out of her gown, her brow furrowed still, as it had been all day. Lines around her mouth appeared deeper, especially in the low light of the banked fire and the flickering candles. She was tired, I noted. Worn down. I thought of our wedding night, of her defiance, of her delicious capitulation to pleasure. She was occupied by other things, her eyes far off and glassy. It was as silent as the castle ever appeared to be, and I felt a prickle of guilt not just to her but to my men, who had their feast time overshadowed by further uncertainty. I resolved then that I could not extend this until after the winter celebrations. It would probably be bad luck to kill a man during Yule. It might be more dangerous to let the two of them fester.

"Your father cannot live." I let her hear me, watching her blink into presence, pulled back from wherever she had vanished to. "Eadric must die. And your father cannot remain, also."

Lips that had been pursed so thinly they had nearly vanished opened, then closed again. Opened once more.

"I know." A whisper. I bowed my head.

"I do not want to do this," I told her, the two of us still separated by the great wooden sea between us. "I am sorry."

"You wish for my permission?" Her voice was cracked and harsh and soft all at once.

"I ask your forgiveness. But it must be done."

She turned away.

“I know he has done wrong and he - I know. But I cannot say that -”

As she started to weep I could not bear the distance. I crossed the mattress, pulling her into my arms. And when she was within them it was as though something was released and she wept, openly against me, her tears dampening my chest. We stood together for a long time, my head bowed over hers, my hand holding the back of her neck.

“It will be over soon,” I told her eventually. “I will not make you wait. Either of you.”

“I do not deserve this,” she said. “I do not - you should include me, Draco. You should kill me.”

“I will not.”

“I am guilty.”

“Of what? Wanting? Fighting for something? If you are guilty then so am I.”

“You are making allowances for me because -”

“Yes,” I agreed easily. “Of course I am. You are my wife. You will still be my wife. You will be queen of England. But you will always be mine, first.”

I suddenly did not care that she had tried to kill me. I was glad that I had seen it, the extent of her ambition, glad that I had someone as fearsome as I was by my side.

“You will always fight for what you want,” I told her, my grip tightening almost without my knowledge, my cock thickening slightly at the thought of it. “That is why I love you. I was wrong to call you sparrow,” I told her, as we both breathed a little harder. “You are a lioness instead.”

“It scares me,” she said.

“The wanting?”

She nodded.

“The power?”

“Yes.”

“The desire?”

“Yes.”

“I want it too,” I told her. “I want all you want. To win. To succeed. The power, and all it brings with it.”

“You told me once,” she said, unsteadily as I dipped my head to her neck. “That you would teach me. Pleasure, and power. The two of them.”

“Yes,” I agreed. “I did.” She smelled musky from the day, her skin warm under my nose. I breathed her in deeply. “I want to see how much you want,” I admitted. “I want to know all that you desire. I

want to watch you disembowel it at my feet.”

“I would have killed you because of it.”

“I know,” I said, my cock fully hardening. “You did not. But you wanted to. Do you know how badly I want you for it?”

She gasped as I pressed into her.

“Is this -”

“Wrong?” I guessed. “There are no wrongs between us, though, my little lioness.” I ground against her harder, her eyes fluttering. “Look at me. There are no wrongs between us. Here, in this room. You belong to me, and I you. And together we will build something no man or woman will ever bring down, do you understand?”

“Yes,” she gasped, as I ran my hands down her front, catching her pebbled nipples underneath my fingers and twisting through the fine material of her smock. “I want you,” she said.

“You and me,” I promised, as I pushed her towards the bed. “I am going to build you an empire.” She lay back, letting me kiss her, deeply, opening her legs underneath me almost lazily. Her scent wafted upwards, and I groaned into her mouth. “That is why,” I said, almost panting myself. “Because your cunt is so fucking hot and wet, and I can watch you scream underneath me one moment and then build a kingdom the next.”

She was writhing against me, her smock riding up between us as she undulated, moving slightly frantically as I continued to grind against her. My trousers were still on, we both fumbled, pushing them down, her hand catching around my cock. I nearly came.

“Put me inside you,” I urged, and she did, leading me to her centre, so hot and wet and perfect. I pushed in, the two of us moaning as I felt her stretch around me. “Fuck,” I said, flexing inside her.

“I want it,” she said. “All of it. I want an empire with you.”

“You are going to be Queen not just of this country,” I promised her. “The world. I will give you this world. And I will conquer heaven and give that to you, too.” I was too far gone to care about blasphemy. “You are going to rule by my side, every day. And every night, I am going to own this tight little cunt,” she cried out as I thrust deeper. “I am going to pump you so full of my seed that it will run out of you as you sit on your throne. I am going to give you the world and cover you in jewels and build a thousand scriptoria in your name. And you are going to take my cock, like the perfect little wife you are.” She started to shake, snaking one hand between us to press on her pearl. “Yes. Feel your pleasure, know that this is yours, too,” I urged, watching her screw up her eyes no longer out of hesitation but of desire. “Take all of it.”

“I want it,” she said, her mouth open. “I want your cock. I want your heirs. I want to give you sons that will rule forever in your name.” Her words were my undoing. I came, suddenly, blotting out my vision. It was so forceful, my only sensation her, as she clenched and shook around me.

Finally I returned to the living. The final hesitation between us seemed to have broken, and neither of us moved, remaining entangled, sweat-stained and out of breath, my arms around her. We kissed, touched, all those things that usually did not last as hesitation crept in again, though this time there was none. I saw for the first time my wife unrestrained, and could not stop my joy, even with the

shadow of what I must do hanging over us. I slept like that, her pressed against me, her curls spreading across my pillow, my head bowed over us.

The following day I found myself bracing for her coldness, as had become custom, expecting to find her already risen and in church. But she was still there, nose pressed into my collarbone, body ensuring my arm was numb and deprived of feeling. I stretched my fingers experimentally, and realised as she began to stir that my headache had also gone.

She nuzzled into me, and it was suddenly familiar to kiss her and run my hands over her body.

“Good morning,” she said softly, as I pawed at her, enjoying the feel of her breast in my hand, fantasising about them growing heavier when my child was in her belly. She hummed in lazy pleasure, and for the first time I offered up a silent prayer of thanks to this new God. He had brought me my wife, it seemed, and for that I would be grateful.

“Good morning,” I replied, dipping my head again to breathe her in, unable to resist her. Soft kisses were pressed into her skin, my tongue darting out as I made my way down her body, licking and sucking the sweat from the night before. Divine liquor, I was drunk on the scent and taste of her. Her smock was tugged off, her cunt displayed to me, open and glistening, her curls pressed against her thighs. She smelled like the two of us, tasted like it, too, as I bent my head to gently lap at her. She gasped, the room was filled with the small and soft sounds of her moans in the early morning, as gentle as the grey dawn.

I should have been in a rush for many things but I was not. Her hands scrabbled into the bed linens and I reached for her wrists, pressing them down. Her body relaxed under me as my tongue delved into her, lapping at her. There was something soft about it despite my hunger for her, something sweet like the taste of her. Her orgasm was like that, too, gentle and shuddering and lazy, and when I pulled her onto my cock afterwards I was in no rush, content to slowly pulse inside of her as our bodies were pressed against each other, finding my own release as I kissed her deeply, letting her lick the taste of herself off my mouth and beard. I hid us under sheets as I called for water to wash and let the slaves light fires, hiding her from sight, the two of us giggling like real lovers did, and when we were left alone again I washed her as diligently as I had fucked her, cupping her cunt to keep my seed inside.

“I will be unable to ride,” she said, still hazy.

“Where do you need to go,” I asked, unable to take my hands off her, insisting on dressing her, watching her responses as I pulled up stockings and on new smocks, dresses, robes, veils, layers of fine cloth that I would remove later with the greatest of pleasure. “I will carry you there myself.”

She snorted softly, readjusting her head coverings so they fell a little further back, just the edge of her hairline visible, the gold circlet holding them in place.

“I love the way gold looks upon your skin,” I murmured, tracing the circlet with the tip of my finger. “I thought I preferred silver. Now I know it was only because I had not seen you covered in gold.”

“I do not care,” she said, the frown line back, and the ghost of an eye-roll threatening. “You know there are things more important than these. You still owe me many churches, after all.”

I grinned at her. "Of course I remember."

"And a library."

"And a library," I said, trying to appear solemn, and failing. "I would not break my word."

"Good," she sniffed, standing and fluffing out the robes, fussing over the way they hung. "What -"

"We must try them," I said. "They must face judgment, first. I will not sentence without a trial." She stiffened, then nodded, once. We both knew that it was no more than formality. The two of them would be dead before the week was out.

"Very well. Let us break our fasts first, and then I must pray."

"I will come with you."

"To Church?" She could not hide her surprise. I shrugged, suddenly a little bashful.

"I said I would convert, did I not?"

"I did not realise you still - that after -"

"Yes," I said, taking her hand and tucking it into my arm. I knew one day perhaps we would be able to talk openly about it, and felt secure that such a day was not far off. But I did not want to spend too long thinking about the way my wife had betrayed me, even if her reasons I understood and, in many ways, respected.

"Thank you," she said, abruptly stopping to look at me, her eyes dark and serious. "Thank you."

"Thank you," I replied, bringing the back of her hand to my lips and kissing it softly. We went down, speaking no more about such things and not needing to, for our quiet joy was apparent to all those who looked upon us. Something I had not realised, some tension or some sorcery seemed to dissipate in the face of it, the castle letting out a collective sigh of relief. The sun broke through the clouds as we ate, the first time in days, letting the ice-coated bare branches in our gardens sparkle.

Chapter End Notes

one more chapter left *weeps*

Vikings looooved silver, much moreso than gold. There are lots of hoards in Scandinavia etc that are full of silver coins - many of which are from the Islamic caliphates! Dr Jane Kershaw at Oxford does lots of work on this - here's a very brief [blog post](#) if you're interested in learning more about her work! Changing your favourite metal because the other suits your wife better is peak simp viking Draco behaviour.

Not Viking related but I also uploaded a very extremely silly Crookshanks POV, after having the idea noodle around my head for like two years at this point. Mwah!

Meditations on mice and men

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

I normally upload on Sundays but I have a big weekend coming up so :')

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

We were to gather in the open air for the executions. Overall, five men were charged with the conspiracy, and it seemed true that others, even if they did not want me there, would at least keep their discontent to themselves. There was much feasting and drinking to be done, and though the winter would be long I knew that this show of force now would pay off in the long run.

I had decided that the four others would be killed by someone else, their bodies dumped over the side of the castle.

I would execute Hermione's father myself.

The mail-coat was passed over my head. I wore the plain version, the one I wore to fight. I did not want the metal rings spun with golden thread, though I kept my hair uncovered and placed my crown upon my head anyway, lest anyone mistake me for a normal soldier. It fitted tightly, despite the lack of fighting I had somehow put on weight, my arms straining at the sides. I raised them experimentally, relieved that I could still move them. I would need to, need to wield the great broadsword that I did not often carry. It was almost as large and long as I, its edge gleaming in the dim winter sun as I inspected it, turning the blade this way and that.

We were silent, Erik and Thorkell and I. I knew they had little left to say, having spoken with me already of their sadness, their disappointment, their sorrow. I did not know how I felt. I was still furious at Eadric for his silence. He had still not spoken of the extent of his plans, and I would have to appease myself with the fact that I would never know. But he did not seem the same man as the one who had been by my side for years, his betrayal colouring his appearance, or perhaps unveiling the true man underneath - one rotten and pointed and red with anger and rage and a deep, burning jealousy. I was glad to be rid of that man, to cut out the growth from my court. I did not regret having him killed.

I only regretted Edmund's death because of my wife, though I knew I had been lucky, actually, in the circumstances. Keeping him alive was a risk I should not have taken in the first place, and I could not lie to myself and say his betrayal was not a convenient way to be rid of him. Hermione's sorrow would soften in time. She understood, perhaps more than I had given credit to her in the first place.

It was an honour he did not deserve, to be killed by my own hand. I did it for her.

They were there, handcuffed, huddled, shivering. They had been given no cloak, and though I knew Eadric would want to face his death like a warrior he was shaking hard in the frigid weather. I tried not to smirk.

There was a great crowd, everyone who could slip away from their duties naturally doing so, peering from room windows when there was no space on the ground, the nobles who were visiting for the Christmas feast gathered uneasily at the front, staring at the man who had been their king, defeated in battle and now, useless and shivering, awaiting his own death. The air stank of expectation and fear, expectation from the household, a kind of gleeful anticipation of the bloodshed, a bowstring taught throughout their hearts. And fear, from those who were in power before, from those who realised now that I would take no quarter and would not hesitate, not even to kill one of my own men, not even to cut down the father of the woman I loved.

It had been a while since I had felt strong. The lack of fighting, then the feelings for my wife, the fall. It was a relief to return to myself, to take up the space that was mine, to breathe deeply and feel my muscles bunch as I carried the great sword, to stare at each of the men in the face as they trembled before me.

Edmund was last on the line. He was grey, tired. Scared. But he met my gaze, as he had all those months ago, defeated once again.

“Come forward,” I said. “Kneel.”

His eyes widened in surprise, clearly he had not been expecting it.

“You?”

I nodded, once. He took a deep breath and walked, one foot in front of the other. He paused slightly and swallowed, though by the working of his throat it was dry. Death hovered between us.

“Thank you,” he said, quick and quiet. “Look after her.”

I nodded, once. He sank to his knees, closed his eyes.

“May God forgive me.”

His words were a sigh, carried over the wind. I swung the sword, holding it high above my head. There was no breath, no wind, no birdsong for that moment.

I let the blade’s own gravity bring it down, slicing through air, then bone. Edmund’s head rolled, the blood seeping into the earth. The spell was broken, the crowd cried out. I turned, blood splattered on my legs, breathing fast, as though the crest of the wave had broken and time was now rushing to catch up with itself.

My wife was stood, front and centre. Her arms were crossed in front of her, hands buried in her fur-lined sleeves. The silver embroidery on her red cloak made her appear some winter goddess, though I knew the comparison would displease her. Her white cheeks were stained red with cold, the tip of her nose matching the cape, the coverings on her head stark white and coloured with stitching, gold and silver woven bands at the edges falling round her like waterfall, sparse curls springing from her hairline, unseen before by all except me. The great golden circlet rested lightly on her brow, a cut rock crystal refracting the winter light, a kiss of frost upon her forehead. We took

each other in. She did not cry. I nodded to her. She tipped her chin, holding my gaze. I saw what I needed without hearing her voice. It was done.

I returned to her side, not touching her with my stained clothes and hands, and together we watched the rest of the men meet their end. We waited, standing, staring, as their bodies were collected in a wheelbarrow, heaved on top of the other.

Edmund was the only one who was piled separately, taken away in the opposite direction. He would be buried in the churchyard. She would see him again.

“What did he say to you,” she said, quietly.

“He thanked me,” I told her, my voice hoarse from lack of use. “Asked for forgiveness from God, and for me to look after you.”

I felt, rather than saw, her nod.

“Good.”

I was suddenly tired.

“Come with me,” she asked. “Just for a moment.”

We would be missed, but only briefly. I had been keeping my distance out of respect for her father, but she reached for me, threading her hand through the crook of my elbow, keeping me next to her. We turned into the private gardens right in the centre of the palace, hidden away from all except the Queen and her household.

There was a brackish covering of old ivy in one corner, behind it, an ancient carved bench. She pulled me down, we sat side by side, her hand entwining with mine. I breathed, she breathed.

“I used to sit here when I was a child,” she said suddenly. “It was always peaceful here, especially in summer when the ivy grows in even thicker and muffles the outside world. It was the only place in the castle that was truly quiet.”

My lips twitched despite themselves, imagining her so serious.

“It is restful,” I agreed, resting back against the wall. “The bench?”

“I don’t know. Older than all of us, older than our memories. Likely those who came before,” she removed one hand to trace some mottled carving. “Gods I do not recognise.”

“I do not either,” I said, failing to pick out anything despite the faded and crumpled face of a woman.

“It has lasted, though,” she said, her fingers playing over the stone. “Lasted beyond memory.”

My lips twitched again.

“You have an idea,” I said. She huffed a laugh.

“Perhaps. A great church in stone. Buildings in stone. Like the ancients did. We know little of them but their stories, their world - it survives even if they do not.”

“You are thinking of the future,” I said. She smiled at me, eyes glinting.

“I am.”

My heart sped, though I was not sure why.

“To build - in stone?”

“Yes.”

“If you want,” I shrugged. It would be expensive and costly, we would likely have to bring experts in from the continent, though I was sure it would not be too much effort -

“Your son will need to inherit something sturdy,” she said, interrupting my thoughts. “Great empires cannot be built in wood.”

I stared at her. Her laugh was birdsong, bright peals.

“Yes.”

“No.”

“Yes,” she urged, clutching my hand tighter. “It is true.”

I did not know what to say. So much - there was so much. Overwhelmed. My throat tightened, I bowed over her, shaking, clutching.

“Do not lie to me.”

“I tell the truth.”

I laughed then, too, great big whoops of it, joyful and dancing, scooping her into me, the two of us clutching one another.

“It is true,” I said, feeling her nod against me.

“It is true.”

“Well.”

That evening Ottar was on fine form, already spinning tales of my valiant wins against treacherous and fantastical foes. Hermione and I sat side by side, and I was forced to not reach out and touch her stomach. It was early, she said. There was still much risk. Only her and Matilda knew the truth, though I did not think it would stay secret for long. Not when I was so excited, so attentive to her, hovering protectively over every mouthful, forcing more food onto her plate.

The hall was full of smoke and music and laughter, the chanting of singing, even Stigand looking hale, cheeks flushed with wine and pleasure. Hermione followed my gaze as I looked around us, reaching over to twist her fingers in my hand.

“May I tell you now,” she said, quietly into my ear. It took me a moment to understand what she asked.

“Yes. Tell me now,” I said, turning towards her, our lips nearly touching.

“I love you,” she said, a smile growing to touch her flushed cheeks.

“And I, you.”

I kissed her before our past, as she promised me our future.

Chapter End Notes

Enormous thank you to bremonster for beta-ing this, and to Tobi Ann, aka the dramione effect, for reading all my unhinged emails. Another giant thank you to midnighttomoscow, who literally kicked this whole thing off by being born. Now we get to exist alongside beautiful marauders AUs AND smutty viking dramione, so thank you <3 <3 <3

Most importantly - thank you all for reading. This fic deserves to be at least 40k longer, and you all deserve to be in an even bigger, more fleshed out world. However. I have gone on several “personal journeys” in the writing of this, and one of them has absolutely been around perfectionism and responsibility. As a supposed expert in medieval history, I feel an enormous amount of responsibility in replicating the past faithfully. As someone in the process of finishing their thesis, I have had to really try and get a handle on this idea that my fun smutty hobby has to be PERFECT. And so, this fic must come to an end here.

The much more interesting personal response has been in relation to the limitations of female power in the 11thC. I try to write every version of Hermione from a feminist perspective. And even if she doesn't *start* very strong (ie, nowhere else to go), at least by the end of the fic she becomes strong.

However. This fic is in the 11thC, and in the 11thC...that can't happen. I'll be the first to admit this is historically accurate vibes over historically accurate events, but even with that we can't suddenly come full circle and have Hermione get everything she wanted. She *has* to capitulate to something. For a HEA, Hermione has to submit to Draco. Her own ambitions can never be fully realised.

This is because even by the 11thC, Hermione's ambitions - to be a powerful abbess or even female bishop herself - are already far-fetched. By the 11thC men are working actively to exclude women from the church even further than they already were excluded. She cannot hold the kind of power she wants to have without the influence, or the appearance of influence, of a man. Her greatest opportunity for future power is also pretty much only tied to her ability to reproduce. Her 'best case scenario', I guess, would be for her son to inherit the

crown too young, and she gets to rule in his stead until he grows up. And even THEN, she has to hand over power to him when he becomes a man.

This fic is a Draco POV, but she absolutely is the most interesting character in this. Figuring out ways to try and demonstrate that internal struggle, through the lens of her idiotic husband who is just staring at her with goo-goo eyes has been so, so fun.

Anyway. In other end notes: Cnut did kill Eadric in 1017, for being a traitor. This was apparently well-received (was described as ‘very justly’), though we don’t know how Eadric was killed. We do know that he wouldn’t have been buried properly (aka deviant burials) - the fact that Edmund is, is a big deal and a great mercy. Traitors would have been either executed or hung. I didn’t bother going into the trial because SNOOZE, but there would have been one. Vikings were pretty big on trials and things. And I chose that Draco did some executing in this for the drama, and also because he’s had several chapters of being a moody sad boy and I thought he deserved to hold a sword again :)

In very UNhistorical notes: Hermione and not the Norman Conquest brings building in stone to England LMAO. This was taking place on the continent at this time, and is popularised post-1066 in England.

A very brief reading list for anyone interested in pursuing anything further:

Books:

John Blair, Building Anglo-Saxon England.

Maureen Miller, Clothing and the Clergy.

Richard North, Erin Goeres and Alison Finaly (eds), Anglo-Danish Empire: a companion to the reign of King Cnut the Great (especially chapters 1, 8, 9 and 10).

Andrew Reynolds, Anglo-Saxon Deviant Burial Customs

Articles:

Clare A Lees and Gillian R. Overing, “The Clerics and the Critics: Misogyny and the Social Symbolic in Anglo-Saxon England,” in Gender in Debate from the Early Middle Ages to the Renaissance.

Keith Ruiter and Steven P. Ashby. “Different Strokes: Judicial Violence in Viking-Age England and Scandinavia.” Viking and Medieval Scandinavia 14 (2018): 153–84.

Mary Clayton, “Ælfric’s Judith: Manipulative or Manipulated?” Anglo-Saxon England, vol. 23, 1994, pp. 215–27.

That’s all from me, folks. A very silly and fluffy marriage fic is coming next <3

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